

28 DEVOTIONALS ON HEBREWS

# Eyes Fixed on Jesus

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## How to use this booklet

1. Set aside about 15 to 20 minutes for each day, ideally somewhere quiet.
2. Read the Scripture passage first, slowly – aloud, if you can. It stands at the start of each devotional.
3. "Digging Deeper" takes you into the context and the language of the original text. "Living It Out" asks what it means for you.
4. Take your time with the questions. You may want to write your answers down.
5. Close with the prayer – and with your own words.

**Eyes Fixed on Jesus**
28 devotionals on Hebrews

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Read online: https://hannesnortje.github.io/devotionals/hebr/en/

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The whole of Hebrews

DAY 1

# The Final Word: Christ, the Radiance of God's Glory

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 1:1–4**

[1] In many parts and in many ways God spoke in the past to the fathers
through the prophets; [2] at the end of these days he has spoken to us
through the Son. Him he appointed heir of everything, and through
him he also made the worlds. [3] He is the radiance of his glory and the
very stamp of his being, and he carries all things by the powerful word.
When he himself had made purification for sins, he took his seat at the
right hand of the Majesty on high, [4] and so he has become as much bet-
ter than the angels as the name he has inherited is superior to theirs.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Today we begin a journey of twenty-eight days through the letter to the Hebrews, in which we will explore the unrivalled greatness of Christ and the earnest call to persevere.

The letter to the Hebrews is one of the most masterful theological documents in the New Testament. Unlike Paul's letters, it does not open with a traditional greeting or with the name of its author. It launches straight in, like a powerful sermon speaking directly to the heart of a persecuted and discouraged congregation. The first readers were Jewish Christians (perhaps in or near Rome, cf. 13:24) who were under enormous social and physical pressure. While Judaism enjoyed Roman protection as a recognised religion (what was later called a *religio licita*), Christianity was in-

creasingly seen as a suspect new sect. These believers were therefore tempted to return to the safe, visible rituals of the Old Testament temple service, the priesthood and the law of Moses.

The author's purpose is simple but vital: to draw back the curtain of heaven and show them that **Jesus Christ is infinitely better, greater and more exalted** than anything the old order could offer. To turn back to the shadows when full sunlight has already dawned would be spiritual suicide. In the Greek text, verses 1 to 4 form a single, breathtaking, poetic sentence that sets out the majesty of Christ in seven colossal truths.

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us dig into the riches of the original Greek terms in this opening:

- **"In many parts and in many ways" (*polymerōs kai polytropōs* – πολυμερῶς καὶ πολυτρόπως, v. 1):** The author opens with a beautiful Greek alliteration: in the past God spoke *polymerōs* ("in many parts", "many times") and *polytropōs* ("in many ways") – through dreams, visions, burning bushes, laws and prophecies. No single Old Testament prophet had the whole picture; each held one piece of the puzzle. But *"at the end of these days"* (the messianic age that dawned with the coming of Jesus) God no longer speaks merely through messengers. He speaks *in Son* (the Greek literally has *en huiō* – ἐν υἱῷ, without the article).
- **"The worlds" (*aiōnas* – αἰῶνας, v. 2):** Christ has been appointed *"heir of everything"*. Everything that exists flows from him and moves back towards him. More than that, it was through him that God *"made the worlds"*. The Greek word here, *aiōnas*, does not mean only the physical globe (*kosmos* – κόσμος), but the "ages": time, space, matter and history itself.
- **"The radiance" (*apaugasma* – ἀπαύγασμα, v. 3):** *Apaugasma* means the radiance or reflection of light. Just as you cannot separate the sun from its rays, and just as we can only see and experience the sun through the

rays that reach the earth, so Christ is the visible radiance of God's invisible glory. He does not merely reflect God's light as the moon reflects the sun; he radiates God's own glory.

- **"The very stamp of his being" (*charaktēr tēs hypostaseōs* – χαρακτὴρ τῆς ὑποστάσεως, v. 3):** The word for "stamp" is *charaktēr* (from which we get our word "character"). In the ancient world it referred to the exact impression a signet ring makes in warm wax, or the image struck on a coin. The impression in the wax shows every finest line and detail of the original seal. Christ is the exact expression of God's being (*hypostasis*: his deepest reality and nature).
- **"He carries all things" (*pherōn* – φέρων, v. 3):** Jesus *"carries all things by the powerful word"*. The Greek participle *pherōn* is not a passive word, like the mythological Atlas balancing a dead weight on his shoulders. It is a dynamic, active word: to carry something forward towards a destination.
- **"Purification" (*katharismon* – καθαρισμόν, v. 3):** From the cosmic creation the author suddenly moves to our personal salvation: *"When he himself had made purification for sins, he took his seat at the right hand of the Majesty on high."* In the Old Testament tabernacle and temple there were splendid furnishings: the altar of burnt offering, the lampstand, the table with the bread of the Presence. But there was **no chair**. Why? Because the human priests' work was never finished. Day after day they had to stand and offer sacrifices. But when Jesus had offered his own blood, he *sat down*.

### CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **God spoke step by step, and Christ is his final Word.** Jesus does not merely bring a message from God; **he is God's final, perfect Message.**
2. **Christ is heir and creator of the universe.** The one who hung on a Roman cross is the same one who created the galaxies and the ages of history.

3. **Christ reveals God completely.** He radiates God's glory because he himself is God. To look at Jesus' compassion, holiness and truth is to look straight into the Father's heart.
4. **Christ sustains everything and steers it to its goal.** He does not only hold the atoms of the universe together at this moment so that it does not collapse into chaos; he is actively steering the whole of history towards God's ultimate purpose.
5. **The purification is finished, and the King is seated.** The work of redemption is complete once and for all, and he now sits in the place of highest authority, at the right hand of the Majesty.

## Living It Out

When life becomes overwhelming and our plans fall apart, our spiritual sight often narrows to tunnel vision. Like the first readers of Hebrews, we are tempted to fall back on what we can see, feel and control: our own efforts, our religious duties, or worldly security. We grow tired of trusting an invisible God.

Hebrews 1:1–4 heals our spiritual short-sightedness by lifting our eyes to the greatness of Christ. If Jesus really created the *aiōnas* (the ages and the universe) and is *actively carrying* everything at this very moment by the powerful word, then your life is not out of control. The uncertainty about your future, your family, your health or your finances is not too heavy for the one who sustains galaxies by his mere word.

What is more, you no longer need to "scurry around" spiritually like an Old Testament priest trying to win God's favour. Jesus is *seated*. When guilt or old failures accuse you and tell you that you must first do "enough" for God again before you may come to him, this passage reminds you that the purification of your sins has already been completed by him himself. We rest in his finished work.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Where are you looking for a "new word"?** Do you often look for signs, feelings or human opinions to find peace, while God has already given his final, clearest Word in his Son and in Scripture?
- **Which part of your life feels as if it is falling apart today?** How does your anxiety change when you realise that Christ not only created the universe, but is actively *carrying* (*pherōn*) your life by the powerful word?
- **Are you still standing, or are you seated with Christ?** Are you still trying to pay for your sins through your own performance or religious dutifulness – or do you truly rest in the fact that Jesus has already sat down after making your purification?

## Prayer

> *Heavenly Father, today I bow before you in deep wonder. Thank you that you did not leave me in the dark to guess who you are or what your heart is like. Thank you that at the end of these days you have spoken to me through your Son, Jesus Christ.*
>
> *Lord Jesus, forgive me that I so often make you small in my thoughts while I make my problems and fears so big. You are the radiance of God's glory and the very stamp of his being. Through you the universe and the ages were made, and by the power of your one word you are carrying all things at this moment – including my life, my breath and my future.*
>
> *Thank you that on the cross you yourself made full purification for my sins, and that you are now seated at the right hand of the Majesty. Teach my soul today to stop toiling to earn your favour, and help me to become still and rest in your finished work. Open my eyes on this journey through Hebrews to see you greater, brighter and mightier than ever before. Amen.*

DAY 2

# Exalted above the Angels: The Eternal King and Ministering Spirits

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 1:5–14**

5 For to which of the angels did he ever say:

You are my Son;
today I have fathered you?
And again:
I will be a father to him,
and he will be a son to me?

6 And when he again brings the firstborn into the world, he says:

And let all God's angels worship him.

7 With regard to the angels he says:

He makes his angels winds,
and his ministers a flame of fire.

8 But with regard to the Son:

Your throne, O God, stands for ever and ever,
and the sceptre of uprightness is the sceptre of your kingdom.
9 You have loved righteousness and hated lawlessness;
therefore God, your God, has anointed you
with the oil of rejoicing beyond your partners.

10 And:

In the beginning, Lord, you laid the foundation of the earth,
and the heavens are the works of your hands.
11 They will perish, but you remain;
they will all wear out like a garment,
12 and like a cloak you will roll them up;
like a garment they will also be changed.
But you are the same,
and your years will never come to an end.

13 But to which of the angels has he ever said:

Sit at my right hand

until I make your enemies
a footstool for your feet?

[14] Are they not all ministering spirits, sent out to serve for the sake of those who are going to inherit salvation?

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

### HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

To modern readers it may sound strange that the author of Hebrews devotes a whole chapter to proving that Jesus is greater than the angels. We are rarely tempted to exalt angels above Christ. But in the Jewish world of the first century – especially in certain mystical and apocalyptic movements such as the Qumran community – angels played an enormous role. Jewish tradition held that the law of Moses was given on Mount Sinai through the mediation of angels (cf. Deuteronomy 33:2; Acts 7:53; Galatians 3:19). Angels were seen as the dazzling, awe-inspiring messengers and go-betweens between a holy God and a sinful humanity. Some writings from Qumran even give the archangel Michael a leading role in God's final victory.

So to convince his readers that the new covenant in Christ is infinitely better than the old covenant of Moses, the author had to show that the mediator of the new covenant is far above the heavenly messengers of the old. He does it in a typically Jewish way: by threading together a *charaz* (חרז, a "string of pearls") of seven Old Testament quotations from the Greek Septuagint. With each pearl from the Psalms, Deuteronomy and Samuel he builds an irrefutable case.

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us explore the theological and linguistic depths of this comparison:

- **"The firstborn" (*prōtotokon* – πρωτότοκον, vv. 5–6):** The author quotes Psalm 2:7 and 2 Samuel 7:14, two classic messianic royal texts. In the Old Testament angels are sometimes collectively called "sons of God" (e.g. Job 1:6) because God created them, but to no single angel did God ever say: "*You are my Son*". The phrase "*today I have fathered you*" does not refer in the New Testament to a point at which Jesus was created (he is eternal, after all), but to his public vindication and enthronement as the risen Messiah-King (cf. Acts 13:33; Romans 1:4). In verse 6 Jesus is called "*the firstborn*" (*prōtotokos*). In ancient culture and in biblical Greek, *prōtotokos* refers primarily to **rank, authority and the right of inheritance**, not merely to origin in time (just as David is called "firstborn" in Psalm 89:27, although he was the youngest son of Jesse). The quotation in verse 6 comes from Deuteronomy 32:43 as it reads in the Septuagint (cf. Psalm 97:7); the line is missing from the Hebrew text of Deuteronomy 32.
- **"Let them worship him" (*proskynēsatōsan* – προσκυνησάτωσαν, v. 6):** The proof of Jesus' divine rank lies in the command to the angels: they must *worship* him. In Jewish monotheism only God himself may be worshipped.
- **"Winds" (*pneumata* – πνεύματα, v. 7) and "O God" (*ho theos* – ὁ θεός, v. 8):** Here we meet a sharp contrast (from Psalm 104:4 and Psalm 45:6–7). Angels are changeable and subordinate; God makes his angels "winds" and his ministers "*a flame of fire*" to carry out his orders at lightning speed. They are created instruments. But when the Father speaks to the Son, he addresses him directly as God: "*Your throne, O God (ho theos), stands for ever and ever.*"
- **"Lawlessness" (*anomian* – ἀνομίαν, v. 9):** The Son has "loved righteousness and hated lawlessness". The psalm goes on to speak of his anointing "with the oil of rejoicing beyond your partners".
- **"Cloak" (*peribolaion* – περιβόλαιον) and "the same" (*ho autos* – ὁ αὐτός, vv. 10–12):** Next the author applies Psalm 102:25–27 – a passage that in the Hebrew Old Testament speaks directly of the LORD (YHWH)

– to Jesus without hesitation. At the end of history Christ will roll up the present cosmos like an old cloak and replace it with a new heaven and earth. But in the midst of a universe that grows old and changes, Jesus stands firm: "*But you are the same (ho autos), and your years will never come to an end.*"

- **"Ministering spirits" (*leitourgika pneumata* – λειτουργικὰ πνεύματα, vv. 13–14):** The chapter's climax reaches back to Psalm 110:1 (the Old Testament verse most often quoted in the New Testament). No angel was ever told to come and sit at God's right hand. The ancient image of enemies as a "footstool" goes back to the practice of a victorious king placing his foot on the neck of his defeated enemy as a sign of total subjection. What then is the angels' true position? Verse 14 calls them *leitourgika pneumata*: "liturgical" or "*ministering spirits*". They are heaven's support staff!

### CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The Son is unique.** No angel was ever addressed as Son. The Son receives the worship of the angels – something due to God alone.
2. **The Son is God.** "*Your throne, O God, stands for ever and ever*" is one of the most powerful and direct declarations of Christ's full deity in all of Scripture. While the angels serve, the Son reigns with "*the sceptre of uprightness*". His kingship rests on his moral perfection.
3. **The Son is the unchanging Creator.** The physical universe, however impressive and permanent it may seem to us, is subject to decay. It will wear out like an old garment. But he remains the same.
4. **The Son is seated in victory; the angels are sent out to serve.** And whom do they serve? They are sent out to serve *us*: "*those who are going to inherit salvation*".

## Living It Out

In our modern world we may not bow before angels, but every day we are tempted to exalt "substitutes" above Christ. Sometimes the supernatural, spiritual experiences, or even great spiritual leaders and traditions fascinate us more than the person of Jesus himself. At other times we fix our eyes on earthly rulers, political systems or economic structures, as if *they* were sitting on the throne. Hebrews 1 sets our perspective straight: everything and everyone in creation is only a changeable servant or a temporary garment that wears out. Only Jesus' throne stands for ever and ever.

This passage also offers great comfort to an uncertain heart. First, **your stability lies in his unchangeableness.** We live in a world where everything "wears out". Bodies grow old, relationships change, economies falter and seasons shift. When you feel as if the rug is being pulled from under your feet, hold on to verse 12: "*But you are the same*." The Jesus who was faithful yesterday is on the throne today, and his years will never come to an end.

Second, **realise how precious you are to God in Christ.** Think of the breathtaking reality of verse 14: mighty heavenly beings – God's flames of fire – are sent out by the King to stand by *you*, to protect you and to help you on your way to the eternal inheritance. You never walk through your trials alone; heaven's resources are actively involved in keeping you.

### QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Good things in place of the best:** Are there "good" spiritual things in your life (ministry, traditions, spiritual books, or emotional experiences) that have subtly taken the place of intimate worship of Jesus himself?
- **Where do you look for unchanging security?** Which "garments" of this world (status, money, health, comfort) are you clinging to as if they will last for ever, when only Christ remains unchanging?

- **Love for righteousness:** Verse 9 says the Son loved righteousness and hated lawlessness. As you grow closer to him, is your heart also beginning to love what he loves and hate what he hates – or are you making peace with small compromises?

## Prayer

*Eternal King Jesus, with all the angels of God I fall down in worship before you today. You are not merely a messenger or a good teacher; your throne, O God, stands for ever and ever, and the sceptre of uprightness is the sceptre of your kingdom.*

*Lord, in a world where everything around me keeps changing, ageing and wearing out like an old garment, I anchor my soul anew today in who you are. You are the same – yesterday, today and for ever. When my circumstances are shaken, remind me that you are the one who laid the foundations of the earth, and that at this very moment you are seated in full victory at the right hand of the Father.*

*Purify my heart, so that like you I may love righteousness and hate every form of sin and lawlessness. Fill me through your Spirit with the oil of rejoicing. And thank you, Father, for the indescribable grace that you send even your mighty angels as ministering spirits to carry me and keep me on the way to eternal salvation. I trust you with my life. Amen.*

DAY 3

# The Danger of Drifting: Do Not Disregard a Salvation This Great

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 2:1–4**

[1] That is why we must pay much closer attention to what we have heard,
so that we do not drift away. [2] For if the word spoken through angels
proved binding, and every transgression and disobedience received a
just penalty, [3] how shall we escape if we disregard a salvation this great?
It began when the Lord spoke of it, and it was confirmed to us by those
who heard, [4] while God added his testimony by signs and wonders and
various mighty works and by distributions of the Holy Spirit according
to his will.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In chapter 1 the author painted a breathtaking theological portrait of Jesus Christ as the eternal Creator-King – one who is infinitely exalted above all the angels. Now he makes a sudden, urgent turn. In the structure of the letter to the Hebrews we come here to the very first of five well-known **warning passages** (Hebrews 2:1–4; 3:7–4:13; 5:11–6:12; 10:19–39; 12:14–29). Here we see the heart of a true shepherd: deep theology is never meant merely to flatter our intellect; it demands a life-changing response. The little word "That is why" (*Dia touto* – Διὰ τοῦτο) at the start of verse 1 is the hinge: *precisely because* Christ is greater than any angel or prophet, an even greater responsibility rests on us who have heard his voice.

To make his point, the author uses a classic Jewish rabbinic way of reasoning known as *qal wahomer* (קַל וָחֹמֶר, literally "light and heavy": if something is true in a lesser case, how much more is it true in a greater one!):

- **The lesser:** *"The word spoken through angels"* refers to the law of Moses at Sinai (Acts 7:53). Under the old covenant, deliberate transgression and disobedience were punished strictly and justly (e.g. Numbers 15:30–31).
- **The greater:** If God's covenant word given through servants (angels) was taken so seriously, *"how shall we escape"* if we ignore the final word of salvation spoken by the **Son himself**?

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us look at the rich nautical and legal vocabulary of the Greek text:

- **"Pay attention" (*prosechein* – προσέχειν) and "drift away" (*pararyōmen* – παραρυῶμεν, v. 1):** The author uses two powerful Greek verbs from ancient seafaring. First he says we *"must pay much closer attention to what we have heard"* (*prosechein*). In everyday speech this means to fix your full attention on something, but in seafaring the word meant to hold a ship on course towards a harbour and moor it there safely (to drop anchor). The opposite is to "drift away" (*pararyōmen*). The word describes a boat that has not been properly tied up and quietly drifts with the current past the safe harbour – or a precious ring that slips unnoticed off a finger, or water seeping from a leaking jar. Notice that the danger for these believers was not a sudden, dramatic rebellion against God, but a slow, unnoticed drifting caused by spiritual tiredness and neglect.
- **"Binding" (*bebaios* – βέβαιος, v. 2):** That word *"proved binding"* – *bebaios* is a legal term for a binding, guaranteed contract.
- **"Transgression" (*parabasis* – παράβασις) and "disobedience" (*parakoē* – παρακοή, v. 2):** *Parabasis* means stepping over a clear boundary line; *parakoē* means closing your ears and refusing to listen.
- **"Disregard" (*amelēsantes* – ἀμελήσαντες, v. 3):** The word for "disregard" means to be indifferent, not to care, or to brush something aside as unimportant. The same word is used in Matthew 22:5 for the invited

guests who ignored the king's wedding invitation in order to see to their own fields and businesses.

- **"Added his testimony" (*synepimartyrountos* – συνεπιμαρτυροῦντος, v. 4):** God himself acted as co-witness – through supernatural signs (*sēmeiois* – σημείοις), wonders (*terasin* – τέρασιν), mighty works (*dynamesin* – δυνάμεσιν) and the sovereign distribution of the gifts of the Holy Spirit.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Deep theology demands a response.** Precisely because Christ is greater than any angel or prophet, an even greater responsibility rests on us who have heard his voice.
2. **The great danger is slow drifting.** The danger is not first of all dramatic rebellion, but indifference and neglect.
3. **The threefold foundation of "a salvation this great" (vv. 3b–4).** Why is this salvation (*sōtērias* – σωτηρίας) so great and so impossible to escape? Because it rests on an unshakeable threefold testimony: - **The origin (the Lord):** It began with the preaching, the death on the cross and the resurrection of the Lord Jesus himself. - **The transmission (the eyewitnesses):** It was reliably confirmed by the apostles who heard and saw Jesus first-hand (which also suggests that the author of Hebrews was a second-generation Christian). - **The divine seal (Father and Spirit):** God himself added his testimony by signs and wonders, mighty works and distributions of the Holy Spirit.

## Living It Out

Nobody wakes up one morning with a deliberate plan to shipwreck their faith. Spiritual decline almost always happens through *drifting*. Drifting away from the truth takes no effort at all; you only have to pull in your oars, loosen your anchor and let the current of our busy, secular culture do the rest.

When we are under pressure – whether through disappointment, busy schedules, financial stress or social opposition – the first things we often let slip are our daily anchor points: stillness before the Lord, meditating on his word, and the fellowship of believers. We do not openly reject the gospel; we simply get used to it. We treat "a salvation this great", which cost the Son of God his life, with a shrug of indifference while we spend all our energy on passing things.

This passage does not call us to panic, but to holy watchfulness. If we are not to drift, we must deliberately row against the current and moor our hearts daily (*prosechein*) to the gospel we have heard.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Check your spiritual course:** If you compare your love for Christ and your hunger for his word today with where you were a year ago, are you anchoring more deeply, or quietly drifting away with the current?
- **Which undercurrents are pulling at you?** Which specific things in your daily routine (e.g. too much screen time, career ambition, worry, or entertainment) act like a silent undercurrent drawing your attention away from the Lord?
- **The value of your salvation:** Where in your life may you have grown used to the grace of God? How can you "pay attention" to the gospel again today with fresh wonder?

## Prayer

> *Holy Father, thank you for the loving seriousness of your word today. You know my human heart, and you know how easily my attention is divided and how quickly I can begin to drift on the currents of this world without even noticing.*
>
> *Forgive me, Lord, for the times when I have treated your precious gospel – a salvation this great, bought with the blood of your own Son – with lukewarmness or indifference. Forgive me when passing worries and earthly*

*distractions became more important to me than the eternal word spoken through Jesus.*

*I pray that by your Holy Spirit you will shake my spiritual senses awake today. Help me, with new discipline and deep wonder, to pay attention to what I have heard. Be the unshakeable anchor of my soul in every storm and every busy season. Keep my feet on your path and hold my heart close to your cross. Amen.*

DAY 4

# Crowned with Glory: Humanity's Destiny and Our Substitute

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 2:5–9**

5 For it was not to angels that he subjected the world to come, about
which we are speaking. 6 Rather, someone has testified somewhere:

What is a human being, that you remember him,
or a son of man, that you look after him?
7 You made him a little lower than the angels;
with glory and honour you crowned him;
8 you subjected everything under his feet.
For in subjecting everything to him, he left nothing that is not subject
to him. As it is, we do not yet see everything subjected to him.

9 But we do see the one who was made a little lower than the angels,
Jesus, crowned with glory and honour because of the suffering of death,
so that by the grace of God he might taste death for everyone.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In chapter 1 the author showed us that Jesus is the eternal Son of God, highly exalted above the angels. But that raised a huge stumbling block in the minds of his Jewish readers: *If Jesus is so great and divine, why did he become a frail human being, suffer, and die a humiliating death on a Roman cross?* To the Jewish mind a crucified Messiah was a scandal (1 Corinthians 1:23). How can someone who descended lower than the angels and died still be greater than the angels?

To answer this deep question, the author takes us back to humanity's original purpose in creation by quoting Psalm 8:4–6. He shows that Jesus' incarnation and suffering were not a tragic accident or a sign of weakness, but God's brilliant rescue plan to win back humanity's lost crown.

He introduces the psalm with a deliberately vague formula: "*Rather, someone has testified somewhere*". Every Jewish reader knew exactly where it was written, and so the emphasis falls on God as its true author rather than on the human writer.

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us explore the literary and linguistic treasures in these verses:

- **"The world to come" (*oikoumenēn tēn mellousan* – οἰκουμένην τὴν μέλλουσαν, v. 5):** The author resumes his comparison with the angels: God did not subject "*the world to come*" (the new, redeemed earth and kingdom under the Messiah's rule) to angels. To whom does it belong, then? To answer, he quotes David's words from Psalm 8.
- **"A little" (*brachy ti* – βραχύ τι, vv. 7 and 9):** *Brachy ti* can express degree ("a little lower") or time ("for a little while"). In Psalm 8 it is about humanity's place in creation: "*You made him a little lower than the angels; with glory and honour you crowned him.*" When the author applies the same words to Jesus in verse 9, many interpreters read them in terms of time: for a little while, during his earthly life.
- **"We do not yet see" (*oupō horōmen* – οὔπω ὁρῶμεν, v. 8):** According to Psalm 8, God placed everything without exception under humanity's feet. But then the author voices the painful reality we all experience every day: "*As it is, we do not yet see everything subjected to him.*"
- **"But we do see ... Jesus" (*blepomen Iēsoun* – βλέπομεν Ἰησοῦν, v. 9a):** Here lies one of the most powerful contrasts in the whole New Testament. In verse 8 the author uses the word *horōmen*, in verse 9 the verb *blepomen*. Some interpreters see a difference here: we do not yet see the fulfilled creation with our physical eyes, but we fix our spiritual

gaze on him with insight and focus: "*But we do see the one who was made a little lower than the angels, Jesus*". Notice that this is the very first time in the letter that the author uses his human name, *Jesus* (meaning "Yahweh saves").

- **"Taste death" (*geusētai thanatou* – γεύσηται θανάτου, v. 9b):** The purpose of his humiliation is described with a moving expression: "*so that by the grace of God he might taste death for everyone*" (*chariti theou* – χάριτι θεοῦ). He did not merely dip his fingertips into death. In biblical idiom, "to taste death" means to experience death really and fully: he drained the bitter cup of death and of God's judgement on sin on our behalf.

### CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Humanity's original calling.** In Genesis 1:26–28 God created human beings as his image, to rule as his deputies over creation. God crowned humanity with glory and honour to govern the physical creation. Angels were never destined to rule over creation – human beings were!
2. **The tragic dissonance of the fall.** When Adam and Eve fell into sin, the crown rolled off humanity's head. Instead of ruling over creation in harmony and authority, we are plagued by sickness, natural disasters, temptation, sin and finally our greatest enemy: death. We are kings who have lost our throne and become slaves in our own kingdom.
3. **Jesus, the last Adam, has stepped into our shoes.** We do not stare at our own broken rule; we look at Jesus, the last Adam (1 Corinthians 15:45). Jesus walked exactly the path of Psalm 8. He who is eternally God was made a little lower than the angels by taking on a mortal human body.
4. **Through suffering to the crown.** And precisely *because of* his willing suffering to the point of death (cf. Philippians 2:8–9), he is now exalted as a human being and crowned with glory and honour at the Father's right hand! Where we humans failed, a true human being now sits on the throne of the universe.

## Living It Out

When we look at our world and our own lives today, the feeling of verse 8 often dominates our thoughts: *"As it is, we do not yet see everything subjected to him."* We see broken relationships, cancer diagnoses, economic pressure, injustice in society and our own stubborn shortcomings. It often feels as if chaos is winning and we are utterly powerless.

If you look only at your circumstances, you will become discouraged and begin to drift. But Hebrews 2 gives us the secret of perseverance: shift your gaze from what you *do not yet see* (v. 8) to the one you *can indeed see by faith* (v. 9): **"But we do see ... Jesus!"**

Think about what this means for you day by day:

- **Your humanity has eternal value:** You are not a cosmic accident or an insignificant speck of dust in a cold universe. God remembers you and looks after you (v. 6). In Christ your human destiny is being restored, so that one day you will reign with him in the world to come.
- **Your suffering is not the end of the story:** For Jesus the road to the crown of glory and honour led *through* the valley of suffering and death. If you are going through trials now, it does not mean that God has abandoned you; you are simply following in the footsteps of your King on the way to glory.
- **The sting of death has been drawn:** Because Jesus drank ("tasted") the bitter poisoned cup of death to the bottom for you, you never need to fear spiritual death or the judgement of God.

### QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Where are your eyes fixed today?** Are you letting the things in your life that still seem "out of control" and broken (v. 8) paralyse your faith – or are you deliberately choosing to fix your spiritual eyes on the crowned Jesus (v. 9)?

- **Wonder at God's care:** When did you last pause over David's question: *"What is a human being, that you remember him?"* Do you really grasp that the Creator of the galaxies knows you by name and has compassion on you?
- **Are you living from grace?** Verse 9 says that it is *by the grace of God* that Jesus tasted death for everyone. How does this truth change the way you deal with your own fear of failure or of death today?

## Prayer

> *Lord, our Lord, how wonderful is your name in all the earth! With the psalmist I cry out in wonder today: What is a human being, that you remember him, and who am I, that the Creator of the universe should look after me?*
>
> *Lord Jesus, I confess that I so often stare at the brokenness of this world. When I see sin, pain and uncertainty raging around me, my heart easily becomes afraid and discouraged because I do not yet see everything subjected to you. But today I choose to turn my eyes away from the storm and fix them on you. I see you, Jesus – crowned with glory and honour at the right hand of the Father!*
>
> *Thank you that you were willing to be made lower than the angels for a little while, to become human in my place, and by the indescribable grace of God to taste the bitter cup of death to the last drop on my behalf. Because you have conquered death, I need fear nothing. Fill me today with new hope and courage as I look forward to the world to come, where I will reign with you. Amen.*

DAY 5

# Our Merciful High Priest: The Pioneer Who Suffers with Us

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 2:10–18**

10 For it was fitting for him, for whose sake everything exists and
through whom everything exists, in bringing many sons to glory, to
make the pioneer of their salvation perfect through sufferings. 11 For the
one who makes holy and those who are made holy are all from one. That
is why he is not ashamed to call them brothers and sisters, 12 saying:

I will declare your name to my brothers and sisters;
in the midst of the assembly I will sing your praise.

13 And again:

I will put my trust in him.
And again:
See, here am I, and the children God has given me.

14 Since, then, the children share in blood and flesh, he too in the same
way took part in the same things, so that through death he might break
the power of the one who holds sway over death, that is, the devil, 15 and
set free all those who through fear of death were held in slavery all their
lives. 16 For surely he does not take hold of angels; it is the offspring of
Abraham he takes hold of. 17 Therefore he had to be made like the broth-
ers and sisters in every respect, so that he might become a merciful and
faithful high priest before God, to make atonement for the sins of the
people. 18 For because he himself suffered when he was tested, he is able
to help those who are being tested.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

### HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In the ancient Greco-Roman world one of the most important philosophical attributes of God was *apatheia* (ἀπάθεια) – complete imperviousness. The pagan philosophers believed that a true god could feel no pain, no grief and no human weakness, because to suffer would mean that someone or something had power over that god. Even for many Jews, the thought that the exalted Messiah would be tortured and die an accursed death on a cross was unthinkable.

In Hebrews 2:10–18 the author breaks radically with this cold, distant picture of God. He shows that it was precisely in keeping with the character and majesty of the Creator God ("it was fitting for him" – *eprepen* – ἔπρεπεν) to climb down into the mud and blood of our broken humanity. Jesus did not shout our salvation to us from the safe distance of heaven; he became flesh and blood to buy us back from the inside. Here in verse 17 the great central theme of the whole letter to the Hebrews is introduced for the very first time: **Jesus as our merciful and faithful high priest.**

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us dig into the riches of the Greek terms in this passage:

- **The pioneer made perfect through suffering (*archēgos* – ἀρχηγός and *teleioō* – τελειόω, v. 10):** God's great goal is "bringing many sons to glory". To do this he appointed Jesus as "the pioneer of their salvation". The Greek word here is *archēgos*, a rich and dynamic word meaning a pioneer, a trailblazer or a champion. A well-known sermon illustration pictures the *archēgos* as the brave sailor who leaps from a ship into a stormy sea, swims through the breakers to the rocky shore and ties a rescue line there, so that everyone else on board can cross safely to land. The text goes on to say that God had "to make the pioneer of their salvation perfect through sufferings" (*teleioō*). This does not mean in

any way that Jesus was morally imperfect or sinful (see Hebrews 4:15). *Teleioō* means to bring something to its full goal, or to qualify someone fully for a task.

- **Our brother who is not ashamed of us (vv. 11–13):** Because Jesus took on our true human nature, the one who makes holy and we who are made holy "are all from one" (one common Father and a human family bond). And then comes one of the tenderest sentences in the Bible: "That is why he is not ashamed to call them brothers and sisters." To prove it, the author quotes three Old Testament sayings and puts them on the lips of Jesus:
- **Psalm 22:22** (v. 12): The great psalm of the cross, which begins "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?", turns at verse 22 into a song of victory in which the rescued Messiah stands with his brothers and sisters in the assembly and sings the Father's name. Jesus leads our praise!
- **Isaiah 8:17** (v. 13a): "I will put my trust in him." Just as the prophet Isaiah put his whole trust in God in the midst of an unbelieving people, Jesus stands among us as the one who trusted the Father in human dependence.
- **Isaiah 8:18** (v. 13b): "See, here am I, and the children God has given me." Together with the faithful remnant, Jesus presents us to the Father as the children entrusted to him.
- **The devil's power broken (*katargeō* – καταργέω, vv. 14–16):** Verse 14 says that "the children share in blood and flesh" – the whole fragile, mortal human existence. That is why Jesus "in the same way took part in the same things" (*paraplēsiōs* – παραπλησίως). Ironically, his weapon was the very weapon with which the enemy had held humanity captive: death! Through his own substitutionary death he came to "break the power of" the devil. The Greek word *katargeō* does not mean that the devil ceased to exist, but to make something powerless, to disarm it, to put it out of action. Verse 16 confirms that he did not come to res-

cue angels; "it is the offspring of Abraham he takes hold of" (*epilambanomai* – ἐπιλαμβάνομαι – he grips them firmly in order to rescue them), that is, those who believe.

- **Our merciful high priest and atonement (*hilaskomai* – ἱλάσκομαι and *boētheō* – βοηθέω, vv. 17–18):** Unlike a prophet, who speaks to the people on God's behalf, a high priest stands before God on the people's behalf. To be able to do this, Jesus "had to be made like the brothers and sisters in every respect". He is both **merciful** (*eleēmōn* – ἐλεήμων – deeply compassionate towards our need) and **faithful** (*pistos* – πιστός – utterly reliable towards God and towards us). His core task as high priest was "to make atonement for the sins of the people" (*hilaskomai* – to turn aside and remove God's righteous anger over sin through a blood sacrifice). And because in his humanity he endured the full assault of testing and suffering without ever giving in, he is now able to "help" us. The Greek word for help is *boētheō* (made up of *boē* – βοή = a cry for help, and *theō* – θέω = to run). It literally means: **to rush towards a cry for help!**

### CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Our Saviour was qualified through suffering.** Through his real human suffering Jesus gained the qualification of experience to be the perfect Redeemer and High Priest for suffering people.
2. **Jesus is our brother.** Because the one who makes holy and those who are made holy are all from one, he stands with us as our brother in the assembly and leads our praise to the Father.
3. **The accuser has been disarmed.** Satan's power over death lay in his ability to accuse us as sinners before a holy God, for the wages of sin is death. When Jesus paid the debt on the cross, the accuser's trump card was torn out of his hand. As a result we are set free from the lifelong slavery of the fear of death.

4. **Our high priest comes to our aid.** Because he himself carried the full weight of testing, he rushes towards our cry for help with exactly the grace we need.

## Living It Out

This passage speaks directly to three of our deepest human struggles: **shame, fear and loneliness in temptation.**

First, think about your **shame**. When we stumble, doubt or wrestle with old sinful habits, the enemy whispers to us that Jesus is disappointed in us and ashamed of us. We feel like the "black sheep" of God's family and hide away. But look at verse 11: because he has made you holy with his own blood, Jesus is not ashamed to call you his brother or sister! He stands beside you today and presents you to the Father with joy.

Second, look at your **fear**. Much of our daily anxiety – about illness, safety, growing old and the unknown future – is rooted at its core in the fear of death (v. 15). That fear holds people captive in a cramped effort to stay in control. But Christ has broken through the grave and come out on the other side. For a child of God, death is no longer an execution but a passage into the Father's house. You have been set free to live for him fully and without fear.

Third, remember who he is when you are **tempted and tested**. When temptation knocks at your door or suffering overwhelms you, Jesus does not stand in heaven with folded arms, waiting to see whether you will fall. He knows how heavy the full weight of temptation feels, because he never gave in – he withstood the storm to the very end. As soon as you call, he rushes towards your cry (*boētheō*) with exactly the grace you need.

### QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Hiding in shame:** Is there an area of your past or your present struggle that makes you feel God is ashamed of you? How does verse 11 ("That is why he is not ashamed to call them brothers and sisters") change your

confidence to come to him today?

- **Slavery to fear:** In what practical ways do you still let the fear of loss, illness or death dictate your decisions and your peace, when Christ has already bought you free from it?
- **The cry for help in temptation:** When you are tempted, do you first try to fight it in your own strength (and fail), or do you immediately call on your high priest, who promises to run towards your cry for help (*boētheō*)?

## Prayer

> *Lord Jesus, my pioneer and my merciful high priest, my heart overflows with gratitude today. It is beyond my understanding that you, through whom and for whom all things were created, were willing to take on flesh and blood and to become like me in every respect – yet without sin.*
>
> *Thank you that you are not ashamed of me. Though you know every weakness, every scar and every failure in my life, you still call me your brother, your sister, and you sing over me in the presence of the Father. Thank you that through your death on the cross you broke the devil's power over death and made full atonement for my sins.*
>
> *Lord, set my spirit free today from every remnant of fear that still wants to hold me in slavery. And when I go through temptation or testing today, remind me that I am not fighting alone. You know the pain of the struggle. Hear my cry for help, merciful and faithful high priest, and come to my aid with your strength and grace. Amen.*

DAY 6

# Greater than Moses: The Servant in the House and the Son over the House

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 3:1–6**

[1] Therefore, holy brothers and sisters, partners in a heavenly calling,
consider closely the apostle and high priest of our confession, Jesus.
[2] He is faithful to the one who appointed him, as Moses also was in his
house. [3] For he has been counted worthy of greater glory than Moses,
just as the builder of a house has greater honour than the house itself.
[4] For every house is built by someone, but the one who built all things is
God. [5] Moses was faithful in all his house as a servant, to testify to the
things that were to be spoken later, [6] but Christ as a Son over his house.
And we are his house, if we hold fast to the confidence and the pride we
take in hope.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In the first two chapters the author has shown us that Jesus is exalted above the prophets and the angels. Now he comes to the very greatest human figure in Israel's history: **Moses**. For a first-century Jew, Moses was the undisputed giant of faith. He was the man who led Israel out of Egypt with signs and wonders, who received the Ten Commandments at Sinai, the author of the Torah, and the man with whom God spoke "mouth to mouth" and "face to face" (Numbers 12:6–8; Deuteronomy 34:10). Some Jewish traditions even placed Moses above the angels.

Had the author of Hebrews tried to exalt Jesus by running Moses down, his Jewish readers would have stopped listening at once. But look at the masterly wisdom and respect with which he goes about it: he fully affirms Moses' greatness and faithfulness, and then shows how the glory of Jesus

surpasses that of Moses at every level. Just as the architect of a building is infinitely more important than one of the stones in its wall, so Christ is greater than Moses.

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us dig into the riches of the Greek terms in these six verses:

- **Our dignity and our task (*katanoēsate* – κατανοήσατε, v. 1):** The author addresses the discouraged believers with two exalted titles: they are "holy brothers and sisters" (set apart for God through Christ) and "partners in a heavenly calling" (*metochoi* – μέτοχοι – partners who share together). Then he gives the central command of the passage: "consider closely … Jesus." The Greek verb is *katanoēsate* (from *katanoeō* – κατανοέω). It does not mean taking a quick glance at something; it means fixing your thoughts deeply on it, studying it carefully, pondering it and getting to the bottom of it. What are we to focus on so intently? On Jesus in his double office as "the apostle and high priest of our confession" (*apostolos* – ἀπόστολος, *archiereus* – ἀρχιερεύς, *homologia* – ὁμολογία – what we confess together as true). This is the only place in the whole New Testament where Jesus is called an "apostle"! An *apostolos* is an official envoy sent out with the full authority of the sender. Under the old covenant Moses was the "apostle" sent by God to Pharaoh (in the Greek Septuagint, Exodus 3:10 uses exactly the verb *apostellō* – ἀποστέλλω), while his brother Aaron was the high priest.
- **The house and its builder (*oikos* – οἶκος and *kataskeuazō* – κατασκευάζω, vv. 2–4):** The author draws on Numbers 12:7, where God himself testifies that Moses is faithful in all God's house. The Greek word for "house" (*oikos*) has a double meaning: it refers to a building (such as the tabernacle or the temple), but also to a **household, family or dynasty** (the people of God). Both Moses and Jesus were faithful (*pistos* – πιστός) to God. But Jesus is the **builder** (*ho kataskeuasas* – ὁ

κατασκευάσας – creator, architect and outfitter) of the house! And verse 4 draws the line straight through to Jesus' deity: "but the one who built all things is God."

- **The servant in the house and the Son over the house (*therapōn* – θεράπων versus *huios* – υἱός, vv. 5–6a):** In verse 5 Moses is called a "servant". The author does not use the ordinary Greek word for a slave (*doulos* – δοῦλος), but the very honourable word *therapōn*. A *therapōn* was a trusted, honoured servant, a personal confidant of his master. Moses' high calling as *therapōn* in the house was "to testify to the things that were to be spoken later" – in other words, everything Moses did and wrote (the tabernacle, the sacrifices, the exodus) was a prophetic preview pointing to the future coming of Christ. But look at the contrast in verse 6: Moses was a servant **in** (*en* – ἐν) the house, but Christ is there "as a Son over his house" – **over** (*epi* – ἐπί) the house! The servant carries out orders within the household; the Son is the rightful heir and ruler to whom the whole house belongs.
- **We are his house (*parrēsia* – παρρησία and *kauchēma* – καύχημα, v. 6b):** *Parrēsia* means open boldness and unashamed assurance in standing before God; *kauchēma* means a jubilant pride or joy in the hope that awaits us. (The words 'firm to the end', which older translations have here in verse 6, are not in the oldest manuscripts; the author does use them in verse 14.)

### CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Jesus is apostle and high priest in one person.** Under the old covenant Moses was the one sent and Aaron was the high priest. Under the new covenant Jesus fulfils **both** offices perfectly in one person: as apostle he comes from God to us to make the Father known; as high priest he goes to God on our behalf to make atonement.
2. **Christ is the divine builder, not part of the building.** Moses himself was part of the "house" (the community of faith); he was a redeemed sinner within Israel who needed grace himself. Moses is an honourable

part of the building, but Christ is the divine architect who brought the whole household – and the universe – into being.

3. **The Son rules over the house.** The servant's task was to point ahead; the Son is the fulfilment and the owner of the house.
4. **We are his house – the evidence of true faith.** Under the new covenant God's temple is no longer a building of stone and gold in Jerusalem: "And we are his house ..." As believers we form the living household and temple in which God dwells. Then the author closes with a conditional sentence that prepares us directly for tomorrow's warning: "if we hold fast to the confidence and the pride we take in hope." This does not teach that we earn our salvation by our own perseverance; rather, it shows that **perseverance is the evidence of genuine faith.** Whoever has truly been built into his house by the builder holds fast to him to the end.

## Living It Out

How does this passage speak to us today? When life gets hard, we all look for fixed points. Sometimes we make the mistake of building our faith on "servants in the house" – wonderful spiritual leaders, pastors, theological systems or church traditions. Like Moses, these people and structures are precious gifts from God, meant to point to Jesus like signposts. But when we pitch our tent at the signpost instead of looking at the destination itself, we will be disappointed, because every human leader is himself only a broken stone in the building.

Hebrews 3:1 gives us the simple, powerful remedy for spiritual weariness and confusion: ***Katanoēsate* – fix your thoughts deeply and wholly on Jesus!**

- When you feel that God is far away and unknown, look to Jesus as your **apostle**: he was sent by the Father to you to open God's heart to you perfectly.

- When you feel guilty and unworthy, look to Jesus as your **high priest**: he stands before the Father on your behalf and pleads his own blood for your acquittal.
- When you are worried about the church, your family or your own spiritual growth, look to Jesus as the **builder and Son over the house**: you do not have to hold up the roof of your life in your own strength. You belong to his household, and the Son rules over his own house.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Where does your attention go (*katanoeō*)?** If you look honestly at what you think about and dwell on most during the day, does Jesus as your apostle and high priest receive your deepest focus – or only the leftover moments of your attention?
- **Servants or the Son:** Have you perhaps tied your spiritual security to a human leader, a congregation or a tradition ("servants in the house"), instead of anchoring yourself directly to the Son who rules *over* the house?
- **Confidence and joyful hope:** What do your *parrēsia* (confidence) and your *kauchēma* (pride/joy in hope) look like today? Have disappointments made you shrink back into silence, or are you still holding on to his promises with glad expectation?

## Prayer

> *Heavenly Father, I thank you that you have called me by grace to be a holy child of yours and a partner in the heavenly calling. Thank you that I am not a stranger or an outsider, but part of your own household – the living temple that you inhabit by your Spirit.*
>
> *Lord Jesus, today I obey the call of your word and fix my thoughts and the eyes of my heart on you anew. You are the perfect apostle who came from heaven to me to reveal the Father's love to me, and you are the faithful high*

*priest who intercedes for me before the throne of grace. You are infinitely greater than every earthly leader or prophet, for you are the builder of all things and the eternal Son who rules over your house.*

*Forgive me when my eyes wander to people or circumstances. Build my life and my family according to your perfect architect's plan. Give me, through your Spirit, the strength to hold fast unshakeably to the end to the confidence and the joyful pride of the hope I have in you. Amen.*

DAY 7

# Today, If You Hear His Voice: A Warning against a Hardened Heart

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 3:7–19**

7 Therefore, as the Holy Spirit says:

Today, if you hear his voice,
8 do not harden your hearts as in the rebellion,
on the day of testing in the wilderness,
9 where your fathers tested me and put me to the proof
and saw my works
10 for forty years.
Therefore I was indignant with this generation
and said: They always go astray in their heart;
they have not known my ways.
11 So I swore in my anger:
They shall never enter my rest!

12 Take care, brothers and sisters, that none of you has an evil heart full of unbelief that falls away from the living God. 13 Rather, encourage one another every day, as long as it is called "Today", so that none of you is hardened by the deceitfulness of sin. 14 For we have become partners of Christ – if indeed we hold the assurance we had at the beginning firm to the end. 15 As it is said:

Today, if you hear his voice,
do not harden your hearts as in the rebellion,

16 who, then, were they who heard and yet rebelled? Was it not all those who came out of Egypt led by Moses? 17 And with whom was he indignant for forty years? Was it not with those who sinned, whose corpses fell in the wilderness? 18 And to whom did he swear that they would not enter his rest, if not to those who disobeyed? 19 So we see that they could not enter because of unbelief.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

### HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In the first six verses of chapter 3 the author has shown that Jesus, as the Son over the house, is infinitely greater than Moses, the servant in the house. Now he opens the second great **warning passage** of the letter (it runs on to 4:13). To drive his point home with unforgettable force, he takes his Jewish readers back to the darkest and most tragic chapter in Israel's wilderness history. He quotes Psalm 95:7–11 – a well-known psalm that calls Israel to worship – and applies it directly to their own hearts.

Why does he use the exodus generation as his example? Because that generation showed in a shocking way that you can experience great miracles, belong outwardly to the covenant people and make a good start – and still miss the final destination through a hardened, unbelieving heart.

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us explore the rich linguistic treasures of this gripping passage:

- **The living voice of the Holy Spirit and the urgency of "Today" (*sēmeron* – σήμερον, vv. 7–11):** Notice how the author introduces Psalm 95: he does not say "As David once wrote", but "as the Holy Spirit says" (present tense). For the author of Hebrews, the Old Testament is not a dead history book; when Scripture is read, the Holy Spirit speaks in the present. The key word that rings like a bell through this chapter is **Today** (*sēmeron* – vv. 7, 13, 15). Grace is never guaranteed for tomorrow. The moment God's voice speaks to your conscience is the critical hour of decision. The Spirit warns against the attitude shown at *Meribah* and *Massah* (see Exodus 17:1–7; Numbers 14 and 20:1–13). In Hebrew the names mean "quarrel" and "testing"; the Greek translation that Hebrews quotes has, instead of the names, the words "rebellion" (*parapikrasmos* – παραπικρασμός) and "testing" (*peirasmos* – πειρασμός). Although that generation saw God's supernatural provision (manna, water from the rock, the pillar of cloud) with their own eyes for forty

years, they kept challenging God with the question: "Is the LORD among us or not?" (Exodus 17:7). Their problem was not a lack of evidence but a heart that kept wandering away from God (*planaō* – πλανάω): "They always go astray in their heart."

- **The anatomy of spiritual hardening (*sklērynō* – σκληρύνω and *apistia* – ἀπιστία, vv. 12 and 13b):** In verse 12 the author turns the spotlight directly on the congregation: "Take care (*blepete* – βλέπετε – be constantly on your guard), brothers and sisters ..." The danger does not lie outside, in Roman persecution, but inside the human chest: "an evil heart full of unbelief" (*kardia ponēra apistias* – καρδία πονηρὰ ἀπιστίας). In Hebrews, unbelief (*apistia*) is not merely intellectual doubt or an honest wrestling with questions; it is a decision of the will to distrust God's promises and to shrink back from obedience when the road gets hard. This unbelief leads someone to fall away "from the living God" (*apostēnai* – ἀποστῆναι – from which we get the word *apostasy*: deliberately standing away, deserting). How does it happen? Verse 13 shows the process: through "the deceitfulness of sin" (*apatē tēs hamartias* – ἀπάτῃ τῆς ἁμαρτίας). Sin never comes to us with its true face and a warning label; it comes through *apatē* – deceit, illusion and false promises that compromise will give you rest and safety. The Greek word for harden (*sklērynō* – from which the medical term *sclerosis* comes) describes how something soft and living gradually stiffens and becomes numb.
- **God's remedy: daily mutual encouragement (*parakaleite* – παρακαλεῖτε, v. 13a):** How do we keep our hearts from turning to stone through the deceitfulness of sin? God gives a shared prescription: "Rather, encourage one another every day ..." The Greek word *parakaleō* (παρακαλέω) literally means "to be called alongside" someone. It includes encouragement, comfort, admonition, warning and urging (it has the same root as *Paraklētos* – Παράκλητος, the name of the Holy Spirit as our Comforter and Helper).

- **Partners of Christ (*metochoi* – μέτοχοι and *hypostasis* – ὑπόστασις, v. 14):** "For we have become partners of Christ – if indeed we hold the assurance we had at the beginning firm to the end." Notice the tense in the Greek: "we *have become* partners" (*gegonamen* – γεγόναμεν – a perfect tense, pointing to an action in the past with lasting results in the present). The word *hypostasis* ("assurance" or "foundation") refers to the solid reality on which we stand.
- **The tragic verdict at Kadesh-barnea (vv. 16–19):** The author closes the chapter with a series of rhetorical questions that fall like hammer blows. Whose corpses (kōla – κῶλα – limbs or corpses) were left behind in the wilderness? They were not pagans; they were the very people who had smeared the Passover blood on their doorposts, walked through the Red Sea on dry ground and sung the song of Moses! Yet when they stood on the threshold of the Promised Land at Kadesh-barnea and saw the giants (Numbers 13–14), they chose to listen to their fears instead of to God's promise. In verse 18 the author calls them "those who disobeyed" (*apeithēsasin* – ἀπειθήσασιν), and in verse 19 he says that they could not enter "because of unbelief" (*apistia*). They could not enter God's rest (*katapausis* – κατάπαυσις) – not because God's arm was too short to bring them in, but because their unbelief had locked the door from the inside.

### CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **God speaks today.** When Scripture is read, the Holy Spirit speaks in the present, and every "Today" is an hour of decision.
2. **Hardening happens gradually.** Every time we believe the lie of sin above the voice of God, spiritual calluses form on our soul.
3. **We cannot do it alone.** Sin's deceit thrives on isolation and secrecy. We need brothers and sisters who live close enough to us to remind us every day – while the window of "Today" is still open – of the truth of the gospel, when our own eyes are blinded by worry and temptation.

4. **Perseverance as the touchstone of partnership.** Verse 14 makes an enormous contribution to our understanding of the assurance of salvation. You do not become part of Christ by persevering at the end; your perseverance to the end proves that you truly became part of him from the beginning! True faith is not a rocket that shoots up brightly and then burns out; it is a lifelong anchor in Christ.
5. **Unbelief and disobedience are two sides of the same coin.** Unbelief is the root in the heart; disobedience is the fruit in our actions.

## Living It Out

Hebrews 3:7–19 shakes us out of every form of spiritual complacency. It is possible to look back on all the times God has helped you in the past – "out of Egypt" – and still reach a point in your life where disappointment, exhaustion or fear of the "giants" on your road make your heart bitter and hard.

Spiritual sclerosis (hardening of the heart) rarely happens overnight. It begins when you hear the voice of the Holy Spirit speaking to you about a specific matter – perhaps an unforgiving attitude, a compromise in your integrity, a lack of trust in God's provision, or a call to obey – and you say to yourself: "*Not today, Lord. I'll deal with it tomorrow.*" Every postponed act of obedience makes it easier to ignore his voice the next time, until at last you think that sin's sham solutions are safer than the living God.

At the same time this passage gives us a tremendous key to spiritual health: **Don't try to be a "lone-ranger Christian".** The spiritual journey through the wilderness is too dangerous, and our own hearts are too inclined to fool us. We need daily, honest fellowship – in our marriages, our families and our circle of believing friends – where we don't just greet one another with superficial compliments, but take one another by the hand and point to the faithfulness of Christ.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **What is the Spirit saying to you "Today"?** Is there a specific area in your life where the Holy Spirit has recently been speaking gently (or urgently) to your conscience, but where you are still dragging your feet or looking for excuses?
- **Unmask the deceit (*apatē*) of sin:** What false promise are sin, bitterness or worry trying to sell you at the moment (for example: "*If you just take control yourself or stay angry, you'll be safe*")? How does God's truth expose that lie?
- **Who encourages you, and whom do you encourage?** Do you have believers in your life who have the freedom to remind you of God's truth on a daily basis? And whom can you deliberately encourage (*parakaleō*) today who may have grown weary on the road?

## Prayer

*Living and holy God, who tests hearts and minds, I bow before you in honesty today. Thank you that you are not silent, but that your Holy Spirit still speaks to my heart today, clearly and lovingly, through your word.*

*Lord, I confess that my heart can so easily wander when the road through the wilderness grows long and hot. Keep me from an evil heart full of unbelief that forgets all the wonders and faithfulness you have already shown me in my past. Unmask every lie and every deceit of sin in my thinking before it takes root and hardens my spirit.*

*Give me today a soft, pliable and obedient heart that answers at once when you call. Make me also an instrument of encouragement to the people around me – in my home and my community of faith – so that we hold on to one another and spur one another on every day. Thank you that I am a partner of Christ; hold me fast by your grace, so that I keep my trust in you unshakeable to the end and enter your full rest. Amen.*

DAY 8

# The Promise of Rest: The Word of God as Judge of Our Hearts

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 4:1–13**

[1] So, since the promise of entering his rest still stands, let us fear that
any of you should seem to have fallen short. [2] For we too have had the
good news proclaimed to us, just as they did; but the word they heard
did not benefit them, because they were not united by faith with those
who truly heard. [3] For we who have believed are entering the rest, just
as he has said:

So I swore in my anger:
They shall never enter my rest!
And yet the works had been finished since the foundation of the world.

[4] For somewhere he has spoken about the seventh day like this: "And
God rested on the seventh day from all his works." [5] And again in this
passage: "They shall never enter my rest!" [6] Since, then, it remains for
some to enter it, and those who first had the good news proclaimed to
them did not enter because of disobedience, [7] he again sets a certain day
– "Today" – speaking through David so long afterwards, as has been said
before:

Today, if you hear his voice,
do not harden your hearts.

[8] For if Joshua had given them rest, he would not have spoken after-
wards of another day. [9] So then, a Sabbath rest remains for the people of
God; [10] for whoever has entered his rest has also rested from his own
works, as God did from his. [11] Let us therefore make every effort to enter
that rest, so that no one falls by following the same example of
disobedience.

[12] For the word of God is living and effective and sharper than any dou-
ble-edged sword; it pierces through to the dividing of soul and spirit, of
joints and marrow, and it judges the thoughts and purposes of the heart.
[13] And no creature is hidden before him, but all things are naked and
laid bare to the eyes of the one to whom we must give account.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

### HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

With chapter 4 we come to the part of the letter where the author begins to draw back the curtain on the unequalled high priesthood of Jesus and the true spiritual rest he has won for his people. At the end of chapter 3 we saw how the exodus generation turned back at Kadesh-barnea because of unbelief, and how their corpses fell in the wilderness. Now the author draws that warning straight into the present: the promise of entering God's rest still stands open – but it requires us to embrace the word we have heard with **active faith**.

To help the Jewish Christians understand that they lose nothing by leaving the shadows of the old covenant behind, the author brilliantly links three Old Testament crossroads: the rest of creation in Genesis 2:2, the entry into Canaan under Joshua, and David's prophetic call in Psalm 95.

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us explore the linguistic depths of this passage:

- **Hearing without faith (*synkerannymi* – συγκεράννυμι, vv. 1–2):** The author begins with a call to holy watchfulness ("let us fear ..."), like a coach who does not want a single runner in a marathon to drop out and miss the finishing line: no one should "seem to have fallen short" (*hystereō* – ὑστερέω – to fall behind, to arrive too late). Why did the wilderness generation drop out? They "had the good news proclaimed" to them (*euangelizomai* – εὐαγγελίζομαι) – the news of God's redemption and the promised land – just as we have. But merely hearing the message did them no good, "because they were not united by faith with those who truly heard" – with Joshua and Caleb, who received the promise in faith. (Older translations follow a different reading here: the word was not mixed with faith in those who heard it. Both readings come to the same point: hearing without faith does no good.) The Greek word for "united" (*synkekerasmenous* – συγκεκερασμένους, from

*synkerannymi*) was used for mixing two liquids, or for the digestion of food in the body. You can eat the best and most nourishing meal, but if your body does not digest it and take it into your bloodstream, it gives you no strength.

- **From Canaan to the eternal Sabbath rest (*katapausis* – κατάπαυσις and *sabbatismos* – σαββατισμός, vv. 3–10):** The author makes a careful distinction between two Greek words for rest. Throughout chapters 3 and 4 he uses the word *katapausis* (a general word for rest or a place of rest, such as the land of Canaan). He points out that even when Joshua (in Greek *Iēsous* –'Ιησοῦς, the same name as Jesus!) led the second generation across the Jordan into Canaan, this was not God's final rest. How do we know? Because David, centuries after Joshua, was still speaking in Psalm 95 of a future "Today" on which people must enter God's rest (vv. 7–8). What, then, is this deeper rest? In verse 4 the author points back to Genesis 2:2: "And God rested on the seventh day from all his works." God's rest has existed since creation, and he invites his people to come and share in *his own* rest. That is why in verse 9 the author uses a very rare Greek word: **sabbatismos** – a true, festive "Sabbath rest". Hebrews is the earliest known place where the word occurs (Plutarch later uses it too); the author may have coined it himself.
- **The paradox of eager rest (*spoudasōmen* – σπουδάσωμεν, v. 11):** In verse 11 the author calls us: "Let us therefore make every effort to enter that rest." The verb *spoudazō* (σπουδάζω) means to hurry, to strain every muscle and to pursue a goal with the utmost seriousness. It sounds contradictory: how can you *work hard* in order to *rest*?
- **The surgical scalpel of God's word (*tomōteros* – τομώτερος and *tetrachēlismena* – τετραχηλισμένα, vv. 12–13):** "The word of God" (*ho logos tou theou* – ὁ λόγος τοῦ θεοῦ) is not dead letters on paper; it is **living** (*zōn* – ζῶν) and **effective** (*energēs* – ἐνεργής – from which we get the word "energy": effective and at work). It is "sharper than any double-edged sword" (*tomōteros*; *machaira distomos* – μάχαιρα δίστομος – the short Roman sword, or the sharp knife the priests used to cut open sac-

rificial animals). It pierces to the deepest, invisible hinge points of our humanity – "soul and spirit … joints and marrow" – and acts as a judge (*kritikos* – κριτικός – a discerning critic or judge) of "the thoughts and purposes of the heart" (*enthymēseōn* – ἐνθυμήσεων and *ennoiōn* – ἐννοιῶν). Both Greek words describe what goes on inside us: the first what a person ponders in the mind, the second intentions and insights. Together they cover our deepest motives. Verse 13 closes with a gripping image: all things are "naked and laid bare" (*tetrachēlismena*) to his eyes. The verb *trachēlizō* (τραχηλίζω) comes from *trachēlos* (τράχηλος, neck or throat). In ancient wrestling it referred to a hold in which a wrestler bent his opponent's head back so that he could not look away; some interpreters also see an echo of the sacrificial animal whose neck was drawn back and cut open so that the priest could inspect it for any inner defect. At the end of verse 13 the Greek literally reads: "before him to whom for us is the word (*logos* – λόγος)."

### CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **God's word must be "digested" by faith.** In the same way, God's word remains powerless in our lives if we only hear it with our ears but do not "digest" it by faith into our will and our actions.
2. **The true Jesus brings us into the eternal rest.** Where the first *Jesus* (Joshua) could give only a temporary, earthly shadow-rest in Canaan, the true *Jesus* brings us into the eternal *sabbatismos* of God, where we stop trying to earn God's favour by our own works and legalistic toil (v. 10).
3. **Resting takes the fight of faith.** Our human nature constantly wants to fall back on self-salvation, pride, control or rebellious unbelief when the road gets rough. It takes spiritual effort and deliberate focus to lay down your own performance mentality and to keep resting with your full weight on Christ's finished work.

4. **No one can fool God.** No one can fool God with outward religiousness while their heart is hardened in unbelief. The God whose *logos* (word) lays our hearts open today is the same God to whom we must one day give our *logos* (account).

## Living It Out

This powerful passage speaks directly to two great challenges in our everyday walk with the Lord: **spiritual exhaustion** and **subtle self-deception**.

First, how often do we as believers still live as if we were running on a spiritual treadmill? With our minds we know that we have been saved by grace, but in our emotions and our daily lives we still try to buy peace through our own "works" – flawless conduct, dutifulness, or our ability to keep everything under control. Hebrews 4:9–10 invites you today to step off that treadmill. Entering Christ's *sabbatismos* does not mean becoming lazy or passive; it means that you stop working *for* God's approval and start living *from* his finished approval in Christ. Just as God looked with joy at his finished creation on the seventh day, your soul can rest today because Jesus cried out on the cross: "It is finished!"

Second, verses 12 and 13 remind us that true rest is only possible when we become honest before God. We are masters at wearing pious masks – even in our prayers. We hear the word and nod our heads, but inside we still harbour unbelief, bitterness, hidden fears or secret compromises. When the sharp, double-edged sword of Scripture touches a sore or hidden place in your heart today, don't recoil or defend yourself. God does not use his sword like an enemy to destroy you, but like a loving surgeon to cut out the malignant growth of unbelief, so that you can heal and enter his true rest.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Are you digesting the word by faith?** When you read or hear Scripture, does it stay as interesting theological information in your head, or do you "mix" it (*synkerannymi*) by faith and obedience into your daily decisions and crises?
- **Where are you still trying to "work" for your own salvation?** In which area of your life are you experiencing a deep inner restlessness at the moment, because you are trying to carry the outcome in your own strength instead of eagerly entering God's Sabbath rest?
- **Under the surgeon's knife:** If you stand before the eyes of the Lord today without any defence or excuses ("naked and laid bare"), what hidden motive, fear or unbelief does his living word expose within you?

## Prayer

*Living and all-knowing Father, I come and bow before you today without pretence or masks. Nothing is hidden before your eyes; you see right through my outward words and deeds into the deepest thoughts and motives of my heart. And yet, though you know everything about me, you lovingly invite me today to enter your rest.*

*Lord Jesus, thank you that you are my true Joshua, who does not merely lead me to a temporary earthly promise, but brings me into the eternal Sabbath rest of God. Forgive me for all the times I have heard your word but not united it with faith in my heart. Forgive me for my restless toil in trying to fix things and control them in my own strength.*

*Today I willingly surrender my heart to the sharp, living sword of your word. Cut through my self-deception, my pride and my little faith. Heal what is broken within me, and help me today to rest from my own works, completely secure in the finished work of my Redeemer on the cross. Amen.*

DAY 9

# The Throne of Grace: Our Great High Priest Who Can Sympathize with Us

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 4:14 – 5:10**

14 Since, then, we have a great high priest who has passed through the
heavens, Jesus, the Son of God, let us hold fast to the confession. 15 For
we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our
weaknesses, but one who has been tested in every respect in the same
way – yet without sin. 16 Let us therefore approach the throne of grace
with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace as help at
the right time.

1 For every high priest is taken from among human beings and ap-
pointed on behalf of human beings in what is to be done before God, to
offer gifts and sacrifices for sins. 2 He is able to deal gently with those
who are ignorant and going astray, since he himself is beset with weak-
ness. 3 Because of this he must offer sacrifices for sins for himself as well
as for the people. 4 And no one takes this honour for himself; he is called
by God, just as Aaron was.

5 So also Christ did not glorify himself to become high priest; it was the
one who said to him:

You are my Son;
today I have fathered you,

6 as he also says in another place:

You are a priest for ever
according to the order of Melchizedek.

7 In the days of his flesh he offered up prayers and pleas with loud cries
and tears to the one who was able to save him out of death, and he was
heard because of his reverence. 8 Although he was a Son, he learned obe-
dience through what he suffered; 9 and having been made perfect, he be-
came the source of eternal salvation for all who obey him, 10 addressed
by God as high priest according to the order of Melchizedek.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

### HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In Hebrews 4:12–13 the author confronted us with the sharp, double-edged sword of God's word, before which all things are "naked and laid bare". It is easy to lose heart and shrink back in fear. How can a broken sinner ever stand before so all-knowing and holy a God? The author's answer in 4:14–5:10 is one of the most comforting passages in all of Scripture: the One before whose eyes we lie exposed is at the same time our **great high priest**, who intercedes for us.

For Jewish Christians the Levitical high priest was the centre of their worship. Once a year, on the Day of Atonement (*Yom Kippur*), the high priest passed with fear and trembling through three curtains – from the outer court, through the Holy Place, into the Most Holy Place. In the tabernacle, which Hebrews describes, the ark of the covenant with its atonement cover (*kapporet* – כַּפֹּרֶת) stood there; in the Second Temple of the readers' own day that room was empty. But now the author shows that Jesus has done something infinitely greater.

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us dig into the richness of the Greek terms and the theological structure of this passage:

- **Our great high priest who has passed through the heavens (*dielēluthota tous ouranous* – διεληλυθότα τοὺς οὐρανούς, v. 14):** The Old Testament speaks of "the high priest" or "the great priest" (e.g. Leviticus 21:10). The full title "great high priest" (*archierea megan* – ἀρχιερέα μέγαν) occurs in the New Testament only here, and the author gives it to Jesus. Aaron walked through earthly curtains of linen; Jesus "has passed through the heavens" – beyond the visible sky and the galaxies, right up to the throne of God himself. And notice how the

author holds his two natures together in one breath: **Jesus** (his full humanity, which suffered alongside us) and **the Son of God** (his full deity, which gives his sacrifice infinite worth).

- **Sympathy without sin (*sympatheō* – συμπαθέω and *chōris hamartias* – χωρὶς ἁμαρτίας, v. 15):** The author uses a double negative to drive his point home: "For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses." The verb *sympatheō* (from which we get "sympathy") is much stronger in Greek: literally to suffer with someone from the inside. He "has been tested in every respect in the same way" (*pepeirasmenon* – πεπειρασμένον), but with one decisive difference: "**yet without sin**" (*chōris hamartias*). Some people wrongly think that because Jesus never sinned, he does not really know how hard temptation is. The opposite is true! As C. S. Lewis rightly observed, someone who gives in to a temptation after five minutes does not know how strong it would have become an hour later. Because Jesus resisted every temptation to the very end without ever giving in, he felt its full, crushing hurricane force in a way we never fully will.
- **Confidence before the throne of grace (*parrēsia* – παρρησία and *eukairon boētheian* – εὔκαιρον βοήθειαν, v. 16):** Because our high priest is already seated at the Father's right hand, God's judgement seat becomes for the believer a **throne of grace** (recalling the *hilastērion* – ἱλαστήριον, the atonement cover on the ark where the blood was sprinkled, 9:5). We may now approach "with confidence" (*parrēsia* – unashamed boldness and openness). There we receive two things: **mercy** (*eleos* – ἔλεος – forgiveness and compassion for the failures of our past) and **grace** (*charis* – χάρις – God's helping, strengthening power for our present need), "as help at the right time" (*eukairon boētheian* – at exactly the critical moment when we are about to give up).
- **What makes a true high priest (*metriopathein* – μετριοπαθεῖν, Hebrews 5:1–6):** In chapter 5 the author sets out two requirements for any true high priest:

- **First, human solidarity and gentle compassion (5:1–3):** An earthly high priest had to be "able to deal gently with those who are ignorant and going astray". The Greek *metriopathein* means to moderate one's emotions – not to flare up in anger at those who stumble, nor to walk away from them coldly and indifferently, but to treat them with gentle forbearance. Earthly priests, however, also had to offer sacrifices for their own sins; Christ had no sin of his own, yet showed perfect gentleness towards sinners.
- **Second, a divine appointment (5:4–6):** No one in Israel could make himself high priest (think of King Uzziah, struck with leprosy when he took on himself the priestly task of burning incense in the temple, 2 Chronicles 26). In the same way Jesus did not seize the office. The Father himself appointed him, and the author joins two Old Testament sayings: Psalm 2:7 ("You are my Son; today I have fathered you") and Psalm 110:4 ("You are a priest for ever according to the order of Melchizedek"). In Israel kingship (from Judah) and priesthood (from Levi) were strictly separate – but in Christ King and Priest are united for ever!
- **The school of Gethsemane (*eulabeia* – εὐλάβεια and *emathen … tēn hypakoēn* – ἔμαθεν … τὴν ὑπακοήν, Hebrews 5:7–10):** Verses 7 to 9 take us back to the dark night in the garden of Gethsemane and to the cross ("in the days of his flesh"). We see the eternal Son praying to the Father "with loud cries and tears". The text says "he was heard because of his reverence" (*eulabeia* – his deep, reverent godly fear and surrender to the Father's will; some read it as "heard and set free from his anguish"). God did not save him *from* dying on the cross, but brought him *through* death, "out of death", in the resurrection! Verse 8 contains a brilliant Greek wordplay: *emathen aph' hōn epathen* (ἔμαθεν ἀφ' ὧν ἔπαθεν) – **"he learned (*emathen*) obedience through what he suffered (*epathen*)"** As the eternal Son, Jesus was never disobedient; he did not need to learn to stop rebelling as we do. But in becoming human he learned *by experience* what it costs to remain obedient to the Father as a human

being in a broken world, when obedience costs you everything. Through this ordeal he was "made perfect" (*teleiōtheis* – τελειωθείς – fully qualified as mediator) and became the *aitios* (αἴτιος – cause, source) "of eternal salvation for all who obey him".

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The holy Judge is also our sympathetic high priest.** The One before whose eyes all things are naked and laid bare (4:13) also intercedes for us. We need not flee from his holiness, for our high priest has passed through the heavens.
2. **Jesus is truly God and truly human.** "Jesus, the Son of God" – his humanity makes him one with us; his deity gives his sacrifice infinite worth.
3. **Sinlessness does not mean ignorance of temptation.** Because Jesus never gave in, he bore the full force of temptation – and so he can truly sympathize with our weaknesses.
4. **Christ was appointed by God as King and Priest.** He did not take the honour for himself; the Father appointed him, according to Psalm 2 and Psalm 110, as Son and eternal priest according to the order of Melchizedek.
5. **Obedience is learned in suffering.** The Son learned obedience through what he suffered, and he is the source of eternal salvation for all who obey him.

## Living It Out

When we stumble or go through a spiritual drought, our human hearts nearly always react in one of two wrong ways: either we run away from God because we think he sits frowning on a **throne of condemnation**, or we try to "clean ourselves up" first and behave well for a few days before we dare to pray again.

Hebrews 4:14–5:10 smashes this religious lie to pieces. Your high priest in heaven is not an impatient judge shaking his head in disgust at your weakness. He has *sympatheia* and *metriopatheia* – a deep, gentle, personal compassion. Why? Because he knows the salty taste of tears in Gethsemane. He knows what it is like when body and soul tremble under pressure and you have to cry out to heaven for help.

Notice *when* verse 16 invites us to approach the throne of grace with confidence: not when we feel strong and have everything under control, but precisely when we need **mercy** (for our failures) and **grace** (for our weakness)! You do not have to wait until you have dried your tears before you come to him; you can walk straight into the Most Holy Place, tears and all.

At the same time, verse 8 teaches us a precious lesson about our own trials. If even the sinless Son of God had to learn obedience through what he suffered, why do we think we can grow to spiritual maturity without hardship? Your present suffering or challenge is not a sign that God has forgotten you. It is the classroom in which the Spirit is shaping you to learn, like Jesus, deeper obedience and trust.

#### QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **What does God's throne look like in your imagination?** When you become aware of your shortcomings or temptations, do you see God's throne as a judge's bench to hide from, or as a *throne of grace* you can run to with confidence (*parrēsia*)?
- **The honesty of Gethsemane:** In his distress Jesus prayed "with loud cries and tears" (5:7). Do you still pray only neat, polite prayers that hide your real fears, or do you dare to pour out your heart raw and honest before the Father?
- **The classroom of suffering:** Which difficult situation or "suffering" in your life right now is God using to teach you a deeper level of obedience and surrender (*emathen aph' hōn epathen*)?

## Prayer

*Merciful Father, with deep gratitude and wonder I approach your throne of grace with confidence today. I do not come on the basis of my own achievement or worthiness, but only because my great high priest, Jesus the Son of God, has already passed through the heavens and opened the way for me with his own blood.*

*Lord Jesus, thank you that you do not stand cold or indifferent towards my human frailty. You know the weight of temptation, you know the pressure of anguish in Gethsemane, and you know what it is like to cry out to the Father with tears. Thank you that you can fully sympathize with my weaknesses, and that you carry me with gentle patience when I go astray or fall short.*

*Today I ask for your mercy over my failures and your fresh grace for the challenges that lie ahead of me. Give me your help at exactly the right time. Teach me too, as you did, not to rebel against the hard seasons of life, but to learn obedience in every trial and to stay close to the Father's heart. Amen.*

DAY 10

# From Milk to Solid Food: A Warning against Spiritual Stagnation

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 5:11 – 6:3**

11 About this we have much to say, and it is hard to explain, since you
have become sluggish in hearing. 12 For though by this time you ought
to be teachers, you again need someone to teach you the first basics of
the words of God; you have become people who need milk, not solid
food. 13 For everyone who still lives on milk is unacquainted with the
word of righteousness, for he is an infant. 14 But solid food is for the ma-
ture, whose faculties have been trained by practice to distinguish good
from evil.

1 So let us leave behind the elementary word about Christ and be carried
on to maturity, not laying again a foundation of repentance from dead
works and of faith in God, 2 of teaching about washings and laying on of
hands, about the resurrection of the dead and eternal judgment. 3 And
this we will do, if indeed God permits.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

At the end of yesterday's passage (Hebrews 5:10) the author was just about to open up the fascinating and profound subject of Jesus' high priesthood "according to the order of Melchizedek". But suddenly he slams on the brakes! Before he can share this rich theological treasure with his readers, he realizes there is a major obstacle – not in the subject itself, but in the spiritual condition of his hearers. With this we enter the third great **warning passage** of the letter (Hebrews 5:11–6:12).

These Jewish Christians had been believers for some time ("by this time"), but under the pressure of persecution and the temptation to slip back into the visible shadows of Judaism, their spiritual growth had stalled. Worse still, they had gone backwards. In Greco-Roman philosophical teaching (among the Stoics, for example, and in Philo of Alexandria) the picture of milk for beginners and solid food for the advanced was a familiar teaching image. The author uses it masterfully to shake his congregation out of their spiritual apathy.

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us look at the Greek terms and the theological structure of this passage:

- **The diagnosis: spiritual deafness and sluggishness (*nōthroi* – νωθροί, v. 11):** The author has much to say about Melchizedek and Christ's priesthood, but it is hard to explain "since you have become sluggish in hearing". The Greek word for sluggish is *nōthroi* (according to an old explanation, made up of *nē* = not and *ōtheō* = to push or move). It describes someone who has become dull, lazy, listless or numb. Notice the verb "have become" (*gegonate* – γεγόνατε): they were not always like this! Their spiritual hearing had gradually grown dull because they had stopped actively listening and obeying. In Hebrews 6:12 the same word (*nōthroi*) appears again as the opposite of eager faith and patience.
- **Grown-ups who have become babies again: milk instead of solid food (*stoicheia* – στοιχεῖα and *nēpios* – νήπιος, vv. 12–13):** By now these believers should have been mature teachers of others. Instead they had sunk back to a level where someone has to teach them all over again "the first basics of the words of God" (*ta stoicheia tēs archēs* – τὰ στοιχεῖα τῆς ἀρχῆς – literally the ABC, the elementary building blocks). They had become like a nursing infant again (*nēpios* – according to the old explanation of the word, "one who cannot yet speak", a baby), able to live only on milk (*gala* – γάλα) and choking on solid food (*sterea trophē* – στερεὰ τροφή). There is nothing wrong with a newborn baby drinking

milk (see 1 Peter 2:2); it is natural and healthy. But when an adult is still living on a bottle after years and cannot chew solid food, it is a sign of a serious developmental problem. That is why they are "unacquainted with the word of righteousness" – they do not yet grasp the deep implications of Christ's finished work of justification and his high-priestly ministry.

- **The mark of spiritual maturity (*aisthētēria gegymnasmena* – αἰσθητήρια γεγυμνασμένα, v. 14):** Who are the spiritually mature (*teleioi* – τέλειοι) who can digest solid food? Verse 14 gives a brilliant definition of true Christian maturity. It is not about how many Bible verses you know by heart or how many theological debates you can win. It is about people "whose faculties have been trained by practice to distinguish good from evil" (*aisthētēria* – powers of perception; *gegymnasmena* – from *gymnazō* – γυμνάζω, from which we get "gymnastics" and "gymnasium"). Spiritual discernment is not learned overnight in a classroom; it is built up like muscle in a gym through *hexis* (ἕξις – "practice", repeated daily habit). Every time you hear the word and put it into practice by choosing the good and rejecting evil (and false teaching), your spiritual muscles grow stronger.
- **Beyond the foundation to the finished house (*teleiotēta* – τελειότητα, Hebrews 6:1–3):** In 6:1 the author switches his picture from a growing child to the building of a house. We are to "leave behind the elementary word about Christ" (*aphentes* – ἀφέντες) and "be carried on to maturity" (*pherōmetha* – φερώμεθα; *teleiotēta* – maturity). Of course this does not mean rejecting or forgetting the foundation! No builder tears down his own foundation – but no sensible builder spends his whole life pouring the same foundation over and over without ever putting up walls and a roof. The author names six "foundation stones" in three pairs that were typically part of early instruction for Jewish converts (and that would to some extent have been familiar even to a devout Jew under the old covenant):

- **The personal turnaround:** *repentance from dead works* (turning away from sin as well as from useless legalistic attempts to save oneself) and *faith in God*.
- **The shared rites:** *teaching about washings* (plural: *baptismōn* – βαπτισμῶν – which may include the distinction between the many Jewish purification washings, John's baptism and Christian baptism) and *laying on of hands* (for blessing, receiving the Spirit and setting apart for service).
- **The future hope:** *the resurrection of the dead* and *eternal judgment*. In verse 3 the author ends with a humble acknowledgement of God's sovereignty: "And this we will do, if indeed God permits" – for only by God's grace can a heart that has grown sluggish be raised up to maturity again.

### CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Spiritual sluggishness is a condition we drift into, not one we are born with.** The readers had *become* sluggish; their hearing had grown dull because they had stopped listening and obeying.
2. **Growth is the normal life of a believer.** Milk is good for babies, but someone who can take only milk after years has a developmental problem. God calls his children to become "teachers" of others.
3. **Maturity is trained discernment.** True maturity is measured not by knowledge but by faculties trained by practice to distinguish good from evil.
4. **The foundation stays, but we build on it.** Repentance, faith, washings, laying on of hands, resurrection and judgment are the indispensable foundation – but God wants to build a house on it.
5. **Growth is God's gift of grace.** "If indeed God permits" – only by his grace can a sluggish heart be carried on to maturity again.

## Living It Out

In the spiritual life there is no such thing as "neutral gear". Walking with Christ is like driving up a mountain or rowing against a strong current: the moment you stop moving forward, you start sliding back. This passage exposes one of the greatest dangers for believers who have walked with the Lord for many years: **spiritual boredom and stagnation**.

How easily we settle for the "milk" and the "foundation stones". We enjoy simple, uplifting thoughts about God's love and forgiveness (which are wonderful and true!), but we shy away from the "solid food" that challenges us to think more deeply about God's character, to crucify our own idols, to handle suffering maturely and to invest in discipling others. For years we attend worship services and read devotionals, yet remain perpetual "spiritual consumers" instead of becoming spiritual providers and teachers for the next generation.

Look at the author's secret of spiritual growth in verse 14: **the spiritual gym of daily practice.** Why do some Christians struggle to discern God's will or to stand firm when a crisis or temptation strikes? Because their spiritual faculties have not been *trained* (*gegymnasmena*) in the small decisions of every day. You do not become mature simply by reading more books; you become mature when you obediently put into practice the truth you already know today. Every time you choose to forgive, to speak the truth when it costs you, or to lean on Christ's righteousness instead of your own "dead works", you exercise your spiritual muscles and build walls on the foundation of your faith.

#### QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Consumer or provider?** Verse 12 says: "For though by this time you ought to be teachers ..." Considering how long you have known the Lord, are you already able to nourish and guide younger believers, your family or friends spiritually – or are you still living off other people's spiritual energy?

- **The state of your spiritual ears:** Where might you have become *nōthros* (sluggish or dull) in hearing because God's word asked you for a change that felt too uncomfortable?
- **Your daily "gym" (*gymnazō*):** Which specific spiritual habits are you practising at the moment to keep your discernment between good and evil, truth and lies, sharp in a confusing world?

## Prayer

> *Heavenly Father, I bow before you today with an open and teachable heart. Forgive me for the times I have grown spiritually lazy and sluggish in listening to your voice. Forgive me where I have been content to stand still in the same place and to look only for spiritual milk that makes me feel comfortable, while you are calling me to mature devotion and service.*
>
> *Lord Jesus, thank you for the unshakeable foundation of my faith – that you have saved me from dead works and given me the sure hope of the resurrection. But I do not want to stay sitting at the foundation. By the power of your Holy Spirit I want to go on to maturity. I want to understand and live out the depth and richness of your word of righteousness.*
>
> *Train my spiritual faculties today in the gym of everyday life. Give me sharp discernment to distinguish good from evil in every choice, and make me able to teach and encourage others around me in your truth with wisdom and love. Amen.*

DAY 11

# Earnestness and Perseverance: Inheriting the Promises through Faith and Patience

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 6:4–12**

4 For it is impossible for those who have once been enlightened, who
have tasted the heavenly gift and have become partners of the Holy
Spirit, 5 who have tasted the goodness of the word of God and the pow-
ers of the age to come, 6 and who have fallen away, to be renewed again
to repentance – crucifying the Son of God again for themselves and
holding him up to contempt. 7 For land that drinks the rain that often
falls on it, and produces vegetation useful to those for whose sake it is
cultivated, receives a blessing from God. 8 But if it bears thorns and this-
tles, it fails the test and is close to being cursed, and its end is to be
burned.

9 But even though we speak like this, dear friends, we are convinced of
better things in your case, things that belong to salvation. 10 For God is
not unjust; he will not forget your work and the love you have shown
for his name when you served the saints, as you still serve them. 11 And
we long for each one of you to show the same eagerness for the full as-
surance of hope to the end, 12 so that you do not become sluggish, but
imitate those who through faith and patience inherit the promises.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Hebrews 6:4–12 is without doubt one of the most debated, and sometimes most feared, passages in the whole New Testament. Down the centuries many sincere and sensitive believers have read verses 4 to 6 and wondered

whether they have stumbled too far to be forgiven by God. To understand these verses rightly, however, we must read them within the historical setting of the letter and in the light of the farming picture of verses 7–8.

The author is speaking here to Jewish Christians who were considering openly denying Christ and returning to the temple sacrifices of Judaism to escape persecution. To go back to the synagogue would have meant declaring, together with Jesus' opponents, that Jesus was a false Messiah and a blasphemer who deserved his death on the cross. The author warns them that such a final, deliberate rejection of Christ leaves no other lifeboat. Yet right after this thunderclap, the sun of pastoral tenderness breaks brightly through in verse 9: he calls them "dear friends" (*agapētoi* – ἀγαπητοί) and assures them that he sees the fruit of genuine salvation in their lives!

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us dig into the richness of the Greek terms and the theological structure of this passage:

- **The five privileges of the community of faith (vv. 4–5):** The author describes people who had experienced enormous spiritual blessings within the visible covenant community (just as the wilderness generation of chapter 3 ate the manna and saw the pillar of cloud):
- **Once enlightened (*phōtisthentas* – φωτισθέντας):** They had received the knowledge of the light of the gospel and had stepped out of the darkness of ignorance in their understanding.
- **Tasted the heavenly gift (*geusamenous* – γευσαμένους):** They had come to know at first hand the gracious gift of God that came down from heaven.
- **Become partners of the Holy Spirit (*metochous* – μετόχους):** They had shared in the common working and power of the Spirit in the congregation.

- **Tasted the goodness of the word of God (*kalon theou rhēma* – καλὸν θεοῦ ῥῆμα):** They had heard the powerful proclamation of God's spoken promises and experienced their goodness.
- **The powers of the age to come (*dynameis mellontos aiōnos* – δυνάμεις μέλλοντος αἰῶνος):** They had seen the miracles and spiritual gifts (see Hebrews 2:4) that broke into the present like a foretaste of God's coming kingdom.
- **The impossibility of renewal after open rejection (*parapiptō* – παραπίπτω and *anastaurountas* – ἀνασταυροῦντας, v. 6):** What happens when someone who has experienced all this light and power at close quarters deliberately has "fallen away" (*parapesontas* – παραπεσόντας – a total, calculated falling away and betrayal of the truth, not a believer stumbling into sin out of weakness)? The author says it is impossible for them "to be renewed again to repentance – crucifying the Son of God again for themselves and holding him up to contempt" (*anastaurountas … paradeigmatizontas* – παραδειγματίζοντας). Notice the present participles (*crucifying*, *holding up*): repentance is impossible as long as someone persists in the attitude that rejects Jesus afresh and shouts with his crucifiers that he is an impostor. If you reject the only high priest and the only final sacrifice of the cross, there is no "Plan B" for salvation. (And for anyone who is afraid today of having committed this sin: the very fact that your heart is tender, that you grieve over your sin and long for Jesus, is the unfailing proof that you are *not* in the hardened state of verse 6!)
- **The parable of the land: the same rain, different harvests (vv. 7–8):** To explain verses 4–6 the author uses a picture from nature (reminiscent of Isaiah 5 and Jesus' parable of the sower). Two pieces of land receive exactly the same gracious showers from heaven (the blessings of verses 4–5). One drinks in the rain and produces useful vegetation for the farmer. The other drinks the same rain but pushes up only thorns and thistles. The point is clear: **a tree is known by its fruit.** Outward

exposure to spiritual rain is not enough; where true new birth has taken place, the ground will in time bring forth the fruit of repentance and love.

- **Things that belong to salvation (*echomena sōtērias* – ἐχόμενα σωτηρίας, vv. 9–10):** In verse 9 the tone changes at once. This is the only place in the whole letter where the author addresses his readers as "**dear friends**" (*agapētoi*). He is "convinced of better things in your case" (like the fruitful land of verse 7) – "things that belong to salvation" (*echomena sōtērias* – things inseparably bound up with true salvation). How does he know that they are truly saved and not thorns and thistles? Verse 10 gives the answer: by their **work and the love** they have shown for God's name. (Older translations read "labour of love" here; those words are found in some manuscripts, but not in the Greek text we follow – compare 1 Thessalonians 1:3.) They did not just say with their mouths that they knew God; under difficult circumstances they served their fellow believers ("the saints") practically and sacrificially, and they still do! And God is just: he never forgets a single cup of cold water or act of love shown for the sake of his name.
- **Faith and patience to the end (*plērophoria* – πληροφορία and *makrothymia* – μακροθυμία, vv. 11–12):** The author's heart's desire is for each one of them "to show the same eagerness for the full assurance of hope to the end" (*spoudēn* – σπουδήν; *plērophorian tēs elpidos* – πληροφορίαν τῆς ἐλπίδος – like a sailing ship whose sails are filled with wind). He warns them not to become "sluggish" (*nōthroi* – νωθροί – the same word as in 5:11!) again, but to "imitate" (*mimētai* – μιμηταί) the heroes of faith who inherit the promises through two things: **faith** (*pistis* – πίστις) and **patience** (*makrothymia* – a long breath that keeps on believing even when a long time passes between God's promise and its fulfilment).

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Privilege is not the same as fruit.** A person can experience the light, the gift, the working of the Spirit and the powers of the age to come at close quarters – and still reject Christ.
2. **There is no other sacrifice than Christ.** Whoever rejects the only high priest and the only sacrifice of the cross has no "Plan B"; as long as someone keeps crucifying the Son of God again, repentance is impossible.
3. **A tree is known by its fruit.** The same rain falls on all the land, but true new birth becomes visible in a harvest of repentance and love.
4. **God does not forget the love shown in his name.** God is not unjust; every hidden act of service to the saints is known to him.
5. **The promises are inherited through faith and patience.** True faith has a long breath and holds fast to the full assurance of hope to the end.

## Living It Out

This passage holds up both a mirror and a tremendous encouragement for us today.

First, the mirror of verses 7–8 asks us: **What am I doing with the spiritual rain that falls on my life?** We have more access to Bibles, sermons, Christian books and devotionals than any generation before us. We are soaked in "rain". But the test of our spiritual life does not lie in how much rain falls on us or how moved we feel during a worship song; it lies in the harvest our life produces. Are we letting the word sink into the soil of our hearts and bring forth practical fruit of humility, obedience and service?

Second, verse 10 gives every discouraged servant of the Lord an indescribable comfort: "**For God is not unjust; he will not forget your work ...**" Perhaps you feel exhausted today. You serve your family, you help other believers in need, you pray in secret, and you do your work with integrity

– and sometimes it feels as if no one notices or appreciates it. Hear the promise of Scripture today: the just God of the universe sees every hidden act of love you do for the sake of his name. It is written in the books of heaven.

Finally, verse 12 reminds us that God's promises are received not only through *faith*, but through *faith joined to patience* (*makrothymia*). We live in an instant culture that wants everything at once. When God's promise or answer is slow in coming, we easily become sluggish and discouraged. But true faith has staying power; it holds on to God's character even in the long waiting room between promise and fulfilment.

#### QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Rain and harvest:** What specific "useful vegetation" (in your character, your family or your service to others) has the spiritual rain you have received over the past few months produced in your life?
- **The work of love:** Are you serving other believers in practical ways for the sake of the Lord's name at present (v. 10)? And how does it encourage you to know that God himself sees and remembers every sacrifice you make?
- **Faith with a long breath (*makrothymia*):** In which area of your life have you been waiting a long time on the Lord, and are you tempted to give up? What does it mean today to keep holding on to his promise with *patience*?

## Prayer

> *Faithful and righteous Father, I thank you for the abundant rain of your grace that falls so often on my life. Thank you that you have enlightened me with the truth of the gospel, that I could taste the sweetness of your good word and may know the power of your Holy Spirit within me.*

*Lord, keep my heart from ever taking your grace for granted. Let the soil of my life stay soft and receptive, so that every drop of your word yields a rich harvest of obedience and fruit to your glory. Thank you for the deep comfort that you never forget the work and love done in your name. Renew my strength where I have grown weary of serving.*

*Today I pray for the gift of patience. Where I am still waiting for the fulfilment of your promises and the road feels long, keep me from sluggishness. Give me a persevering faith that holds fast to my Redeemer to the end, with the full assurance of hope. Amen.*

DAY 12

# God's Unchangeable Oath: The Sure and Firm Anchor of Our Soul

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 6:13–20**

13 For when God made his promise to Abraham, since he had no one
greater by whom to swear, he swore by himself, 14 saying: "I will surely
bless you and surely multiply you." 15 And so, after waiting patiently,
Abraham obtained the promise. 16 For people swear by someone greater
than themselves, and for them an oath is the end of every dispute, as
confirmation. 17 In the same way God, wanting to show even more
clearly to the heirs of the promise how unchangeable his purpose was,
guaranteed it with an oath, 18 so that through two unchangeable things,
in which it is impossible for God to lie, we who have fled for refuge
might have strong encouragement to hold fast to the hope set before us.
19 We have this hope as an anchor of the soul, sure and firm, and it enters
the inner place behind the curtain, 20 where Jesus has entered as a fore-
runner on our behalf, having become high priest for ever according to
the order of Melchizedek.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

At the end of yesterday's passage (Hebrews 6:12) the author called us not to become sluggish, but to "imitate those who through faith and patience inherit the promises". Now, in verses 13 to 20, he takes up the greatest Old Testament example of such patient faith: the patriarch **Abraham**.

To Jewish Christians shaken by uncertainty and persecution, the author shows that our hope does not rest on wishful thinking or human optimism, but on the rock-solid character of God himself. With these verses he also closes the long section of exhortation that began in Hebrews 5:11,

and he masterfully brings us back into the main stream of his argument: Jesus as our eternal high priest according to the order of Melchizedek (v. 20).

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us explore the historical, linguistic and theological richness of this passage:

- **Abraham on Mount Moriah and God's oath by himself (vv. 13–15):** The author quotes Genesis 22:16–17 – the dramatic moment on Mount Moriah just after Abraham had been willing to offer his only son of promise, Isaac: "I will surely bless you and surely multiply you." Abraham had already had to wait twenty-five years from God's first promise of offspring in Genesis 12 until Isaac was finally born ("after waiting patiently" – *makrothymēsas* – μακροθυμήσας). And on Moriah God confirms his promise in an extraordinary way: he swears an oath. In ancient legal practice (v. 16) one swore by someone greater than oneself (such as by God's name) to settle every "dispute" (*antilogia* – ἀντιλογία) once and for all. But because there is no one in the universe greater than God, **he swore by himself**. In doing so God put his own deity, his honour and his very being on the line as a guarantee!
- **The "two unchangeable things" and God's guarantee (*mesiteuō* – μεσιτεύω and *ametathetos* – ἀμετάθετος, vv. 17–18a):** God's word alone is already completely reliable; he never needs to swear an oath to be honest. Why then did he do it? Verse 17 says he did it for the sake of *our* human weakness and doubt! He wanted "to show even more clearly to the heirs of the promise how unchangeable his purpose was" (to *ametatheton* – τὸ ἀμετάθετον – a word used in ancient legal language of a will or agreement that could not be cancelled or altered). So God "guaranteed it with an oath". The Greek verb in verse 17 is *emesiteusen* (ἐμεσίτευσεν, from *mesiteuō*), related to *mesitēs*, "mediator" (8:6; 9:15): to step in as **guarantor or mediator**. God, as it were, came and stood between himself and us as his own guarantee! And so our faith now

rests on "two unchangeable things" (*dia dyo pragmatōn ametathetōn* – διὰ δύο πραγμάτων ἀμεταθέτων), "in which it is impossible for God to lie" (*adynaton* – ἀδύνατον): first, **his unfailing promise**, and second, **his irrevocable oath**.

- **Fleeing to the city of refuge (*katapheugō* – καταφεύγω, v. 18b):** Through this double guarantee "we who have fled for refuge" (*hoi kataphygontes* – οἱ καταφυγόντες) "might have strong encouragement to hold fast to the hope set before us". In the Greek Old Testament (the Septuagint) the verb *katapheugō* is used, among other things, for someone who fled to one of Israel's six **cities of refuge** (see Numbers 35; Deuteronomy 19:5; Joshua 20) to be protected from the avenger of blood. We have fled from the judgement on our sin to Christ, our true city of refuge, and now hold on with both hands to the firm hope stretched out before us.
- **The anchor of the soul that is cast upwards (*ankyra tēs psychēs* – ἄγκυρα τῆς ψυχῆς, v. 19):** In verse 19 the author uses one of the best-known images of early Christianity: our hope is "an anchor of the soul, sure (*asphalē* – ἀσφαλῆ – it cannot slip) and firm (*bebaian* – βεβαίαν – it cannot break)". (Many anchors have been found on early Christian graves in the catacombs of Rome; the anchor was a familiar symbol outside the church as well, but Christians probably linked it with this verse.) But notice how the author turns the picture of an earthly anchor completely on its head! An ordinary ship's anchor is thrown *downwards* to the bottom of the passing sea. Our spiritual anchor, however, is cast **upwards and inwards**: it "enters the inner place behind the curtain" (*eis to esōteron tou katapetasmatos* – εἰς τὸ ἐσώτερον τοῦ καταπετάσματος) – straight into the heavenly Most Holy Place, where it takes hold at the throne of God himself!
- **Jesus our forerunner (*prodromos* – πρόδρομος, v. 20):** How did our anchor get there behind the curtain? Through Jesus, who "has entered as a forerunner on our behalf". The Greek word *prodromos* fits beautifully with both the ship picture of verse 19 and the temple picture:

- **A picture from seafaring:** A well-known sermon illustration (for which, however, there is no clear ancient evidence) tells of harbours with a dangerous sandbank or reef across the entrance. When a storm was blowing and the tide was low, a large cargo ship could not enter without running aground. Then a small, nimble rowing boat – the "forerunner" – would take the big ship's heavy anchor, row over the dangerous reef into the calm harbour and set the anchor there in firm ground. Afterwards the big ship could gradually haul itself safely into the harbour along that anchor rope. Whether or not it happened exactly like that, the picture captures the author's point perfectly!
- **In the temple service:** Under the old covenant the high priest was never a *forerunner* into the Most Holy Place. Once a year he went behind the curtain in fear, and no one could ever follow him there. But because Jesus has become "high priest for ever according to the order of Melchizedek", he has gone ahead as our *prodromos* to open the way, so that **we can all follow him into God's presence!**

### CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Our hope rests on God's character, not on our optimism.** The believer's hope is grounded in the rock-solid character of God, who swore by himself.
2. **God stoops to our weakness.** God's word is enough, yet for the sake of our doubt he confirmed his promise with an oath and made himself guarantor.
3. **Two unchangeable things secure our hope.** God's promise and God's oath – and it is impossible for God to lie.
4. **Christ is our city of refuge.** We have fled to him for refuge and hold fast to the hope set before us.
5. **Where the forerunner is, his followers will be too.** Jesus has entered behind the curtain as forerunner on our behalf; our hope is anchored there, with our eternal high priest according to the order of

Melchizedek.

## Living It Out

When the storms of life blow up – when a medical report shocks you, when financial or work pressure mounts, or when the world around you feels unstable – our emotions are tossed about like a ship on a rough sea. If in those moments your "anchor" is lying inside the boat (in your own feelings, your clever plans or your own staying power), or is fastened in the loose sand of earthly security, you will drift away (Hebrews 2:1).

Hebrews 6:13–20 teaches us that Christian **hope** is completely different from the way the world uses the word. In everyday speech we say, "*I hope it rains tomorrow*" or "*I hope everything works out*" – by which we really mean that we are unsure and keeping our fingers crossed. Biblical hope (*elpis* – ἐλπίς), by contrast, is a **blood-bought, oath-bound certainty** about the future, because it is grounded on two unchangeable things in which God *cannot* lie: his promise and his oath.

Think today about the overwhelming comfort of verses 19 and 20 for your own life:

- **You do not have to wait for the storm to die down in order to be safe.** An anchor proves its worth precisely when the wind blows and the waves pound against the bow. Your circumstances may be shaking you violently today, but the cable of your faith is fastened to an invisible Rock behind the heavenly curtain.
- **Where the forerunner is, his followers will be too.** Because Jesus as our *prodromos* has already entered the heavenly sanctuary with our human nature and fastened the anchor of our salvation there, our final safe arrival in the harbour is guaranteed. Every day his grace draws you a little closer to the harbour where your forerunner is already waiting for you.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **What is your anchor fastened to today?** When you look at the things that give you peace (or steal it), is your soul's anchor cast into temporary earthly securities that can shift, or is it fixed behind the curtain with Christ?
- **Doubting God's character:** When you struggle to believe that God will keep his promises for your future and your salvation, do you realize that God has given his own name and oath as a guarantee – and that it is *impossible* for him to lie?
- **Abraham's long waiting room:** Abraham had to wait patiently for decades (*makrothymēsas*) between the promise and its fulfilment. How does knowing that God's purpose is *unchangeable* (*ametathetos*) help you to hold on today while you are still waiting for his timing?

## Prayer

*Unchanging and faithful God, I worship you today as the One for whom it is impossible to lie. Thank you that you know my fragile, doubting human heart so well that you have not only given me your precious promises, but have also guaranteed them with an irrevocable oath by your own name.*

*Lord Jesus, I thank you that I may flee to you as my only safe city of refuge. When the storms of this life beat against my soul and my own strength fails me, I choose today not to look at the waves, but to hold fast to the unshakeable hope that lies before me. Thank you that this hope is a sure and firm anchor for my soul that can never break or slip.*

*I praise you, O Christ, that as my forerunner you have already gone ahead behind the heavenly curtain and fastened my life there to the Father's throne. Because you are there as my eternal high priest according to the order of Melchizedek, I know that you will draw me safely into the eternal harbour. Give me today the patience of Abraham, to wait on you in calm trust. Amen.*

DAY 13

# The Order of Melchizedek: King of Righteousness and King of Peace

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 7:1–10**

[1] For this Melchizedek, king of Salem, priest of God Most High, met
Abraham as he was returning from the defeat of the kings and blessed
him, [2] and Abraham gave him a tenth of everything. His name means
first "king of righteousness", and then he is also king of Salem, that is,
"king of peace". [3] Without father, without mother, without genealogy,
having neither beginning of days nor end of life, but made like the Son
of God, he remains a priest for all time.

[4] See how great he is, to whom Abraham the patriarch gave a tenth of
the best of the spoils. [5] Those of the sons of Levi who receive the priestly
office have a commandment in the law to collect a tenth from the peo-
ple, that is, from their brothers and sisters, though these too have come
from Abraham's body. [6] But this man, who does not trace his descent
from them, collected a tenth from Abraham and blessed the one who
had the promises. [7] Beyond all dispute, the lesser is blessed by the bet-
ter. [8] Here, mortal men receive tithes; there, one of whom it is testified
that he lives. [9] And one might even say that Levi himself, who receives
tithes, paid a tenth through Abraham, [10] for he was still in his ancestor's
body when Melchizedek met him.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

At the end of chapter 6 the author assured us that the anchor of our soul reaches safe and firm right behind the heavenly curtain, where Jesus has entered as our forerunner (*prodromos* – πρόδρομος), "having become high priest for ever according to the order of Melchizedek" (6:20). Already in

Hebrews 5:6 and 5:10 the author wanted to speak about Melchizedek, but first he had to deal with his readers' spiritual sluggishness. Now, in chapter 7, he throws the treasure chest wide open.

For first-century Jewish believers, the confession that Jesus is our high priest raised one big and fair question: *How can Jesus be a lawful priest if he was born of the tribe of Judah*? Under the law of Moses only direct male descendants of Levi and Aaron could hold the priestly office. To answer this question, the author takes his readers back to the only two places in the Old Testament where the mysterious figure of Melchizedek appears: the historical meeting with Abraham in **Genesis 14:18–20** (some four centuries before the law of Moses was given!) and David's messianic prophecy in **Psalm 110:4** (centuries after Moses!). With brilliant rabbinic exegesis he shows that from the very beginning there was a priestly order far older, higher and more exalted than that of Levi.

After Abraham had defeated the coalition of four eastern kings to rescue his nephew Lot (Genesis 14), Melchizedek met him in the King's Valley. Melchizedek was a historical Canaanite ruler of the ancient city of Salem (usually linked with later Jerusalem, see Psalm 76:2) who served the one true God, *El Elyon* ("God Most High"). Under the old covenant Israel had a strict separation of powers: the kings came from Judah and the priests from Levi. No king was ever allowed to enter the priestly office. But in Melchizedek – and finally and perfectly in Jesus Christ (see Zechariah 6:13) – **kingship and priesthood** are united in one person!

For a Levitical priest his genealogy was everything: if he could not prove his descent back to Aaron, he was at once barred from the priesthood (see Ezra 2:62). Genesis is the book of genealogies (*toledot*). Every important figure is introduced by who his ancestors were, when he was born and when he died. But when Melchizedek steps onto the stage in Genesis 14, the Holy Spirit deliberately gives no family tree, no date of birth and no date of death!

INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **King of righteousness and king of peace (*basileus dikaiosynēs* – βασιλεὺς δικαιοσύνης; *basileus eirēnēs* – βασιλεὺς εἰρήνης, vv. 1–2):** In verse 2 the author shows how Melchizedek's name and title form a prophetic shadow of Christ. First, his Hebrew name (*Malki-Tsedek*) literally means "king of righteousness". Second, he was king of *Salem* (related to the Hebrew word *shalom*), "that is, 'king of peace'". And notice the divine order: *first* king of righteousness, and *then* king of peace. True peace with God is never a cheap compromise; it always rests on the foundation of righteousness fulfilled (see Isaiah 32:17; Romans 5:1).
- **Without genealogy (*apatōr, amētōr, agenealogētos* – ἀπάτωρ, ἀμήτωρ, ἀγενεαλόγητος, v. 3):** At first sight verse 3 sounds puzzling: "Without father, without mother, without genealogy, having neither beginning of days nor end of life". Does this mean Melchizedek was an angel, or an appearance of Christ before his incarnation? No – the key lies in the rare Greek word *agenealogētos* ("without family tree, without genealogy") and in the way Genesis is written: Melchizedek's parents, birth and death are simply not recorded.
- **Made like the Son of God (*aphōmoiōmenos* – ἀφωμοιωμένος, v. 3):** Through this inspired "silence of Scripture", Melchizedek in the biblical text is "made like the Son of God" (*aphōmoiōmenos* – made like a portrait or facsimile of). Melchizedek is not the original; the eternal Son of God is the Original, and Melchizedek's appearance in Genesis is like a portrait painted in advance, designed so that in the witness of Scripture he "remains a priest for all time" (*eis to diēnekes* – εἰς τὸ διηνεκές, without interruption).
- **"See" (*theōreite* – θεωρεῖτε) and the patriarch (*ho patriarchēs* – ὁ πατριάρχης, v. 4):** The author calls on his Jewish readers: "See how great he is" – *theōreite* means to look with attention and wonder. He respectfully calls Abraham "the patriarch" (*patriarchēs*), a word that in

the Greek stands at the very end of the sentence for maximum emphasis: literally something like: … to whom Abraham gave a tenth – the patriarch!

- **The best of the spoils (*ek tōn akrothiniōn* – ἐκ τῶν ἀκροθινίων, v. 4):** Abraham gave Melchizedek "a tenth of the best of the spoils". In the ancient Greek world *akrothinia* referred to the very top of a heap of grain or of the spoils of war, set apart as a thank-offering for the king or the deity.
- **The better (*tou kreittonos* – τοῦ κρείττονος, v. 7):** The author draws a sharp contrast. The Levitical priests did collect tithes under the law from their fellow Israelites ("that is, from their brothers and sisters") as payment for their service, even though as descendants of Abraham they stood on an equal footing (v. 5). But Melchizedek, who was no part of Levi's family tree at all, received a tenth from Abraham himself and "blessed the one who had the promises" (v. 6). Then comes the irrefutable principle of verse 7: "Beyond all dispute, the lesser is blessed by the better." *Kreittōn* is the word that everywhere else in Hebrews means "better".
- **Mortal men (*apothnēskontes anthrōpoi* – ἀποθνῄσκοντες ἄνθρωποι, v. 8):** "Here, mortal men receive tithes; there, one of whom it is testified that he lives." Literally they are men *who are dying*. With Melchizedek the tenth is received by one of whom Scripture testifies that he lives, because it portrays him without end of days – a pointer to the risen Christ.

### CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Christ is both King and Priest.** What was strictly separated under the old covenant is foreshadowed in Melchizedek and perfectly united in Jesus Christ. He is first King of righteousness, and then King of peace.
2. **Scripture itself points ahead to Christ.** Even the "silence" of Genesis about Melchizedek's origins is part of God's plan to paint a portrait of the eternal Son, whose priesthood does not rest on descent.

3. **Melchizedek's priesthood is higher than Levi's.** When Abraham bowed his head before Melchizedek to receive his blessing, the father of the whole Jewish nation acknowledged that Melchizedek's priesthood was higher than himself.
4. **Corporate solidarity.** In verses 9–10 the author delivers his masterful final stroke: when Abraham handed over a tenth to Melchizedek that day in the King's Valley, his great-grandson **Levi** (and the whole later Aaronic priesthood) was "still in his ancestor's body". Through Abraham's hand Levi himself, as it were, paid a tenth to Melchizedek and bowed before a greater priesthood that would one day be fulfilled in Jesus Christ.

## Living It Out

At first glance Hebrews 7:1–10 looks like a deep theological argument for first-century Jews, but its spiritual pulse touches every single day of our modern lives.

First, the order of Melchizedek's titles (v. 2) teaches us an indispensable lesson about how God works in our hearts: he is **first King of righteousness, and then King of peace.** How often do we look for inner peace (*Salem*) in our lives, but want it without God's righteousness touching our hidden idols, our unconfessed sin or our broken relationships? We look for a psychological plaster while the wound is still dirty. But at Golgotha our true *Malki-Tsedek* first satisfied the full claim of God's righteousness on the cross, so that he could give us genuine, unshakeable peace. When you feel unrest in your heart today, don't try to fake peace by sweeping things under the carpet; bring them into the light before the King of righteousness, and his peace will follow like a river.

Second, verse 3 frees us from the limits of our own **"genealogy" and past**. In the world (and in legalistic religion) your worth is measured by your family tree, your background, your qualifications or your achievements. But in the kingdom of Christ only his eternal priesthood counts. Whether

you come from a broken background or feel that your spiritual "CV" is full of mistakes – your high priest does not hand out his blessing on the basis of your pedigree, but out of free grace.

Third, Abraham's response in verse 4 calls us to **the grateful surrender of our "best of the spoils" (*akrothinia*).** Notice that Abraham was not under the compulsion of the law of Moses when he gave his tenth to Melchizedek; the law would only come some four centuries later! Out of spontaneous wonder and gratitude after the victory he laid the very best part of his gain before the King-Priest, because he had seen Melchizedek's greatness ("See how great he is"). When we open our eyes today and see how great Jesus is – that he has rescued us from the slavery of sin and blesses us with every spiritual blessing – we no longer give our time, our gifts, our attention and our means out of guilt or legal compulsion. We give him the *akrothinia* – the very top, the best part of our day and our heart – because he is overwhelmingly great and worthy!

### QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Righteousness and peace:** Is there an area of your life where you are lacking inner peace right now because you have not yet allowed Jesus, as the *King of righteousness*, to address that matter in truth?
- **The best of the spoils (*akrothinia*) or the leftovers?** When you look at your time, your energy and your resources, does King Jesus get the very first and best part of the "heap" – or do you give him only what remains after the world and your own interests have taken their share?
- **A meeting after the battle:** When Abraham came back from the war tired and vulnerable, Melchizedek met him with bread, wine and blessing (Genesis 14:18–19; Hebrews 7:1). Do you let your high priest refresh and bless you after your daily battles and exhaustion – or do you try to carry on under your own steam?

## Prayer

*God Most High, Maker of heaven and earth, I bow before you today in deep wonder. I thank you that through the ages you have unfolded your perfect plan of redemption and have given me a high priest infinitely greater than any human or earthly institution.*

*Lord Jesus, I worship you today as my true Melchizedek! You are my King of righteousness, who through your spotless life and your death on the cross paid my debt in full and clothed me with your own righteousness. And you are my King of Salem, who makes peace between me and the Father and stills the storms within me. You have no beginning of days and no end of life, and your priesthood stands firm for ever and ever.*

*Open my spiritual eyes today to see afresh how great and glorious you are. Just as Abraham bowed before Melchizedek, I bow all that I am and have before you today. I do not want to serve you out of cold, legalistic duty, but out of a heart overflowing with gratitude. Take today the first and best part of my time, my thoughts, my work and my love as a thank-offering to you, the living Son of God, who makes me rich with every heavenly blessing. Amen.*

DAY 14

# A Permanent Priesthood: Christ Who Is Able to Save Completely

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 7:11–28**

11 Now if perfection had come through the Levitical priesthood – for on
the basis of it the people received the law – what further need would
there have been for another priest to arise according to the order of
Melchizedek, and not to be named according to the order of Aaron?
12 For when the priesthood is changed, there is of necessity a change of
law as well. 13 For the one of whom these things are said belonged to an-
other tribe, from which no one has ever served at the altar. 14 For it is
clear that our Lord has arisen from Judah, and in connection with that
tribe Moses said nothing about priests.

15 And it is even more evident if another priest arises in the likeness of
Melchizedek, 16 who has become a priest not according to a law of a
fleshly commandment but according to the power of an indestructible
life. 17 For it is testified:

You are a priest for ever
according to the order of Melchizedek.

18 For on the one hand, a former commandment is set aside because of
its weakness and uselessness 19 – for the law made nothing perfect – and
on the other hand, a better hope is brought in, through which we draw
near to God.

20 And it was not without a sworn oath. For the others became priests
without a sworn oath, 21 but he with a sworn oath, through the one who
said to him:

The Lord has sworn
and will not change his mind:
You are a priest for ever.

22 So much the more has Jesus become the guarantor of a better
covenant.

23 The former priests were many in number, because they were pre-
vented by death from continuing in office; 24 but he, because he remains
for ever, holds his priesthood permanently. 25 That is why he is able to

save completely those who approach God through him, since he always lives to intercede for them.

[26] For it was fitting that we should have such a high priest: holy, innocent, undefiled, separated from sinners, and become higher than the heavens. [27] He has no need, like the high priests, to offer up sacrifices day after day, first for his own sins and then for those of the people; for this he did once for all when he offered up himself. [28] For the law appoints as high priests men who have weakness, but the word of the sworn oath, which came after the law, appoints a Son, made perfect for ever.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

### HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

With Hebrews 7:11–28 we reach the breathtaking summit of the section on our great high priest in chapters 4 to 7. Having set out the historical picture of Melchizedek in the first ten verses of chapter 7, the author now applies it directly to the person and work of Jesus Christ.

For a first-century Jew the law of Moses (*Torah*) and the Levitical temple service were two inseparable pillars: the priesthood administered the law, and the law regulated the priesthood. Here the author dares to set off a radical theological earthquake: he shows that the old covenant was never meant to be permanent. Why? Because from the start it was unable to solve fully the deepest human problem – a defiled conscience and separation from God.

The author begins with a sharp, logical question: "Now if perfection had come through the Levitical priesthood", why did David, centuries after the law was given, prophesy in Psalm 110:4 that *another* priest would arise according to the order of Melchizedek? What is more, "it is clear that our Lord has arisen from Judah" (v. 14), the royal tribe in connection with which Moses said nothing about priests.

Under the old covenant there was an endless relay race of priests. According to the Jewish historian Josephus there were eighty-three high priests from Aaron to the destruction of the temple in AD 70. Why so many? Because death kept catching up with them! Just when you had built up a relationship of trust with a wise, compassionate priest, he died, and you had to start again with his successor.

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **Perfection (*teleiōsis* – τελείωσις, v. 11):** *Teleiōsis* is perfect reconciliation and unhindered access to God. The Levitical priesthood could not bring it, "for the law made nothing perfect" (v. 19).
- **A fleshly commandment versus an indestructible life (*entolēs sarkinēs* – ἐντολῆς σαρκίνης; *zōēs akatalytou* – ζωῆς ἀκαταλύτου, v. 16):** Jesus has become a priest "not according to a law of a fleshly commandment" – outward rules about physical descent and family trees – "but according to the power of an indestructible life". His resurrection from the dead proved that nothing can dissolve or destroy his life.
- **Setting aside (*athetēsis* – ἀθέτησις, v. 18):** That is why in verse 18 "a former commandment is set aside because of its weakness and uselessness". *Athetēsis* is a legal term for annulling or setting aside an old regulation. The law was not bad, but it was like a signpost: a signpost can show you where the destination is, but it has no power to get you there.
- **Draw near to God (*engizomen tō theō* – ἐγγίζομεν τῷ θεῷ, v. 19):** In its place "a better hope is brought in, through which we draw near to God". Under the old order the people had to keep their distance; under the new order we are invited to come near!
- **Guarantor (*engyos* – ἔγγυος, v. 22):** No Levitical priest was ever appointed with a divine oath; they simply inherited the office by birth. But Christ was appointed by the Father with a solemn sworn oath (Psalm 110:4). And precisely for that reason Jesus has become "the guarantor of a better covenant" (v. 22). The word *engyos* occurs only here in the whole New Testament. It is a stronger word than "mediator"

(*mesitēs* – μεσίτης, 8:6). A mediator negotiates between two parties, but an *engyos* (guarantor) is someone who puts his own life, property and honour at stake to guarantee personally that all the terms of the agreement will be kept. If we should fail, the guarantor pays! Christ does not only guarantee God's promises to us; on the cross he also settled our whole debt to God.

- **A permanent priesthood (*aparabaton* – ἀπαράβατον, v. 24):** Jesus remains for ever, and therefore he "holds his priesthood permanently". *Aparabatos* literally means "inviolable" or "non-transferable" – his office will never pass to anyone else; he never retires.
- **Completely (*eis to panteles* – εἰς τὸ παντελὲς) and intercede (*entynchanein* – ἐντυγχάνειν, v. 25):** Then comes the golden crown jewel of chapter 7: "That is why he is able to save completely those who approach God through him, since he always lives to intercede for them." The phrase *eis to panteles* has a double shade in Greek: it means **completely, utterly** (to the deepest corner of our brokenness) and **for all time** (to the very end of time). Why is his salvation so perfect? Because his death on the cross is followed by his unceasing intercession (*entynchanein*) at the Father's right hand!
- **The perfect high priest (*hosios, akakos, amiantos* – ὅσιος, ἄκακος, ἀμίαντος, v. 26):** The author closes the chapter with a hymn of praise to Christ's character. He is *holy* (*hosios* – inwardly devoted to God), *innocent* (*akakos* – free of any evil or malice towards people), *undefiled* (*amiantos* – free of any ritual or moral defilement), and in his glorified state "separated from sinners, and become higher than the heavens".
- **Once for all (*ephapax* – ἐφάπαξ, v. 27):** Unlike Aaron's descendants, who had to stand and offer sacrifices day after day, Jesus had no sin of his own. And when he offered a sacrifice, he did not bring the blood of goats or calves – **he offered up himself!** Notice the mighty little word in verse 27: "for this he did once for all when he offered up himself."

*Ephapax* is one of the key words of Hebrews (7:27; 9:12; 10:10): it describes something so final, perfect and conclusively done that it never needs to be repeated.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The old covenant was never meant to be permanent.** The law and the Levitical priesthood could not bring perfection; that is why God himself announced another priest according to the order of Melchizedek.
2. **Christ's priesthood rests on his resurrection life and on God's oath.** Not descent, but "the power of an indestructible life" and the Father's sworn oath make him priest.
3. **Christ is our guarantor and our intercessor.** He guarantees the better covenant with his own life, and he always lives to intercede for us; that is why he can save completely.
4. **His sacrifice is once for all.** The Son, "made perfect for ever" (v. 28), offered up himself. Nothing can be added to his finished work.

## Living It Out

How does Hebrews 7:11–28 change the way you handle your faith and your failures today?

First, it sets us free from the **slavery of religious "rule-keeping".** Just like the first readers, we so easily fall back on a "fleshly commandment" (v. 16) – the idea that our spiritual security depends on how well we keep a little list of outward rules. But rules have never had the power to change a human heart or bring you closer to God; they only expose your weakness (vv. 18–19). Real change and intimate nearness to God flow from "the power of an indestructible life" – the resurrection life of Jesus, who lives in you by his Spirit.

Second, rest today in the wonder of Jesus as your **guarantor (*engyos*)** and your **intercessor**. Perhaps you feel today that your grip on God is very weak. You look at your own fickleness and wonder: *How will I ever make it to the end*? Hear the gospel of verses 22 and 25 today: your perseverance does not depend on your ability to keep the covenant standing in your own strength; Jesus has personally signed as *guarantor* for you!

What is more, he did not just save you on the cross two thousand years ago and then leave you to fend for yourself. He lives **today** – at this very second – to intercede for you (*entynchanein*). As the nineteenth-century Scottish preacher Robert Murray M'Cheyne once said: "*If I could hear Christ praying for me in the next room, I would not fear a million enemies. Yet distance makes no difference. He is praying for me.*" Because he prays for you, he is able to save you **completely** (*eis to panteles*) – from every sin, through every temptation, all the way into eternal glory.

### QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Rules or resurrection power?** Are you currently trying to keep your spiritual life going through outward laws and duties (a "fleshly commandment") – or do you live each day from the inner power of Christ's indestructible life?
- **The reach of his salvation (*eis to panteles*):** Is there a particular besetting sin, a deep-rooted fear or a broken part of your life that you secretly think even Jesus cannot really save or heal? What does verse 25 say to that unbelief?
- **The once-for-all sacrifice (*ephapax*):** If Jesus' sacrifice on the cross really was enough *once for all* to take away your sins, why do you still sometimes punish yourself with old feelings of guilt, as if you had to add something to his sacrifice yourself?

## Prayer

*Holy and exalted Father, I praise you that you have not left me to a weak and powerless system of outward laws that could never make me perfect. Thank you for the better hope through which I may draw near today with confidence, right up to your throne.*

*Lord Jesus, I worship you as my eternal high priest according to the order of Melchizedek. Your priesthood does not rest on mortal human effort, but on the power of your indestructible resurrection life and on the unchangeable oath of God. Thank you that you brought the perfect sacrifice once for all when you gave yourself for me on the cross – there is nothing I could ever add, or need to add, to your finished work.*

*What an indescribable comfort to know that you are my guarantor, who stands in personally for my life, and that at this very moment you live in heaven to intercede for me with the Father! Save me completely today, Lord – into the deepest corners of my heart and to the very end of my journey. I rest safely in your hands. Amen.*

DAY 15

# The True Tent and a Better Covenant: Shadow and Reality

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 8:1–13**

1 The main point of what we are saying is this: we have such a high
priest, who took his seat at the right hand of the throne of the Majesty
in the heavens, 2 a minister in the sanctuary and in the true tent, which
the Lord pitched, not a human being. 3 For every high priest is ap-
pointed to offer gifts and sacrifices; so it is necessary for this one too to
have something to offer. 4 Now if he were on earth, he would not even
be a priest, since there are those who offer the gifts according to the law.
5 They worship at a copy and shadow of the heavenly things, just as
Moses was instructed when he was about to complete the tent: "See," he
says, "that you make everything according to the pattern that was
shown you on the mountain." 6 But as it is, he has obtained a ministry
that is as much superior as he is also mediator of a better covenant,
which has been enacted on better promises.

7 For if that first covenant had been faultless, no place would have been
sought for a second. 8 For he finds fault with them when he says:

See, days are coming, says the Lord,
when I will bring about a new covenant
with the house of Israel and with the house of Judah,
9 not like the covenant that I made with their fathers
on the day when I took hold of their hand
to lead them out of the land of Egypt;
for they did not remain in my covenant,
and I disregarded them, says the Lord.
10 For this is the covenant that I will make with the house of Israel
after those days, says the Lord:
I will put my laws into their minds,
and I will write them on their hearts;
and I will be their God,
and they shall be my people.
11 And they shall not teach, each one his fellow citizen
and each one his brother, saying: Know the Lord,
for they shall all know me,

from the least of them to the greatest.
12 For I will be merciful toward their unrighteous deeds,
and I will remember their sins no more.

13 By saying "new", he has made the first one old; and what is becoming old and growing aged is close to disappearing.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

### HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

With chapter 8 we enter the theological climax of the letter to the Hebrews (chapters 8 to 10). In chapter 7 the author showed us that the *person* of our high priest (according to the order of Melchizedek) is infinitely higher than the Levitical priests. Now, in chapter 8, he shifts the focus to the **work and ministry** of this high priest: he ministers in a **better sanctuary** (vv. 1–5) and is the mediator of a **better covenant** enacted on **better promises** (vv. 6–13).

For first-century Jewish Christians it was an enormous emotional struggle to be cut off from the magnificent temple in Jerusalem. Their non-Christian Jewish relatives and neighbours probably mocked them and asked: *"Where is your temple? Where is your visible priest, your altar? You have nothing!"* The author answers this charge by drawing back the veils of the visible world and showing that the earthly temple was never the real thing – it was only a temporary architectural sketch of the true, heavenly reality where Jesus now ministers.

To prove it, the author quotes Exodus 25:40, where God warned Moses on Mount Sinai to build everything exactly "according to the pattern" that was shown him on the mountain (v. 5). Then he gives the longest single Old Testament quotation in the whole New Testament: **Jeremiah 31:31–34** (vv. 8–12). He quotes it as the Greek translation (the Septuagint) has it, and

at one point it differs from the Hebrew: where the Hebrew of Jeremiah 31:32 says "although I was their husband (or master)", the Greek reads "and I disregarded them" (v. 9).

Verse 13 closes with a prophetic remark: what is becoming old and growing aged "is close to disappearing". If the letter was written before AD 70, as many think, the temple in Jerusalem with its sacrifices was indeed "close to disappearing" at the time – and in AD 70 it finally disappeared.

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **The main point (*kephalaion* – κεφάλαιον, v. 1):** The author begins with the word *kephalaion*: the main point, the crowning point or core of the whole argument, not merely a summary. What is this core? "We have such a high priest, who took his seat at the right hand of the throne of the Majesty in the heavens." While the earthly priests had to stand every day because their work was never finished (see Hebrews 10:11), our high priest has sat down.
- **Minister of the true tent (*leitourgos* – λειτουργὸς; *tēs skēnēs tēs alēthinēs* – τῆς σκηνῆς τῆς ἀληθινῆς, v. 2):** Verse 2 calls him "a minister in the sanctuary and in the true tent, which the Lord pitched, not a human being". A *leitourgos* is a public servant who acts in the sanctuary on behalf of the people. The word *skēnē* means "tent" – it is the word for the tabernacle of Moses. In biblical Greek the opposite of "true" (*alēthinos*) here is not "false" or "lying", but *shadowy, provisional*. The tabernacle that Moses set up in the wilderness was good and commanded by God, but it was a temporary replica; the heavenly sanctuary that the Lord himself pitched is the eternal, original reality.
- **Copy, shadow and pattern (*hypodeigmati kai skia* – ὑποδείγματι καὶ σκιᾷ; *typon* – τύπον, v. 5):** On earth Jesus would not even be a priest (v. 4); after all, he was born of the tribe of Judah, not of Levi (7:14). But his ministry does not take place on earth! The Levitical priests only serve "a copy and shadow of the heavenly things" – a *hypodeigma* is a copy or sketch. Moses had to build everything "according to the pattern" (*typos*

– the blueprint, pattern or stamp) shown to him on the mountain. Just as an architect's scale model, or a shadow on the ground, shows that a massive, solid building stands in the sunlight, so the whole Old Testament tent worship pointed ahead to Christ's ministry in heaven.

- **Mediator of a better covenant (*mesitēs* – μεσίτης; *nenomothetētai* – νενομοθέτηται, v. 6):** Jesus' ministry is so far superior because he is "mediator of a better covenant, which has been enacted on better promises". A *mesitēs* is the person who stands between two parties to ratify a peace and an agreement. The verb *nenomothetētai* ("has been enacted") is a word of lawgiving: the covenant has been established with full legal authority on better promises.
- **Faultless? (*amemptos* – ἄμεμπτος; *memphomenos autous* – μεμφόμενος αὐτοὺς, vv. 7–8):** Why was a new covenant needed? Verses 7 and 8 are crystal clear: if the first covenant (the Mosaic covenant at Sinai) had been "faultless" and could really save and change people, God would never have promised a second. And where did the fault lie? Not with God or his holy law, but with broken, sinful people! Look at verse 8: "For he finds fault with **them** when he says." The old covenant demanded: "*Do this and you will live*" (see Leviticus 18:5), but it gave people no inner power to do it.
- **A new covenant (*diathēkēn kainēn* – διαθήκην καινήν, vv. 8 and 13):** For "new" the author uses *kainos* here. It is often distinguished from *neos*: not only new in time, but **new in kind** – fresh and of a completely different quality. (The distinction is not strict; in 12:24 Hebrews also calls the new covenant *nea*.) Why are the promises of the new covenant so infinitely better than those of Sinai? Because God no longer says "*If you …*", but "**I will!**"
- **For (*hoti* – ὅτι), merciful (*hileōs* – ἵλεως) and no more (*ou mē mnēsthō eti* – οὐ μὴ μνησθῶ ἔτι, v. 12):** Notice the little word "For" (*hoti*) at the start of verse 12! Why are inner change and intimate fellowship with God possible? *Because* God promises: "For I will be merciful toward their unrighteous deeds, and I will remember their sins no more."

*Hileōs* means reconciled and gracious. In the Greek there is a double negative, *ou mē mnēsthō eti*: I will **never, ever again** call them to mind against them!

- **Made old (*pepalaiōken* – πεπαλαίωκεν, v. 13):** By speaking of a "new" covenant, God "has made the first one old" (*pepalaiōken* – worn out and obsolete).

### CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

Here are the four great promises of the new covenant (vv. 10–12):

1. **Inner transformation instead of outward tablets of stone (v. 10a).** "I will put my laws into their minds, and I will write them on their hearts." At Sinai the law was engraved from the outside on cold stone, and it could only accuse people. In the new covenant the Holy Spirit engraves God's will from the inside on the soft tablets of our hearts and renews our desires, so that we *want* to do what God asks.
2. **An intimate covenant relationship (v. 10b).** "I will be their God, and they shall be my people." What was broken by Israel's unfaithfulness is restored by Christ so that it can never be broken.
3. **Direct, personal knowledge of God (v. 11).** "For they shall all know me, from the least of them to the greatest." Under the old covenant ordinary people depended on go-betweens – prophets, priests and kings – to know the Lord at a distance, and most members of the nation were unregenerate. In the new covenant every true child of the covenant – from the youngest believer to the oldest – knows the Lord personally and directly through the Spirit.
4. **The foundation of everything: complete and final forgiveness (v. 12).** God will be merciful toward their unrighteous deeds and will remember their sins no more. This is the ground on which all the other promises rest.

## Living It Out

Hebrews 8 touches the deepest nerve of our daily walk with God: **Are you living today under the old covenant of outward pressure, or under the new covenant of inner grace?**

Even though we are New Testament believers, our thoughts often slip back to Sinai without our noticing. We see God's commandments as a cold list of rules outside ourselves ("on tablets of stone"), and then we try, with clenched jaws and sheer willpower, to force ourselves to be good. And every time we stumble, we think God is sitting there with a notebook, digging up all our past failures to punish us. The result is that we keep God at a safe distance, full of guilt and spiritual weariness.

Look today with new eyes at the **better promises** of which Jesus is the mediator for you:

- **From tablets of stone to your heart (v. 10):** Christian holiness is not a matter of trying harder out of fear of punishment; it is the supernatural work of the Spirit, who writes God's love and will from the inside on your mind and heart. When you are struggling with a particular sin or attitude, you do not have to tackle it in your own strength – you may ask the author of the new covenant to engrave his truth more deeply on your heart and to change your desires from within.
- **From an archive of guilt to a clean page (v. 12):** Our human memory (and the accuser) loves to dig up old sins we confessed long ago, like ghosts from the past. But verse 12 says that God chooses **never, ever again** to remember your confessed sins! This does not mean that the all-knowing God suffers memory loss; it means that he promises never again to use your sin against you or to treat you according to your past, because Jesus has paid the debt in full in the true heavenly sanctuary.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Shadow or reality?** Do you sometimes look for your spiritual security in outward forms, rituals and human approval ("shadows"), instead of lifting your eyes to Christ, who now sits as your high priest in the true heavenly sanctuary?
- **Tablets of stone or tablets of the heart?** Do you currently experience God's will for your life as a heavy, outward burden you must try to keep – or do you let the Holy Spirit write God's truth from within on your mind and your love?
- **Do you really believe verse 12?** Is there a particular sin or failure from your past that you have already confessed to the Lord, yet for which you still accuse yourself? What does it mean for your peace today when the King of the universe says: "I will remember their sins no more"?

## Prayer

*Gracious and faithful Father, I praise you that today I do not have to stand at the foot of a smoking mountain of law and judgment, but that through my high priest, Jesus Christ, I may share in a new and infinitely better covenant.*

*Lord Jesus, thank you that you do not minister in an earthly shadow-temple, but sit in the true heavenly tent at the right hand of the Majesty as the mediator of better promises. Forgive me for all the times I still try to live as if I were under the old covenant – when I try to make myself acceptable to you through my own outward strength and willpower.*

*Father, fulfil your precious promise within me today: by your Holy Spirit write your words and your will deep in my mind and on the soft tablets of my heart, so that it becomes my joy to obey you. And thank you for the overwhelming wonder of verse 12 – that because of the blood of Jesus you*

*are merciful toward my unrighteous deeds and will never, ever again remember my sins. Let me live today in the freedom and intimacy of this truth, as someone who knows you personally. Amen.*

DAY 16

# The Earthly Sanctuary: The Limits of the Old Order and the Conscience

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 9:1–10**

1 Now even the first covenant had regulations for worship and an
earthly sanctuary. 2 For a tent was set up, the first one, in which were
the lampstand and the table and the loaves set out; this is called the
Holy Place. 3 Behind the second curtain was a tent called the Most Holy
Place. 4 It had a golden altar of incense and the ark of the covenant, cov-
ered on all sides with gold, in which were a golden jar holding the
manna, and Aaron's staff that had budded, and the tablets of the
covenant. 5 Above it were the cherubim of glory, overshadowing the
atonement cover. Of these things we cannot now speak in detail.

6 With these things set up in this way, the priests go continually into the
first tent to carry out their acts of worship, 7 but into the second only the
high priest goes, once a year, and not without blood, which he offers for
himself and for the sins the people have committed in ignorance. 8 By
this the Holy Spirit makes clear that the way into the sanctuary has not
yet been revealed while the first tent still has standing. 9 This is a symbol
for the present time, according to which gifts and sacrifices are offered
that cannot make the worshipper perfect with respect to conscience,
10 since they deal only with food and drink and various washings – regu-
lations for the flesh, imposed until the time of setting things right.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

At the end of chapter 8 the author declared that with the coming of the new covenant God "has made the first one old" and that it "is close to disappearing". Now, in Hebrews 9:1–10, he takes us on a reverent guided tour

of the Old Testament tabernacle in the wilderness (Exodus 25–40). For his Jewish readers the architecture, the gold and the rituals of the sanctuary were the highest symbol of God's presence on earth. The author does not look down on these things; on the contrary, he describes their splendour with great respect. But he shows that the very design and daily running of the tabernacle carried a built-in message from the Holy Spirit: "**No entry – wait for the Redeemer!**"

The author deliberately focuses on the original wilderness tabernacle of Moses (not on the later temples of Solomon or Herod), because it was the original blueprint. When a priest stepped through the first curtain, he entered the front tent, which is called "the Holy Place". On his left (the south side) stood the seven-branched golden lampstand (*menorah*) that gave light; on his right (the north side) was the table with the twelve loaves, which continually represented the twelve tribes of Israel before God's face.

Further in, screened off by a thick, heavy second curtain, was the innermost, cube-shaped room: the Most Holy Place. According to verse 4 it "had a golden altar of incense and the ark of the covenant". In Exodus 30:6 the incense altar physically stood just *in front of* the curtain in the Holy Place, but theologically and in its function it belonged inseparably to the Most Holy Place: the fragrant smoke was meant to pass through the curtain and fill the Most Holy Place, and on the great Day of Atonement the high priest had to carry the censer right into the Most Holy Place (Leviticus 16:12–13). Inside (or right beside) the ark, "covered on all sides with gold", were three memorials of Israel's history:

- "**A golden jar holding the manna**" (Exodus 16:33) – a reminder of God's faithful provision and of the people's ungrateful grumbling about his bread.
- "**Aaron's staff that had budded**" (Numbers 17:8) – a reminder of God's choice of the priesthood in the midst of the people's rebellion against his authority.

- **"The tablets of the covenant"** (Deuteronomy 10:5) – God's law, which the people had broken. Above the ark were "the cherubim of glory, overshadowing the atonement cover" (v. 5) – the very place where the blood was sprinkled to cover the verdict of the broken law inside the ark!

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

- **An earthly sanctuary (*hagion kosmikon* – ἅγιον κοσμικόν, v. 1):** The first covenant had "regulations for worship" (*dikaiōmata latreias* – δικαιώματα λατρείας) "and an earthly sanctuary". The Greek word *kosmikon* does not mean "sinful" or "worldly-minded" here, but **earthly, material, part of this created, physical cosmos** (in contrast to the heavenly sanctuary of 8:2 and 9:11).
- **The Holy Place (*Hagia* – Ἅγια) and the loaves set out (*hē prothesis tōn artōn* – ἡ πρόθεσις τῶν ἄρτων, v. 2):** In the first tent were "the lampstand and the table and the loaves set out; this is called the Holy Place". Literally the Greek speaks of the setting out of the loaves.
- **The second curtain (*katapetasma* – καταπέτασμα) and the Most Holy Place (*Hagia Hagiōn* – Ἅγια Ἁγίων, v. 3):** "Behind the second curtain was a tent called the Most Holy Place."
- **Altar of incense (*thymiatērion* – θυμιατήριον, v. 4):** The word can mean the altar of incense, but in the Greek Old Testament also a censer. The author says the inner tent "had" it – it belonged to it (see above).
- **Atonement cover (*hilastērion* – ἱλαστήριον, v. 5):** The golden lid of the ark, in Hebrew *kapporet* – the place where the high priest sprinkled the blood on the Day of Atonement.
- **Sins committed in ignorance (*agnoēmatōn* – ἀγνοημάτων, v. 7):** The ordinary priests went into the first tent continually to tend the lamps, burn incense and replace the bread – and the ordinary people were not even allowed in there! But "into the second only the high priest goes, once a year, and not without blood": only *one man*, only on one day of

the year (*Yom Kippur*, the great Day of Atonement), and only with blood, to make atonement for himself and for "the sins the people have committed in ignorance". *Agnoēmata* are sins committed out of human weakness and error, in contrast to defiant, arrogant rebellion, for which there was no sacrifice under the law (see Numbers 15:30).

- **A symbol (*parabolē* – παραβολὴ, v. 9):** What did the Holy Spirit teach through this strict architectural separation? Verse 8 gives the answer: "the way into the sanctuary has not yet been revealed while the first tent still has standing". The whole earthly tabernacle system with its heavy curtains cried out that a barrier still stood between a holy God and sinful people. It is "a symbol for the present time" (*parabolē* – from which we get our word "parable": an object lesson or illustration).
- **The conscience (*kata syneidēsin* – κατὰ συνείδησιν, v. 9):** And where did the great shortcoming of all those animal sacrifices and gifts lie? Verse 9 goes to the heart of it: they "cannot make the worshipper perfect with respect to conscience". The Greek word for conscience, *syneidēsis* (literally "knowing together with oneself"), refers to our inner moral awareness that knows we stand guilty before a holy God.
- **Regulations for the flesh (*dikaiōmata sarkos* – δικαιώματα σαρκὸς) and washings (*baptismois* – βαπτισμοῖς, v. 10):** The Old Testament rules about "food and drink and various washings" were only "regulations for the flesh". They could cleanse your *outside* (your body) ceremonially, so that you were allowed back into the camp of Israel, but they could never reach your *inside* to wash the stain of guilt from your soul!
- **The time of setting things right (*kairou diorthōseōs* – καιροῦ διορθώσεως, v. 10):** These were only temporary measures, "imposed until the time of setting things right". The word *diorthōsis* was used, among other things, for setting a broken bone or for the radical reform of a broken system. With the coming of Christ that great *diorthōsis* – the new order that sets everything straight – has finally dawned!

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **God is holy, and sinful people do not have access to him in themselves.** The whole design of the tabernacle – two tents, a thick curtain, one man, once a year, never without blood – made this truth visible.
2. **The tabernacle was a lesson from the Holy Spirit.** As long as the first tent still had standing, the way into God's presence had not yet been revealed. The old order itself pointed ahead to the one who would open the way.
3. **Outward religion cannot cleanse the conscience.** Sacrifices, gifts, food laws and washings touch only the flesh; the guilt of the heart remains untouched.
4. **Even under the old covenant God provided in grace.** Between the holy presence of God and the law the people had broken lay the atonement cover with the blood – a pointer to Christ and to the time of setting things right that has dawned in him.

## Living It Out

Hebrews 9:1–10 forces us to look honestly at one of the deepest human problems that every person on earth struggles with: **a guilty and restless conscience (*syneidēsis*).**

Think of how people today (and even we as believers) try to silence a nagging conscience. We may no longer have a physical tabernacle with bulls and goats, but we create our own "regulations for the flesh" and "first-tent rituals" (vv. 9–10). When we feel guilty about our shortcomings, we try to make up for it with outward religious activity: we give a little more money, we do charitable work, we make new resolutions, or we punish ourselves with days of self-reproach.

But just as soap and water can only wash the mud off your hands and can never erase a lie or a selfish act from your past, no outward religious effort can ever cleanse your conscience before God. You keep feeling as if a thick

"curtain" hangs between you and the Father, and that you must keep a safe distance in the outer court.

This passage prepares our hearts to embrace the glory of Christ (which we will read about tomorrow in vv. 11–14) with tears of gratitude:

- **Admit the bankruptcy of outward religion:** Stop trying to buy your soul's peace with outward duties that touch only the "flesh". Admit that no human repetition of good works can erase the guilt of the past.
- **See how God already provided for grace under the old covenant:** Look again at verses 4 and 5. Inside the ark of the covenant lay the reminders of human sin (the stone tablets of the law the people had broken, Aaron's staff as a sign against the rebellion against his priesthood, the jar of manna recalling the grumbling about the bread). Had God's holy eyes looked directly on that sin in the ark, the people would have been consumed. But *between* the eyes of the cherubim and the law in the ark lay the **atonement cover (*hilastērion*)** with the blood on it! In Christ the Father no longer looks at the archive of your failures; he looks at you through the atonement cover of his Son's blood!

#### QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Are you still living in front of a closed curtain?** Does your relationship with God sometimes still feel like the old tabernacle – as if he were hidden far away behind thick curtains and you could only communicate with him from a distance through dutiful rituals?
- **How do you deal with a restless conscience?** When your conscience (*syneidēsis*) accuses you of a fault or sin, which outward "washings" or efforts of your own do you often use to make yourself feel better, instead of going to the atonement cover of Christ?
- **The time of setting things right (*diorthōsis*):** Which area of your spiritual thinking has grown "crooked" through legalism and needs the Lord to set it straight today through the truth of the new covenant?

## Prayer

*Holy and triune God, with deep reverence I reflect today on the beauty and holiness of your ancient tabernacle. Every piece of gold, every curtain and every sacrifice bore witness to your spotless purity and showed us how serious my sin is in your eyes.*

*Lord, I confess today that no outward religious ritual, no good resolution and no effort of my own hands can ever make my conscience fully clean before you. Like the objects inside the ark of the covenant, my own history often testifies to broken commandments and ingratitude. If you were to judge me by my own works, I could never stand before you.*

*But I praise you that the time of setting things right has dawned in Jesus Christ! Thank you that the shadows have given way to the full sunlight of your grace, and that Jesus himself has become my atonement cover, covering all my transgressions before your holy eyes. Set my heart free today from all dead, formal religion, and prepare me to understand and receive the full power of Christ's precious blood for my conscience. Amen.*

DAY 17

# Through His Own Blood: Eternal Redemption and a Cleansed Conscience

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 9:11–14**

11 But when Christ came as high priest of the good things that have
come, through the greater and more perfect tent, not made with hands,
that is, not of this creation, 12 not through the blood of goats and calves
but through his own blood, he entered the sanctuary once for all and
obtained eternal redemption. 13 For if the blood of goats and bulls and
the sprinkled ashes of a heifer make holy those who have been defiled,
so that their flesh is clean, 14 how much more will the blood of Christ,
who through the eternal Spirit offered himself without blemish to God,
cleanse our conscience from dead works to worship the living God!

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Yesterday (Hebrews 9:1–10) we saw that the Old Testament tent, with its heavy curtains, restricted access and outward animal sacrifices, was really a visual illustration of a problem not yet solved: the way into God's presence was still closed, and no sacrifice could fully cleanse the worshipper's **conscience** (*syneidēsis* – συνείδησις).

But then verse 11 breaks open with two of the most powerful words in the Bible: "**But Christ …**" (*Christos de* – Χριστὸς δὲ). In the original Greek, verses 11 to 14 form two mighty, tightly woven sentences that sum up the heart of the New Testament teaching on atonement. Where the earthly high priest on the Day of Atonement walked through earthly curtains

with the blood of an animal to obtain only a temporary, outward covering, Christ steps onto the stage as the High Priest who replaces the shadows for ever with the eternal reality.

Behind these verses stand two Old Testament rituals. The first is *Yom Kippur*, the Day of Atonement (Leviticus 16). On that day Aaron had to go behind the curtain more than once: with the incense, with the blood of a bull for his own sins, and with the blood of a goat for the sins of the people. And twelve months later he had to do it all over again. The second is "**the sprinkled ashes of a heifer**" (Numbers 19). When an Israelite became ritually unclean by touching a dead body, the ashes of a burnt red heifer were mixed with running water and sprinkled on the person with hyssop. That sprinkling was enough to declare the person outwardly clean again, so that he could return to the community gathered around the tent.

In verses 13 and 14 the author again uses the rabbinic *qal wahomer* argument (from the lesser to the greater): *if* this was true of animal blood, *how much more* of the blood of Christ!

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

The Greek terms in these four verses are full of theological treasure:

- **"Came" (*paragenomenos* – παραγενόμενος, v. 11):** Christ *"came as high priest of the good things that have come"*. *Paragenomenos* means that he appeared on the stage of history. Our base text reads *tōn genomenōn agathōn* (τῶν γενομένων ἀγαθῶν), "the good things that have come"; older translations read "the good things to come" (*mellontōn*, as in 10:1). Both say something true: these are the good things that the Old Testament looked forward to as future, but which have now dawned in the messianic age.
- **"Not made with hands" (*ou cheiropoiētou* – οὐ χειροποιήτου, v. 11):** Christ did not pass through an earthly tent of goats' hair and acacia wood, but *"through the greater and more perfect tent, not made with*

*hands*". It is *"not of this creation"* (*ou tautēs tēs ktiseōs* – οὐ ταύτης τῆς κτίσεως): it does not belong to this present, physical creation at all, but refers to the heavenly throne room of God himself.

- **"Through his own blood" (*dia de tou idiou haimatos* – διὰ δὲ τοῦ ἰδίου αἵματος, v. 12):** Christ did not come with the blood of defenceless animals that did not even know why they were dying; he entered *"through his own blood"*!
- **"Once for all" (*ephapax* – ἐφάπαξ, v. 12):** *"He entered the sanctuary once for all"* – once and never again, unrepeatable and final.
- **"Eternal redemption" (*aiōnian lytrōsin* – αἰωνίαν λύτρωσιν, v. 12):** The Greek word *lytrōsis* refers to buying the freedom of a slave or prisoner of war by paying a costly ransom (*lytron* – λύτρον). In the whole Old Testament there was only a *yearly* atonement on the Day of Atonement; Christ *"obtained eternal redemption"*, whose value never expires!
- **"So that their flesh is clean" (*hagiazei pros tēn tēs sarkos katharotēta* – ἁγιάζει πρὸς τὴν τῆς σαρκὸς καθαρότητα, v. 13):** The blood and the ashes made the defiled holy *"so that their flesh is clean"* – an outward, ritual cleanness.
- **"Without blemish" (*amōmon* – ἄμωμον, v. 14):** A sacrificial lamb had to be physically without defect; Jesus was morally and spiritually flawless.
- **"Through the eternal Spirit" (*dia pneumatos aiōniou* – διὰ πνεύματος αἰωνίου, v. 14):** Because the offering was made through the *eternal* Spirit, its effect is *eternal*.
- **"From dead works" (*apo nekrōn ergōn* – ἀπὸ νεκρῶν ἔργων, v. 14):** "Dead works" are works that come from a spiritually dead condition and lead to death – our sin and our own self-righteous efforts.
- **"To worship the living God" (*eis to latreuein theō zōnti* – εἰς τὸ λατρεύειν θεῷ ζῶντι, v. 14):** *Latreuō* (λατρεύω) means to worship and serve with joyful priestly devotion.

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Christ is the High Priest of the heavenly sanctuary.** He did not enter an earthly tent but the reality itself, the throne room of God, of which the tabernacle was only a shadow.
2. **His sacrifice is once for all, and his redemption is eternal.** Where Aaron had to return year after year, Christ entered once for all, through his own blood, and obtained eternal redemption.
3. **The whole Trinity works together for our salvation.** Look closely at how the whole **Trinity** works together in verse 14: - **The Son:** *"the blood of Christ, who ... offered himself without blemish"*. - **The Spirit:** He offered himself *"through the eternal Spirit"*. It was the Holy Spirit who anointed, carried and strengthened Jesus throughout his earthly ministry, so that he gave his life on the cross in perfect, eternal self-giving love (cf. Isaiah 42:1; 61:1). - **The Father:** He offered himself "to God", to satisfy the righteous demand of God's holiness.
4. **Christ's blood cleanses the conscience for service.** And what is the result of this saving act of the triune God? It cleanses our **conscience** from **dead works**! Just as an Israelite who had touched a corpse (Numbers 19) had to be cleansed with the ashes of the red heifer before he could worship again, so our conscience is defiled by our sin and by our own self-righteous efforts. Christ's blood washes us clean deep within our soul and frees us from guilt and from anxious attempts to save ourselves, so that we are set free for our true calling: *"to worship the living God"*.

## Living It Out

Hebrews 9:11–14 cuts to the root of why so many Christians today live without joy and power. The problem is a **defiled conscience** that we try to clean with **dead works**.

What are "dead works" in everyday life? Not only obvious sins. In the context of Hebrews they are also all those pious, religious things we do with the secret motive of making up for our sins or making ourselves "acceptable" to God again. When you have sinned or fallen short and your conscience accuses you, your natural human reaction is to "do penance": you feel extra bad about yourself for a few days, you promise to try harder, or you try to drown your guilt in busyness. But that is like touching a dead body – it only leaves you more spiritually exhausted and unclean, because you are trusting in *your* sweat instead of *his* blood.

Hear today the liberating message of the "*how much more*" in verse 14:

- **The power of his blood is stronger than the stain of your guilt.** There is no sin in your past, no failure in your present and no accusation of the enemy that can withstand the spotless blood of Christ, offered through the eternal Spirit. If God the Father was fully satisfied with that sacrifice, who are you to keep accusing yourself?
- **Cleansed to serve, not to earn.** Notice the order at the end of verse 14. We do not serve the living God *so that* our conscience may be cleansed; our conscience is first cleansed by his blood *so that* we may serve him freely (*latreuein*)! When the heavy backpack of guilt and self-reproach falls from your shoulders, serving God and your neighbour is no longer a heavy slave's duty but a grateful response of love to the living God.

### QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **What do "dead works" look like in your life?** What specific things do you sometimes do out of guilt, fear or duty to try to quiet your own conscience, instead of bringing your guilt directly under the blood of Jesus?
- **The "how much more" test:** Do you sometimes struggle to forgive yourself for something you have already confessed to the Lord? Do you realise that holding on to that guilt is really saying that Christ's blood was not enough to wash your conscience clean?

- **Free service to the living God (*latreuein*):** How would your attitude to your daily calling, your family and your prayer life change today if you woke up with the firm knowledge that your conscience is 100% clean and free before God?

## Prayer

> *Living and holy God, I thank you for the two most wonderful words in the gospel: "But Christ!" Where I and all my religious efforts were completely powerless to wash the stain of sin from my soul, my great High Priest came and did what I could never do.*
>
> *Lord Jesus, I bow in deep worship before the worth of your precious blood. Thank you that you entered the heavenly sanctuary once for all, not with the blood of goats or calves but with your own spotless blood, and obtained eternal redemption for me. Thank you that through the eternal Spirit you offered yourself without blemish to the Father.*
>
> *Today I bring you my conscience – with all its old accusations, its regrets and its exhausting "dead works" – and I place it once again under the power of your blood. Wash me clean and quiet within today. Set me free from the slavery of trying to earn your favour, so that today I may worship and serve you, the living God, with a clean conscience, a light heart and joyful gratitude. Amen.*

DAY 18

# The Will and the Blood: Offered Once to Bear the Sins of Many

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 9:15–28**

15 And for this reason he is mediator of a new covenant, so that, since a
death has taken place for redemption from the transgressions commit-
ted under the first covenant, those who are called may receive the prom-
ise of the eternal inheritance. 16 For where there is a will, the death of
the one who made it must be established. 17 For a will takes effect only at
death, since it is never in force while the one who made it is alive. 18 That
is why not even the first covenant was inaugurated without blood. 19 For
when every commandment had been spoken by Moses to all the people
according to the law, he took the blood of the calves with water and
scarlet wool and hyssop, and sprinkled both the book itself and all the
people, 20 saying: "This is the blood of the covenant that God has com-
manded for you." 21 In the same way he sprinkled with the blood the tent
and all the vessels used in the ministry. 22 Indeed, according to the law
almost everything is cleansed with blood, and without the shedding of
blood there is no forgiveness.

23 So it was necessary for the copies of the things in the heavens to be
cleansed with these, but the heavenly things themselves with better sac-
rifices than these. 24 For Christ did not enter a sanctuary made with
hands, a counterpart of the true one, but into heaven itself, now to ap-
pear in the presence of God on our behalf. 25 Nor did he enter to offer
himself again and again, as the high priest enters the sanctuary year by
year with blood that is not his own; 26 for then he would have had to suf-
fer again and again since the foundation of the world. But as it is, he has
been revealed once at the end of the ages to set aside sin by his sacrifice.
27 And just as it is in store for human beings to die once, and after that
comes judgment, 28 so Christ also, having been offered once to bear the
sins of many, will appear a second time, apart from sin, to those who ea-
gerly wait for him, for salvation.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

### HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In yesterday's devotional (Hebrews 9:11–14) we saw how Christ's precious blood does something no animal sacrifice could ever do: it reaches into our innermost being and cleanses our conscience from dead works, so that we can freely worship the living God. But that still leaves the old, nagging question in the minds of the first-century Jewish readers: *Why did the Messiah have to die at all*? Could an almighty God not simply have declared by royal decree that our sins are forgiven, without the cruel scandal of a bloody cross?

In Hebrews 9:15–28 the author gives a masterly answer to this question. He explains the unshakeable divine necessity of Jesus' substitutionary death by weaving two images seamlessly together: the legal concept of a **will** or testament (vv. 15–17) and the Old Testament **consecration with blood at Sinai** (vv. 18–22). He then lets both lead into the **three wonderful "appearings" of Christ** in verses 24 to 28.

For the second image the author goes back to Exodus 24:3–8, when the first covenant was inaugurated at the foot of Mount Sinai. After Moses had read out the commandments, he took the blood of the sacrificial animals and sprinkled the altar and the people with it (Hebrews 9:19 adds the book itself), saying solemnly: *"This is the blood of the covenant that God has commanded for you."* These are almost the same words that Jesus applied to himself at the last Passover in the upper room: "This is my blood of the covenant" (Matthew 26:28; in Luke 22:20 he speaks of the new covenant in his blood)!

Why all this blood on the book, the people and the vessels of the tent? Because Leviticus 17:11 teaches that the life (*nefesh*) of the flesh is in the blood.

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us dig into the riches of the Greek terms:

- **"Covenant" and "will" (*diathēkē* – διαθήκη, vv. 15–17):** In the Greek New Testament the same word, *diathēkē*, is used for both "covenant" and "will" (testament). That is why our translation renders it "will" in verses 16–17, and "covenant" before and after. While the Hebrew word for covenant (*berit*) refers to a solemn treaty between two parties, in everyday legal Greek a *diathēkē* was a last will and testament by which someone left his inheritance (*klēronomia* – κληρονομία) to his heirs. The author uses this play on words to powerful effect: because Jesus wanted to leave *"the promise of the eternal inheritance"* to *"those who are called"* (v. 15), the covenant also works like a will.
- **"The one who made it" ... "established" (*ho diathemenos* – ὁ διαθέμενος; *pheresthai* – φέρεσθαι, vv. 16–17):** As long as the one who made the will (*ho diathemenos*) is alive, the document is only a promise on paper; it comes into effect only when the death of the testator is *"established"*. The verb *pheresthai* (from *pherō*, "bring, carry") means here that the death must be brought forward as evidence, that is, proven. For *"a will takes effect only at death, since it is never in force while the one who made it is alive"*.
- **"Inaugurated" (*enkainizō* – ἐγκαινίζω, v. 18):** *"Not even the first covenant was inaugurated without blood"*: it was formally opened and ratified.
- **"Shedding of blood" and "forgiveness" (*chōris haimatekchysias* – χωρὶς αἱματεκχυσίας; *aphesis* – ἄφεσις, v. 22):** Verse 22 sums up the whole Old Testament sacrificial system in one unbending spiritual law: *"without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness"*. *Aphesis* means release or cancellation of a debt.
- **"To set aside sin" (*eis athetēsin hamartias* – εἰς ἀθέτησιν ἁμαρτίας, v. 26):** The word *athetēsis* (ἀθέτησις), which we also met in 7:18, means to annul something, declare it void, remove it from office.

- **Three words for "appear" (*pephanerōtai* – πεφανέρωται; *emphanisthēnai* – ἐμφανισθῆναι; *ophthēsetai* – ὀφθήσεται, vv. 24–28):** Verses 24 to 28 paint the full panorama of salvation history with three Greek verbs for appearing or being revealed – past, present and future (see below). The word *emphanizō* (ἐμφανίζω) also has a legal ring: in Acts 24:1 and 25:2 it is used of those who bring a case before the governor.
- **"To bear" (*anenenkein* – ἀνενεγκεῖν, v. 28):** Christ was offered once "to *bear the sins of many*" – an echo of Isaiah 53:12.
- **"Who eagerly wait for him" (*apekdechomenois* – ἀπεκδεχομένοις, v. 28):** The verb means to wait for someone with outstretched longing.

### CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **A will requires a death.** Christ did not merely write down an eternal inheritance for us, as it were; he himself died on the cross so that his will could come into effect immediately and irrevocably in our favour – and then he rose from the dead to be the executor of his own will!
2. **Without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness.** Sin is not a small mistake that can be ignored with a smile; it is high treason against a holy God, and its wages are death. Forgiveness requires that a substitute life be laid down so that the guilty life can be acquitted.
3. **The heavenly things themselves were cleansed by a better sacrifice.** In verse 23 the author says that "*the heavenly things themselves with better sacrifices than these*" had to be cleansed. How can the perfect heaven need "cleansing"? Heaven itself is not dirty. But because sinful people are called to enter God's holy presence, our transgressions had to be wiped out before God's judgement seat, so that the heavenly throne room might be open to us.
4. **Christ's three "appearings" span past, present and future. - His appearing in the past – to set aside sin (v. 26):** "*But as it is, he has been revealed once at the end of the ages to set aside sin by his sacrifice.*" At the

cross – the turning point and climax of world history – Jesus finally dethroned the power and guilt of sin. - **His appearing in the present – before God's face for us (v. 24):** Christ entered heaven itself, *"now to appear in the presence of God on our behalf"*. The picture is that of an advocate who appears before the judge on behalf of his client. At this very moment our glorified High Priest stands with his pierced hands before the Father's face as our living Advocate! - **His appearing in the future – for salvation (vv. 27–28):** Just as every human being is destined to die *once* (*hapax* – ἅπαξ) and after that to face God's judgement, so Christ was offered *once* to take the sins of many upon himself. That is why he *"will appear a second time, apart from sin, to those who eagerly wait for him, for salvation"*. At his first coming he carried our sin on his shoulders; at his return he does not come again to pay for sin, for that debt has been settled once and for all – he comes to lead those who long for him into their full, glorified redemption!

## Living It Out

Hebrews 9:15–28 gives you an unshakeable threefold anchor for **your past, your present and your future**.

First, look at **your past** through the lens of the cross (vv. 15–22, 26). Perhaps you are troubled today by guilt over mistakes from your "early days", or you think your sin is too great to be truly forgiven. Hear the unbending justice and the grace of verses 22 and 26: God did not cheaply sweep your sin under the carpet where it could seep out again later. A real death took place! The eternal Son of God shed his blood so that your sin is legally *declared void* (*athetēsis*). And because the testator has died (vv. 16–17), no one can ever contest or cancel your inheritance as a child of God – it is sealed with his blood.

Second, look at **your present** through the lens of the heavenly throne room (v. 24). When you pray today, or when you stumble in your daily work and struggles and feel unworthy to come to God, remember what is

happening in heaven *now*: Christ appears *"now … in the presence of God on our behalf"*. You do not stand alone before the face of a holy God; your Advocate and High Priest appears there for you. When the Father looks at you, he sees his beloved Son interceding for you.

Third, look at **your future** through the lens of his return (vv. 27–28). For the world outside Christ, death and the judgement that follows (v. 27) are the greatest imaginable terror. But why do you as a believer not need to fear verse 27? Because verse 28 follows immediately: *"just as … so Christ also"*! Because Christ has already borne your "dying once" and your judgement on the cross, the future changes for you from a terrifying courtroom into a joyful expectation of your Bridegroom and King, who returns to complete your redemption!

### QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Are you living as an heir of the will?** Do you realise that Jesus' death has irrevocably brought the will of God's grace into effect – or are you still living like a spiritual beggar who doubts whether the promises really belong to you?
- **The three "appearings" in your heart:** Which of Christ's three appearings do you most need to remember today: that he *has already been revealed* to wipe out your guilt (past), that he *now appears* before the Father to intercede for you (present), or that he *will appear again* to make all things new (future)?
- **Eager expectation (*apekdechomai* – ἀπεκδέχομαι):** Verse 28 describes believers simply as *"those who eagerly wait for him"*. When you look at your daily priorities and conversations, are you living with a living, hopeful expectation of Jesus' return – or have you become too comfortable in this passing world?

## Prayer

*Holy and righteous Father, today I bow in deep awe before the seriousness of my sin and the infinite price of my redemption. Your Word teaches me that without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness, and I thank you that you gave your own Son to pay the full ransom for my transgressions.*

*Lord Jesus, thank you that by your death on the cross you sealed with your own blood the new covenant of God's grace, so that today I may have an inalienable share in the eternal inheritance. I praise you for your threefold work of grace: thank you that you were revealed once at the end of the ages on Golgotha to set aside my sin for ever; thank you that at this very moment you appear for me in heaven itself before the Father's face as my living High Priest; and thank you for the blessed promise that you will appear a second time to take me fully to yourself.*

*Take every fear of death and judgement out of my heart today, because you have already borne my judgement on the cross. Wake my heart, so that today I may live as one who looks forward to your coming with joy, watchfulness and eager longing. Amen.*

DAY 19

# One Sacrifice for All Time: The Perfect Obedience That Makes Holy

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 10:1–18**

[1] For the law has only a shadow of the good things to come, not the very
form of the realities. So it can never, by the same sacrifices that they of-
fer continually year after year, make perfect those who approach.
[2] Otherwise, would they not have stopped being offered? For the wor-
shippers, once cleansed, would no longer have any sins on their con-
science. [3] But in these sacrifices there is a reminder of sins year after
year. [4] For it is impossible for the blood of bulls and goats to take away
sins.

[5] Therefore, when he comes into the world, he says:

Sacrifice and offering you did not want,
but a body you have prepared for me;
[6] in burnt offerings and sin offerings
you took no pleasure.
[7] Then I said: See, I have come –
in the scroll of the book it is written of me –
to do your will, O God.

[8] Above he says: "Sacrifices and offerings and burnt offerings and sin of-
ferings you did not want, nor did you take pleasure in them" – these are
offered according to the law. [9] Then he has said: "See, I have come to do
your will." He takes away the first in order to establish the second. [10] By
this will we have been made holy through the offering of the body of
Jesus Christ once for all.

[11] Every priest stands day after day ministering and offering again and
again the same sacrifices, which can never take away sins. [12] But this one
offered one sacrifice for sins for all time and took his seat at the right
hand of God, [13] and from then on he waits until his enemies are made a
footstool for his feet. [14] For by one offering he has made perfect for all
time those who are made holy. [15] And the Holy Spirit also testifies to us;
for after saying:

[16] This is the covenant that I will make with them
after those days, says the Lord:

I will put my laws on their hearts,
and I will write them on their minds,
17 and their sins and their lawless deeds
I will remember no more.

18 Where there is forgiveness of these, there is no longer any offering for sin.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

### HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

With Hebrews 10:1–18 we reach the closing chord of the great doctrinal exposition of Christ as High Priest that began in chapter 5. The author now ties all the golden threads of his argument – about the tent, the priesthood, the covenant and the sacrificial blood – into one irrefutable conclusion: **Christ's once-for-all sacrifice on the cross accomplished everything that the centuries-long Old Testament sacrificial system could never achieve.**

For a Jewish believer who had grown up with the impressive rituals of the temple – the thousands of lambs at Passover, the morning and evening sacrifices and the solemn Day of Atonement – it was almost unthinkable that the whole system should come to an end. But the author shows that the endless repetition of those sacrifices was the very proof of their built-in powerlessness. If a medicine really cures a disease, you stop taking the pills; the fact that you have to keep taking them year after year shows that it only manages the symptoms without curing the cause.

To show that God himself never intended animal sacrifices to be the final solution, the author quotes David's words from Psalm 40:6–8 (40:7–9 in the Hebrew; in the Greek Septuagint it is Psalm 39) and places them directly in the mouth of the Son as he came into the world in his incarnation. In the Hebrew text of Psalm 40:6 it literally says: "Ears you have dug

for me" (to listen obediently). The Greek text that Hebrews quotes reads: *"but a body you have prepared for me"* – possibly a figure of speech in which the part (the ears) stands for the whole (the body).

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

The author's choice of words opens up the insights of this passage:

- **"Shadow" versus "form" (*skia* – σκιά; *eikōn* – εἰκών, v. 1):** In verse 1 the author draws a fine distinction: the law has *"only a shadow of the good things to come, not the very form of the realities"*. A *skia* is a flat, dark outline on the ground with no life or depth, whereas an *eikōn* represents the three-dimensional, tangible reality and form itself.
- **"Take away" (*aphaireō* – ἀφαιρέω, v. 4):** *"For it is impossible for the blood of bulls and goats to take away sins."*
- **"Sins on their conscience" and "reminder" (*syneidēsin hamartiōn* – συνείδησιν ἁμαρτιῶν; *anamnēsis* – ἀνάμνησις, vv. 2–3):** Instead of wiping out the sense of guilt, so that the worshippers *"would no longer have any sins on their conscience"*, every Day of Atonement worked more like an annual direct-debit notice: *"in these sacrifices there is a reminder of sins year after year"*. The people were reminded that their debt was still outstanding!
- **"Prepared" (*katērtisō* – κατηρτίσω, v. 5):** *"But a body you have prepared for me."* God prepared a body for the Son and made it ready for his task.
- **"Take away" and "establish" (*anaireō* – ἀναιρέω; *stēsē* – στήσῃ, v. 9):** With the words *"See, I have come to do your will"*, Christ abolishes the first system (*anaireō* – to take away or abolish), as verse 9 says: *"He takes away the first in order to establish the second."*
- **"Once for all" (*ephapax* – ἐφάπαξ, v. 10):** We have been made holy *"through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all"*.
- **"Stands" and "take away" (*hestēken* – ἕστηκεν; *perielein* – περιελεῖν, v. 11):** The earthly priests **stand** day after day, caught in an exhausting routine of sacrifices *"which can never take away sins"*. *Perielein* literally

means "take away from around", like a dirty garment that is taken right off and thrown away.

- **"Took his seat" (*ekathisen* – ἐκάθισεν, v. 12):** After a single sacrifice Jesus **took his seat** at the right hand of God! The phrase *eis to diēnekes* (εἰς τὸ διηνεκὲς, "for all time") can go in Greek with "offered" or with "took his seat"; our translation takes it with the sacrifice, as in verse 14. Both readings stress the same finality.
- **Two tenses side by side (*teteleiōken* – τετελείωκεν; *tous hagiazomenous* – τοὺς ἁγιαζομένους, v. 14):** "*For by one offering he has made perfect for all time those who are made holy.*" *Teteleiōken* ("he has made perfect") is a perfect tense: a position before God that is already settled. *Tous hagiazomenous* ("those who are made holy") is a present participle: our daily process of growth – we are being made holy.
- **"Forgiveness" (*aphesis* – ἄφεσις, v. 18):** The final legal verdict in verse 18 uses the word for release or cancellation of a debt: "*Where there is forgiveness of these, there is no longer any offering for sin.*"

### CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The shadow could never replace the reality.** Because animal blood stands on a completely different moral and spiritual level from human beings (animals have no moral awareness and cannot willingly choose to suffer in a person's place), the blood of bulls and goats could never really take away sins.
2. **God seeks a body that does his will, not mere rituals.** God never wanted mere mechanical rituals and the slaughter of unwilling animals; he required a human life of complete, loving obedience. That is why Jesus says: "*See, I have come … to do your will, O God.*" And verse 10 gives the glorious result: through the willing obedience of the Son to the Father's will we have been made holy through the offering of Jesus' body, **once for all**.

3. **The seated King-Priest has finished his work.** In verses 11 and 12 the author paints an unforgettable contrast between the standing priests and Jesus, who took his seat. His sitting down is the exclamation mark behind the "*It is finished!*" of Golgotha. And verse 14 beautifully sums up the paradox of the Christian life: your righteous standing before God is already 100% perfect and settled, while the Spirit is now at work day by day to bring your way of life into line with your already perfect status!
4. **The Holy Spirit seals it: no further sacrifice is needed.** To close his whole argument, the author calls the Holy Spirit himself as chief witness and once more quotes the core promises of Jeremiah 31 (which he began in chapter 8): the law on the heart and the assurance that "*their sins and their lawless deeds I will remember no more*". The account is closed, the receipt is stamped, and the altar of self-atonement has been torn down for ever.

## Living It Out

Hebrews 10:1–18 pulls the rug out from under one of our biggest spiritual traps: the temptation to **set up our own little "side altars" next to the cross of Christ.**

When we have messed up in daily life, our human pride finds it very hard simply to go to the Lord and, on the basis of verses 14 and 18, receive full and immediate forgiveness. We feel we must first "do penance" for a while. We walk around for days with a heavy heart, deny ourselves joy, or try to make up for our failure with extra religious zeal. We think this is humility, but in reality it is unbelief! If verse 18 says that "*there is no longer any offering for sin*", then every attempt on your part to pay for your sin by punishing yourself is an insult to the sufficiency of Jesus' once-for-all sacrifice.

Further, verses 5 to 9 teach us a profound lesson about what God is really looking for in our daily lives: **not mere outward religious rituals, but a body willing to do his will.** It is so easy to give God "sacrifices and offer-

ings" – to go to church on Sundays, give a donation or say a quick prayer – while keeping our own will and our own kingdom intact for the rest of the week. But just as Jesus made his physical body available with the words *"See, I have come to do your will"*, Romans 12:1 and Hebrews 10 call us to put our everyday bodies, our time, our work and our family life at his disposal as a living offering of thanks.

Finally, live today in the peace of the balance of verse 14: you do not need to lose heart when you see how much growth ("those who are made holy") still has to happen in your character, because in God's eyes you already stand **perfect for all time** through Christ's one sacrifice ("he has made perfect for all time").

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Sin-consciousness or forgiveness-consciousness?** Are you still walking around with a constant, paralysing sense of guilt (v. 2) about things you have already confessed – or are you resting in the knowledge that Christ has taken away your sin for ever like an old garment (*perielein*)?
- **Rituals or obedience?** Do you sometimes try to make up with outward religious duties ("sacrifices and offerings") for an area of your life where you are really refusing to say with Christ: *"See, I have come … to do your will, O God"* (v. 7)?
- **Perfect and still growing (v. 14):** How does knowing that your position before God is already *perfect for all time* in Christ give you the confidence and energy to work wholeheartedly with the Spirit today at your daily growth in holiness?

## Prayer

> *Heavenly Father, today I stand amazed at the perfection of your plan of redemption. Where no human effort and no thousands of sacrifices could ever wipe out the stain of guilt from my soul, you yourself have opened the way.*

*Lord Jesus, I thank you that you came in obedience to the Father and, with the body prepared for you, paid the full price on the cross. Thank you that you no longer have to stand like an earthly priest whose work is never done, but that after your one perfect sacrifice you took your seat at the right hand of God. I praise you that through that one sacrifice I am made perfect for all time before the Father, while your Spirit makes me holy day by day.*

*Forgive me when, through my own self-reproach and penance, I still try to add something to your work on the cross, as if your blood were not enough. Because there is now full forgiveness, I lay down today every "offering" of my own for guilt. Take my life, my body and my will into your service again today; let the song of my heart be: Here I am to do your will, O God! Amen.*

DAY 20

# The New and Living Way: Let Us Approach with Confidence and Hold Fast

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 10:19–25**

19 So, brothers and sisters, since we have confidence to enter the sanctuary by the blood of Jesus, 20 by the new and living way that he inaugurated for us through the curtain, that is, his flesh, 21 and since we have a great priest over the house of God, 22 let us approach with a true heart in full assurance of faith, with our hearts sprinkled clean from an evil conscience and our bodies washed with pure water. 23 Let us hold fast to the confession of hope, unwavering, for the one who made the promise is faithful. 24 And let us consider one another, so as to spur one another on to love and good works, 25 not abandoning our own meeting together, as is the habit of some, but encouraging one another, and all the more as you see the Day drawing near.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Hebrews 10:19 is the great hinge of the whole letter to the Hebrews. From 1:1 to 10:18 the author has laid a masterly theological foundation: who Christ is (greater than the prophets, the angels, Moses and Aaron) and what he has done as our eternal High Priest in the heavenly sanctuary. He has exhorted his readers before (2:1–4; 3:7–4:13; 5:11–6:12), but now, with the words "**So, brothers and sisters, since we have ...**" (*Echontes oun, adelphoi* –Ἔχοντες οὖν, ἀδελφοί), he moves decisively from *doctrine* to our *duty* – from the wonderful position Christ has won for us to the practical way of life that must flow from it (10:19 to 13:25).

In the original Greek, verses 19 to 25 form one single, beautifully constructed sentence. It rests on **two great spiritual possessions** ("since we have ..." – vv. 19–21) and flows into **three powerful exhortations** ("Let us ..." – vv. 22–25), which together form the classic Christian triad of **faith** (v. 22), **hope** (v. 23) and **love** (vv. 24–25)!

Under the old covenant any ordinary Israelite (or even an ordinary priest) who dared to step behind the curtain into the Most Holy Place would have died on the spot. Even the high priest entered only once a year with fear and trembling. When Jesus' body was broken and torn on the cross, the massive curtain of the temple was torn in two from top to bottom (Matthew 27:51). The double cleansing of verse 22 points to the consecration of priests in the Old Testament (Exodus 29:4, 21; Leviticus 8) and to the new-covenant prophecy of **Ezekiel 36:25–26**.

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us look at the riches of the Greek terms:

- **"Confidence" (*parrēsia* – παρρησία, v. 19):** We "*have confidence to enter the sanctuary by the blood of Jesus*". *Parrēsia* is a free, unhindered and fully legal right of access!
- **"The new and living way" (*hodon prosphaton kai zōsan* – ὁδὸν πρόσφατον καὶ ζῶσαν, v. 20):** The Greek word for "new", *prosphatos*, is especially striking: originally it means "fresh, recently made". Here it points to something that always stays fresh and never grows old or loses its power. Christ's sacrifice on the cross remains for ever as fresh and powerful before God as on the day his blood flowed on Golgotha – and because he is risen, it is a *living* way.
- **"Inaugurated" (*enkainizō* – ἐγκαινίζω, v. 20):** Jesus "*inaugurated*" this way for us, that is, opened it for the first time.
- **"Let us approach" (*proserchōmetha* – προσερχώμεθα, v. 22):** A present-tense form meaning: let us keep drawing near to God, continually and as a habit of life.

- **"With a true heart" (*meta alēthinēs kardias* – μετὰ ἀληθινῆς καρδίας, v. 22):** a sincere, undivided heart, free of hypocrisy.
- **"In full assurance of faith" (*en plērophoria pisteōs* – ἐν πληροφορίᾳ πίστεως, v. 22):** the inner confidence of someone fully convinced.
- **"Unwavering" (*aklinē* – ἀκλινῆ, v. 23):** We are to hold fast to the public confession (*homologia* – ὁμολογία) of our hope, *"unwavering"* (*katechōmen … aklinē* – κατέχωμεν … ἀκλινῆ). The word *aklinēs* literally means "without bending or leaning over" – like an upright pillar that refuses to snap under tremendous wind pressure.
- **"Let us consider one another" (*katanoōmen allēlous* – κατανοῶμεν ἀλλήλους, v. 24):** In Hebrews 3:1 the author told us to *"consider closely"* Jesus (*katanoeō* – κατανοέω: to reflect deeply on, to study); now he uses exactly the same verb for our brothers and sisters!
- **"Spur on" (*paroxysmos* – παροξυσμός, v. 24):** From this word comes our medical term "paroxysm". It is usually used in a negative sense for a violent outburst, irritation or quarrel (like the sharp disagreement between Paul and Barnabas in Acts 15:39). But here the author beautifully turns it around: we are to "provoke" one another in a good way, to shake each other awake and set each other on fire (like spurs that make a horse leap forward) to love and to serve!
- **"Meeting together" and "encouraging" (*episynagōgē* – ἐπισυναγωγή; *parakaleō* – παρακαλέω, v. 25):** We are not to abandon our own meeting together, but to encourage one another.

### CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Our two great possessions: the open way and the great priest (vv. 19–21).** First, by the blood of Jesus we have confidence to enter the sanctuary, *"by the new and living way that he inaugurated for us through the curtain, that is, his flesh"*. His incarnation and death on the cross removed the barrier between God and humanity for ever. Second, we have *"a*

*great priest over the house of God*": we are not walking into an empty throne room; our living King-Priest stands ready at the Father's right hand to welcome us.

2. **Call 1 (faith): "Let us approach" (v. 22).** The first response to the open curtain is to draw near, *"with a true heart in full assurance of faith"*. This inner confidence rests on a double cleansing: - **Inward:** *"with our hearts sprinkled clean from an evil conscience"* (by the blood of Christ, which washes away our deepest sense of guilt). - **Outward:** *"and our bodies washed with pure water"* (the outward sign of Christian baptism, which testifies to the inner renewal and sanctification by the Holy Spirit and the Word; cf. Ephesians 5:26; Titus 3:5). In Christ every believer is now a consecrated priest who may go straight into the Most Holy Place!
3. **Call 2 (hope): "Let us hold fast" (v. 23).** Having drawn near to God *upwards* in faith, we look *forwards* to the future in hope. How can we stay upright when everything around us is shaking? Not because our own grip is so strong, but *"for the one who made the promise is faithful"* (*pistos* – πιστὸς)! Our holding on rests on his unfailing character.
4. **Call 3 (love): "Let us consider one another" (vv. 24–25).** The third call looks *sideways* at our fellow believers. We are to look attentively and compassionately at one another's lives and think creatively about how we can support each other spiritually, *"so as to spur one another on to love and good works"*. But that cannot happen if we isolate ourselves. That is why verse 25 warns against *"abandoning our own meeting together, as is the habit of some"* (probably out of fear of persecution or spiritual lukewarmness). We are to encourage one another, *"and all the more as you see the Day drawing near"* (the return of Christ and the impending judgement on Jerusalem).

## Living It Out

Hebrews 10:19–25 gives us the perfect blueprint for a healthy, balanced spiritual life in a hostile and exhausting world.

First, look at your **vertical relationship with God (vv. 19–22)**. How many Christians today still live as if the curtain had been sewn up again! When you pray, you may feel as if you have to shout to God from outside the camp over a high wall, hoping he might listen if you have lived well enough today. But the gospel declares that the curtain has been torn open for ever through Jesus' broken body. The way to the Father's heart is *prosphatos* – always fresh, living and wide open through Jesus' blood. You do not have to stand at a distance and knock timidly at the door; with a cleansed conscience you may walk today with *parrēsia* (childlike confidence) straight up to your Father's throne.

Second, look at your **horizontal relationship with other believers (vv. 24–25)**. In our modern, individualistic and digital culture the temptation is greater than ever to practise the Christian faith as a private "solo sport". We think: *"All I need is my Bible, my laptop and my personal relationship with the Lord; I don't need the trouble of other people's failings."*

But notice the text: in the long run you cannot live out verse 22 ("let us approach") and verse 23 ("let us hold fast to the confession of hope") if you ignore verses 24 and 25! A coal that rolls out of the fire soon dies and goes cold; in the same way a believer's hope and love cool down in isolation. To "consider" one another (*katanoeō*) means more than sitting next to someone on Sunday and chatting about the weather. It means deliberately investing in one another's lives – in our families, our home groups and our church community – so that, as iron sharpens iron (Proverbs 27:17), we can spur one another on (*paroxysmos*) to practical love and endurance as our King's coming draws ever nearer.

#### QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Are you walking on the "new and living way"?** Do you make daily use of the privilege of entering God's presence with confidence through Jesus' blood – or do you let an old, guilty conscience keep you in the outer court?

- **Is your pillar bending under pressure (*aklinēs* – ἀκλινής)?** In which area of your life is your confession of hope under tremendous pressure right now? How does the truth of verse 23 – "*for the one who made the promise is faithful*" – help you to stay upright?
- **Holy spurring on (*paroxysmos*):** Who are the people you are specifically "considering" at the moment, in order to spur them on to love and good works? And do you let other believers live close enough to you to encourage you when you grow tired?

## Prayer

> *Heavenly Father, with deep wonder and gratitude I come with confidence today into your holy presence. I come not on the basis of my own merit, but only through the precious blood of Jesus, by the new and living way that he tore open for me through his body broken on the cross.*
>
> *Lord Jesus, my great Priest over the house of God, thank you that you have sprinkled my heart clean from an evil conscience. Help me today to live close to you with a sincere, undivided heart and in full assurance of faith. Where the storms of life blow against me, give me the grace to hold fast to the confession of my hope, upright and unwavering, because I know that you who promised are completely faithful.*
>
> *Set me free, too, from spiritual selfishness and isolation. Open my eyes today to consider with compassion and wisdom the people you send across my path – in my own home and in the body of Christ. Make me a spark that spurs others on to love and good works, and let us encourage and hold on to one another day by day as we watch with joyful expectation your great Day drawing near. Amen.*

DAY 21

# Endurance in Faith: Do Not Throw Away Your Confidence

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 10:26–39**

26 For if we sin deliberately after we have received the knowledge of the
truth, there no longer remains a sacrifice for sins, 27 but only a fearful
expectation of judgment and the fury of a fire that will consume the ad-
versaries. 28 Anyone who has set aside the law of Moses dies without pity
on the testimony of two or three witnesses. 29 How much worse punish-
ment, do you think, will be deserved by the one who has trampled on
the Son of God, has regarded as unclean the blood of the covenant by
which he was made holy, and has insulted the Spirit of grace? 30 For we
know the one who said:

Vengeance is mine; I will repay.
And again:
The Lord will judge his people.

31 To fall into the hands of the living God is a fearful thing.

32 But remember the earlier days, when, after you had been enlightened,
you endured a hard struggle with sufferings, 33 sometimes being made a
public spectacle through reproaches and afflictions, and sometimes
standing in fellowship with those who were treated in this way. 34 For
you sympathized with the prisoners, and you accepted the seizure of
your possessions with joy, knowing that you yourselves have a better
possession, one that lasts. 35 So do not throw away your confidence,
which has a great reward. 36 For you need endurance, so that when you
have done the will of God you may receive the promise.

37 For yet a very little while,
and the one who is coming will come and will not delay;
38 but my righteous one will live by faith,
and if he draws back,
my soul takes no pleasure in him.

39 But we are not of those who draw back to destruction, but of those
who have faith to the preserving of the soul.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

### HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

With Hebrews 10:26–39 we complete our journey through the central theological section of the letter. As in chapter 6, an awe-inspiring warning (vv. 26–31) is followed by a warm, encouraging call to endurance and trust (vv. 32–39). Here we enter the fourth great **warning passage** of Hebrews.

Yesterday, in vv. 19–25, the author showed how the way through the curtain has been opened and how we are now to hold on in faith, hope and love together with other believers. The word "For" (*gar* – γάρ) at the start of v. 26 ties the warning directly to v. 25: deliberately abandoning the meetings of the church and turning back to the old order was the first visible step towards a final rejection of Christ. Yet the chapter ends on a triumphant note that builds the bridge to the famous faith chapter, Hebrews 11: "*But we are not of those who draw back to destruction, but of those who have faith to the preserving of the soul.*"

When the readers had just come to faith, they went through hard days (vv. 32–34). This may have been at the time when the emperor Claudius had Jews – and Jewish Christians with them – expelled from Rome, around AD 49. Back then they bore reproach, affliction and the loss of their possessions with joy.

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us look at the original Greek terms and the theological structure of this passage:

1. **Deliberate sin and the one sacrifice (*hekousiōs* – ἑκουσίως and *epignōsis* – ἐπίγνωσις, vv. 26–27):** The author warns: "*For if we sin deliberately after we have received the knowledge of the truth …*" The background is Numbers 15:22–31, where sins committed in ignorance are set against sin committed "with a high hand" (Numbers 15:30). This is not about a believer who stumbles into temptation through human weakness and returns to the Lord in repentance (see Hebrews 4:15–16). The

word *hekousiōs* stands at the very start of the Greek sentence for emphasis, and the verb for sinning (*hamartanontōn* – ἁμαρτανόντων) is a present participle: if we go on sinning, persistently and deliberately. In the context of Hebrews this refers specifically to the sin of **apostasy** (falling away): having received the full knowledge (*epignōsis*) of Christ's once-for-all sacrifice, deliberately turning one's back on him. If someone rejects the one, final Redeemer of sinners, there is no other sacrifice left that can take sins away – only the just judgment of God that will strike his "*adversaries*" (*hypenantious* – ὑπεναντίους; see Isaiah 26:11).

2. **The threefold contempt for the grace of the triune God (*katapatēsas* – καταπατήσας, *koinon* – κοινόν and *enybrisas* – ἐνυβρίσας, vv. 28–31):** Again the author uses the *qal wahomer* argument (from the lesser to the greater): under the law of Moses (Deuteronomy 17:2–6), someone who had deliberately rejected the covenant to serve idols died without mercy on the testimony of two or three witnesses. How much more serious, then, to reject the new covenant! Verse 29 describes the horror of such a rejection by how it treats the Father's Son, the blood of the cross and the Holy Spirit: - **Trampled on the Son of God (*katapatēsas*):** walking over Jesus as though he were worthless, like mud on a road. - **Regarded the blood of the covenant as unclean (*koinon hēgēsamenos* – κοινὸν ἡγησάμενος):** the word *koinos* means "common, ordinary, unholy". It is to claim that Jesus' precious blood on the cross was just the ordinary blood of a human offender, with no atoning power. - **Insulted the Spirit of grace (*enybrisas*):** the word is related to *hybris* – slapping in the face, with arrogant contempt, the very Holy Spirit who holds out grace to you.

The author quotes Deuteronomy 32:35–36 and concludes in v. 31: "*To fall into the hands of the living God is a fearful thing.*"

3. **Memory as an anchor: remember the earlier days (*anamimnēskesthe* – ἀναμιμνήσκεσθε and *theatrizomenoi* – θεατριζόμενοι, vv. 32–34):** As in Hebrews 6:9, the author's tone suddenly changes in v. 32 from thunder to pastoral encouragement. He calls the church to think back

(*anamimnēskesthe* – call it vividly to mind) to "*the earlier days*" just after they had come to faith. Back then they "*endured a hard struggle with sufferings*" (*athlēsis* – ἄθλησις, related to our word "athletics": a gruelling contest or fight in the arena): - They were **made a public spectacle** through reproach and affliction (*theatrizomenoi* – from which we get "theatre": being put on display on a stage to be mocked). - They stood in fellowship (*koinōnoi* – κοινωνοί) with prisoners who suffered for Christ. In a world where prisoners depended entirely on friends for food and clothing, it was life-threatening to be identified with a Christian prisoner – yet they did not run away! - And when their own homes and possessions were plundered and confiscated, they "*accepted the seizure of your possessions with joy*" (*meta charas* – μετὰ χαρᾶς)! How is it humanly possible to be glad when you lose your property? Verse 34 gives the secret: "*knowing that you yourselves have a better* (*kreittona* – κρείττονα) *possession, one that lasts*" (*menousan* – μένουσαν). (Many older translations add "in heaven" here; the Greek base text we follow does not have it, but that is the possession the author means.)

4. **Do not throw away your confidence (*hypomonē* – ὑπομονή and *hypostolē* – ὑποστολή, vv. 35–39):** If they stood so bravely back then, why give up now? So v. 35 says: "*So do not throw away your confidence*" (*parrēsian* – παρρησίαν; *mē apobalēte* – μὴ ἀποβάλητε). In ancient warfare the greatest disgrace for a soldier was to throw away (*apoballō*) his shield on the battlefield and flee. Our *parrēsia* (our unashamed trust in Christ) "*has a great reward*" (*misthapodosian* – μισθαποδοσίαν). What they need now is **endurance** (*hypomonē* – staying on your feet under a heavy load and holding out to the end). To encourage them, the author quotes in vv. 37–38 the well-known prophecy of **Habakkuk 2:3–4**, introduced by a phrase from Isaiah 26:20: "*For yet a very little while*" (*mikron hoson hoson* – μικρὸν ὅσον ὅσον): - In Habakkuk the text is about the vision that will be fulfilled at the appointed time; in Hebrews it becomes a person: "*the one who is coming* (*ho erchomenos* – ὁ ἐρχόμενος, a messianic title for Jesus!) *will come and will not delay*". - And while we wait

for his coming, how do we survive? *"But my righteous one will live by faith."* The chapter closes in v. 39 with a powerful declaration of faith in which the author includes himself and his readers: *"But we are not of those who draw back* (*hypostolēs* – ὑποστολῆς: pulling back like a coward and slinking away) *to destruction, but of those who have faith* (*pisteōs* – πίστεως) *to the preserving* (*peripoiēsin* – περιποίησιν: gaining, keeping safe) *of the soul."*

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **There is only one sacrifice for sins.** Whoever deliberately rejects Christ's once-for-all sacrifice has no other sacrifice left – only the just judgment of God.
2. **The hands of the living God.** For the believer who takes refuge in Christ, the hands of the living God are the safest place in the universe (John 10:28–29); but for the one who tramples on Christ's blood, those same hands are a consuming judgment.
3. **Warning and encouragement belong together.** As in chapter 6, the thunder of vv. 26–31 is followed by the pastoral encouragement of vv. 32–39.
4. **Endurance lives from the promise of his coming.** The one who is coming will come and will not delay. Meanwhile the righteous one lives by faith and does not draw back.

## Living It Out

Hebrews 10:26–39 speaks directly to the believer who, in a long, draining season of life, feels that their spiritual strength is running out.

Look first at the practical power of **holy remembering (vv. 32–34).** When a new crisis or disappointment stares you in the face today, fear often whispers that you won't make it this time. The author's advice is: *Look back at your "earlier days"!* Remember the earlier storms in which the Lord

carried you. Remember the times when your faith was still young and fervent and you were ready to stake everything on Jesus. The same God who carried you through the earlier struggles (*athlēsis*) is still with you today.

Look secondly at the liberating perspective on **earthly possessions and your eternal possession (v. 34)**. Our modern culture teaches us to tie our security and joy to financial security, property and comfort. When those things are threatened, we panic or grow bitter. The early Christians could face the loss of their earthly goods *with joy* – not because they enjoyed pain, but because their accounting was right: they *knew* that they had a **better possession, one that lasts**, with God, which no thief, inflation or persecutor can ever touch. The looser our grip on temporary things, the firmer our joy in Christ.

Look thirdly at the call in vv. 35–39: **Do not throw down your shield of confidence on the battlefield just before the King arrives!** It is often in the last few kilometres of a marathon – when the muscles burn and the finish line is still hidden around the bend – that a runner is tempted to sit down. But v. 37 assures you: "*For yet a very little while, and the one who is coming will come*"! We do not belong to the camp of those who draw back (*hypostolē*); by his grace we are people of faith (*pistis*) who keep walking forward to the finish line!

#### QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Remember the earlier days:** As you look back over your journey with the Lord, which particular hard struggle or trial from your past, through which God carried you, can give you fresh courage today for your present battle?
- **The test of earthly loss (v. 34):** How does your heart react when you lose earthly comfort, money or people's approval? Does your reaction show that you really believe you have in Christ a *better possession, one that lasts*?

- **Holding on to your confidence (*parrēsia*):** Where in your life are you tempted right now to throw down your spiritual shield and draw back out of weariness? What does it mean for you to declare afresh today: *"my righteous one will live by faith"*?

## Prayer

> *Living and holy God, with deep reverence I bow before your majesty. Your word reminds me today how serious and how precious the sacrifice of your Son is. Keep my heart from ever regarding the precious blood of the covenant, by which I was made holy, as something ordinary or to be taken for granted, or from grieving the Spirit of grace through unbelief.*
>
> *Lord Jesus, thank you that in my past you have already carried me through so many storms and struggles. When I grow tired on the road today, remind me of your faithfulness in the earlier days. Open my eyes to the imperishable treasure I have in you – a better possession, one that lasts, which no earthly loss can ever take from me.*
>
> *Today I choose not to throw away my confidence and my shield of faith. Give me by your Spirit the endurance and staying power to keep doing your will while I look forward to your coming. Yet a very little while, and you, the one who is coming, will come and will not delay! Thank you that by your grace I do not belong to those who draw back to destruction, but to those who have faith to the preserving of the soul. Amen.*

DAY 22

# The Nature of Faith and the First Heroes of Faith: Abel, Enoch and Noah

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 11:1–7**

[1] Now faith is the assurance of what is hoped for, the proof of things that
are not seen. [2] For by it the people of old were attested. [3] By faith we un-
derstand that the worlds were fashioned by God's word, so that what is
seen did not come into being out of things that appear.

[4] By faith Abel offered God a greater sacrifice than Cain. Through it he
was attested as righteous, God himself testifying about his gifts; and
through it, though he died, he is still speaking. [5] By faith Enoch was
taken up so that he would not see death, and "he was not found, because
God had taken him up". For before he was taken up, it was testified of
him that he had pleased God. [6] And without faith it is impossible to
please him, for whoever approaches God must believe that he exists and
that he rewards those who earnestly seek him. [7] By faith Noah, when he
was warned by God about things not yet seen, in reverence built an ark
for the salvation of his house. Through it he condemned the world, and
he became heir of the righteousness that accords with faith.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

With chapter 11 we enter the last major section of the letter to the Hebrews (chapters 11 to 13). Yesterday, at the end of chapter 10, the author quoted Habakkuk 2:4 – *"but my righteous one will live by faith"* – and declared that we are not of those who draw back to destruction, but **of those who have faith to the preserving of the soul** (10:38–39). Now he draws back the curtain on the famous "Hall of Fame of Faith".

For the persecuted Jewish Christians, the greatest temptation was to stare only at what the physical eye could see: the power of Rome, the loss of their earthly possessions, and the apparent security of the earthly temple in Jerusalem. The author now shows them that the greatest heroes of their own Old Testament history never lived by what their physical eyes could see, but by God's invisible promises. He starts at the very beginning of Genesis (chapters 1 to 9) – long before Abraham or the law of Moses existed – with creation and the three early witnesses before the flood: **Abel, Enoch and Noah**.

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us dig into the riches of the original Greek terms and the theological foundations of these seven verses:

1. **The ground and proof of the unseen (*hypostasis – ὑπόστασις and elenchos – ἔλεγχος, vv. 1–2): Verse 1 does not give a dry dictionary definition of faith; it shows what faith does: it is "the assurance of what is hoped for, the proof of things that are not seen"*. -** Hypostasis: *We have already met this rich Greek word in Hebrews 1:3 ("being") and 3:14 ("assurance"). In some Greek papyri of the first centuries,* hypostasis *is used for the documents that prove ownership – a kind of title deed to a piece of land. Even if you have not yet gone to live on that plot, you hold in your hand the legal title that guarantees it belongs to you. Faith is the spiritual title deed that makes God's future promises so real and tangible to us today that we can build our lives on them!* - **Elenchos*:** This word is a legal term for **conclusive evidence** that settles a case in court beyond all doubt, or for an inner conviction that works like a sixth sense. Where our physical eyes perceive the visible world, faith is the spiritual eye with which we see the invisible kingdom of God clearly. - **Were attested (*emartyrēthēsan* – ἐμαρτυρήθησαν, v. 2):** In the world people look for the approval of their contemporaries, but *"the people of old"* (*hoi presbyteroi* – οἱ πρεσβύτεροι, literally the elders) received through their faith a good testimony from God himself that his favour rested on them.

2. **The invisible origin of the visible cosmos (*katērtisthai tous aiōnas* – κατηρτίσθαι τοὺς αἰῶνας, v. 3):** The very first place where faith enlightens our understanding is the origin of the universe (Genesis 1). *"By faith we understand"* (*nooumen* – νοοῦμεν: we grasp with spiritual insight) *"that the worlds were fashioned by God's word"*. *"The worlds"* (*aiōnas* – the ages, time and space) were fashioned by the spoken word (*rhēmati* – ῥήματι) of God. The Greek verb for "fashion" is *katartizō*: to fit something together precisely, to equip, to order in perfect harmony (the same word is used in Hebrews 13:21 for the way God equips us to do his will). And notice the end of v. 3: the visible universe (*to blepomenon* – τὸ βλεπόμενον) did not come into being out of things that were already visible (*ek phainomenōn* – ἐκ φαινομένων). The ultimate reality behind everything we can see and touch is not blind matter but the invisible, eternal word of God!

3. **Abel: faith that worships and goes on speaking after death (*pleiona thysian* – πλείονα θυσίαν, v. 4):** Now the author moves through Genesis in order and shows how the walk of faith unfolds: in Abel we see the **worship of faith** (Genesis 4:1–10). By faith Abel offered God a *"greater"* (*pleiona*: fuller, richer, more valuable) sacrifice than Cain. Why did God accept Abel's lamb and reject Cain's fruit of the ground? Not simply because of what was on the menu, but because Abel came with a heart of faith that acknowledged that, as a sinner, he needed atonement through a blood sacrifice, while Cain came with a self-righteous attitude of mere duty. God himself testified about Abel's gifts and declared him **righteous** (*dikaios* – δίκαιος). And although Abel was the very first martyr for the faith when his brother murdered him, the author says: *"through it, though he died, he is still speaking"* (*eti lalei* – ἔτι λαλεῖ). In Genesis 4:10 Abel's blood cried out to God from the ground, but his faith still speaks to us today, in the present tense, and testifies that it is worth serving God on his terms, even if it costs you your life.

4. **Enoch: faith that walks with God and delights his heart (*euarestēkenai* – εὐαρεστηκέναι and *misthapodotēs* – μισθαποδότης, vv. 5–6):** If Abel shows us the *offering* of faith, Enoch shows us the **daily walk of faith** (Genesis 5:21–24). The Hebrew text of Genesis 5 says that Enoch walked with God for three hundred years. The Greek Septuagint, however, rendered that Hebrew expression as "Enoch pleased God" (*euērestēsen tō theō*) – and our author seizes on exactly that verb! Enoch's close fellowship with the Lord in the middle of a corrupt world before the flood was so precious to God that God *"had taken him up"* (*metatithēmi* – μετατίθημι: transferred to heaven) without his tasting death. From Enoch's life, v. 6 formulates an unshakeable ground rule of the spiritual life: *"without faith it is impossible* (*adynaton* – ἀδύνατον) *to please him"*. And what does this faith involve when we approach God? Two things: - We must believe **that he exists** (*hoti estin* – ὅτι ἔστιν, literally "that he is": not just a cold intellectual acknowledgement that there is a Supreme Being, but that he is the living "I AM" of Exodus 3:14, truly present). - We must believe **that he rewards those who earnestly seek him** (*ekzētousin* – ἐκζητοῦσιν). He is a *misthapodotēs* – a generous Rewarder. And what is the greatest reward God gives to the one who seeks him? Himself! (See Genesis 15:1, where God says to Abram: "I am your shield; your reward will be very great.")

5. **Noah: faith that builds in reverence in the dark (*chrēmatistheis* – χρηματισθείς and *eulabētheis* – εὐλαβηθείς, v. 7):** In Abel we see faith that *worships*, in Enoch faith that *walks*, and in Noah faith that **works and perseveres** (Genesis 6–9). Noah acted *"when he was warned by God about things not yet seen"* (*chrēmatistheis* – an official oracle or revelation from God's side) – a worldwide flood at a time when no one had ever experienced such a judgment. How did Noah respond? He did not argue or wait for a weather forecast; **in reverence** (*eulabētheis* – related to *eulabeia* – εὐλάβεια, the same deep godly fear that Hebrews 5:7 testifies of Jesus!) he hammered away at the ark, plank by plank, for decades, *"for the salvation of his house"*. Through his obedient faith he

did two things: first, *"he condemned the world"* (*katekrinen* – κατέκρινεν: his obedience left their wilful unbelief without excuse), and second, *"he became heir of the righteousness that accords with faith"*. Genesis 6:9 is the first place in Scripture where anyone is called "righteous" – and it is Noah!

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Faith makes the unseen certain.** It is the assurance of what is hoped for and the proof of things that are not seen – the title deed of God's promises in our hand.
2. **Reality rests on God's word.** Behind everything we can see and touch stands not blind matter but the invisible, eternal word of God.
3. **Faith worships, walks and works.** Abel shows the worship of faith, Enoch the daily walk of faith, Noah the work and perseverance of faith.
4. **Without faith it is impossible to please God.** Whoever approaches God must believe that he exists and that he rewards those who earnestly seek him.

## Living It Out

Hebrews 11:1–7 frees us from the suffocating tyranny of the visible world and, through Abel, Enoch and Noah, gives us a threefold road map for our daily walk with the Lord.

Think first about **how you see reality (vv. 1–3)**. Every day we are bombarded with news, figures and visible crises that shout at us that only what you can see and measure really matters. But when you look through the lens of vv. 1 and 3, you realize that this visible world is temporary and that God's promises are the *hypostasis* – the firm title deed – under your feet. You don't need to see today *how* God is going to cut through a particular knot in your future or your family in order to stand on it in peace already; you hold the signed title deed of his word in your hand!

Look secondly at **the heart of your relationship with the Father (vv. 4–6).** Many believers live with the constant fear that God is always slightly disappointed or irritated with them. But look at v. 6: how do you delight God's heart (*euaresteō*)? Not by flawless perfection in your own strength, but by **faith**! When today, like Abel, you come to him acknowledging that you rely only on the blood of the Lamb, and when, like Enoch, you walk towards his throne expecting not a stingy judge but a generous *Rewarder* who loves to give himself to those who earnestly seek him (*ekzēteō*), then the Father smiles on you!

Look thirdly at **Noah's hammer in your own house (v. 7).** Notice the moving detail in v. 7: in reverence Noah built the ark *"for the salvation of his house"*. In a culture that mocked God's warnings, Noah held his course and built a spiritual refuge for his wife and children. What a call for us today! The world around us may think it old-fashioned or foolish to be still before the word every day, to choose integrity over profit, and to build your house on the rock of Christ. But every daily act of the obedience of faith by which you lead your family to Christ is like one more plank you nail in place against the storms of this age.

#### QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Your spiritual title deed (*hypostasis*):** Which particular promise of God are you holding on to at the moment, while your physical eyes can see no sign yet of its fulfilment? Do you treat that promise as a "wish" or as a legal *title deed*?
- **How do you see God when you pray (v. 6)?** When you approach God today, do you come merely out of duty, like Cain, or with the firm faith that he is present and that he is a generous *Rewarder* of those who seek him with all their heart?
- **Building your "ark" (v. 7):** Where is the Lord asking you at the moment, like Noah, to keep building *in reverence* and obedience – in your personal devotion, your work or for the blessing of your household – even if there is not yet a cloud on the horizon?

## Prayer

*Eternal and invisible Creator God, I worship you today as the One who, by the power of your single spoken word, prepared and ordered the universe and the ages out of nothing. Thank you that my life is not left to blind chance or to what my limited eyes can see, but that your word is the firm title deed and pledge of my hope.*

*Lord, I want to please you today with a living, childlike faith. Like Abel I come to you with no merit of my own, but only on the ground of the precious blood of the perfect Lamb, Jesus Christ. Like Enoch I long to walk with you today, step by step, in close fellowship, with the joyful conviction that you are truly present and that you richly reward everyone who earnestly seeks you.*

*And as with Noah, I ask you to fill my heart with a holy reverence for your word. Where the world around me lives for the moment and ignores your warnings, give me the courage and perseverance to keep building faithfully in faith every day, for the blessing and shelter of my household and of the people you have entrusted to me. Open my spiritual eyes wide today to the invisible things of your kingdom. Amen.*

DAY 23

# Pilgrims and Strangers Seeking the Eternal City: From Abraham to Joseph

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 11:8–22**

[8] By faith Abraham obeyed when he was called to go out to a place that
he was to receive as an inheritance; and he went out, not knowing
where he was going. [9] By faith he lived as a guest in the land of the
promise as in a foreign land, living in tents with Isaac and Jacob, co-
heirs of the same promise. [10] For he was waiting for the city that has the
foundations, whose designer and builder is God. [11] By faith he received
power to father offspring – together with Sarah herself – even when he
was past the age for it, since he considered the one who had promised
faithful. [12] Therefore from one man, and him as good as dead, descen-
dants were born as many as the stars of heaven and as countless as the
sand on the shore of the sea.

[13] In faith all these died without having received the promises, but they
saw them from afar and greeted them, and confessed that they were
strangers and temporary residents on the earth. [14] For people who speak
like this make it clear that they are seeking a homeland. [15] If they had
been thinking of the one they had left, they would have had opportu-
nity to return. [16] But as it is, they long for a better one, that is, a heavenly
one. Therefore God is not ashamed of them, to be called their God; for
he has prepared a city for them.

[17] By faith Abraham, when he was tested, offered up Isaac. He who had
received the promises was ready to offer up his only son, [18] he to whom
it had been said, "Through Isaac offspring will be named for you." [19] He
reckoned that God is able even to raise from the dead; hence he did re-
ceive him back – as a symbol. [20] By faith Isaac blessed Jacob and Esau,
also concerning things to come. [21] By faith Jacob, when he was dying,
blessed each of the sons of Joseph, and he worshipped, leaning on the
top of his staff. [22] By faith Joseph, at the end of his life, mentioned the
exodus of the sons of Israel and gave instructions about his bones.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

### HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

Yesterday, in the first seven verses of chapter 11, the author showed how the early heroes before the flood (Abel, Enoch and Noah) walked with God by faith. Now he moves on to the patriarchs of Israel: **Abraham, Sarah, Isaac, Jacob and Joseph** (Genesis 12 to 50). More space in this chapter is given to Abraham than to anyone else, because for Jewish Christians Abraham was the prime example of how a person responds to God's call by faith.

What makes the faith of the patriarchs so remarkable? Their whole lives were marked by **pilgrimage and a focus on the future.** They left their safe, settled lives behind and lived in tents for decades – not because they liked wandering, but because their spiritual eyes were fixed on an eternal city designed by God himself. Even on their deathbeds these men and women did not look back with regret, but looked forward with unshakeable certainty to God's future.

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us dig into the riches of the original Greek terms and the theological foundations of this passage:

1. **Obedient departure, and tents versus eternal foundations (*paroikeō* – παροικέω, *technitēs* – τεχνίτης and *dēmiourgos* – δημιουργός, vv. 8–10):** When God called Abraham out of Ur of the Chaldeans – a highly developed, prosperous city of the ancient world – Abraham obeyed at once (in Greek, *kaloumenos* – καλούμενος is a present participle: *while the call was still sounding*, he was already packing!). He went out *"not knowing where he was going"*, without a map, with only God's voice as his compass. More than that: even when he had arrived in Canaan, he lived there *"as a guest"* (*paroikeō* – a temporary resident without rights of citizenship). For the rest of his life he lived in tents with Isaac and Jacob. Why was Abraham content with a temporary canvas over his

head? Verse 10 gives the deep reason: "*For he was waiting for the city that has the foundations* (*tous themelious* – τοὺς θεμελίους), *whose designer* (*technitēs*) *and builder* (*dēmiourgos*) *is God.*" A tent has only tent pegs in the dust; the heavenly Jerusalem has eternal foundations. The word *technitēs* refers to the master architect who draws up the blueprint, and *dēmiourgos* to the creator-builder who brings the city into being.

2. **Life from a body as good as dead (*nenekrōmenou* – νενεκρωμένου, vv. 11–12):** Faith does not only set out for an unknown land; it trusts God for what is humanly impossible. Abraham was nearly a hundred years old – physically speaking "*as good as dead*" (*nenekrōmenou* – dead as far as fathering children was concerned) – and Sarah was barren and far past the age of bearing children. Although Sarah at first laughed when she heard the promise (Genesis 18:12), doubt gave way to faith. Verse 11 says of Abraham: "*By faith he received power to father offspring – together with Sarah herself – even when he was past the age for it, since he considered the one who had promised faithful*" (*piston* – πιστόν). (Many older translations make Sarah the subject of v. 11; the Greek base text we follow speaks of Abraham, with Sarah included.) Their focus shifted from their own worn-out bodies to the faithfulness of the One who promised, and from that one "dead" man came descendants as many as the stars and the sand of the sea.

3. **Strangers who greet from afar, and a God who is not ashamed (*aspazomai* – ἀσπάζομαι and *patris* – πατρίς, vv. 13–16):** Verses 13 to 16 form a beautiful theological commentary on the patriarchs' attitude to life. "*In faith*" (*kata pistin* – κατὰ πίστιν) they all died without holding the final fulfilment of the promises in their lifetime on earth. But look at the three verbs in v. 13: they **saw** them from afar (*idontes* – ἰδόντες), **greeted** them (*aspasamenoi* – ἀσπασάμενοι) and **confessed** (*homologēsantes* – ὁμολογήσαντες)! The word *aspazomai* means to welcome something with joy or to embrace it with open arms – like sailors who, after a long voyage, see the mountain peaks of their homeland appear on the horizon and cheer for joy, though they are still miles from

the harbour! They openly confessed "*that they were strangers* (*xenoi* – ξένοι) *and temporary residents* (*parepidēmoi* – παρεπίδημοι: travellers who stay only for the night on the way to their real destination) *on the earth*". They were seeking "*a homeland*" (*patris* – a true home where you belong with the Father). Had they kept longing for the comforts of Mesopotamia, they could easily have turned the camels round and gone back (v. 15). But because their hearts were set on the heavenly homeland, v. 16 gives one of the most moving statements in Scripture: "*Therefore God is not ashamed of them, to be called their God.*" God proudly identified himself as the God of Abraham, the God of Isaac and the God of Jacob (Exodus 3:6) – three tent-dwellers with no city or land of their own, strangers in the eyes of the world's rich, but whose hearts were wholly set on his eternal city!

4. **The ordeal on Moriah: the logic of faith and the picture of resurrection (*logizomai* – λογίζομαι and *en parabolē* – ἐν παραβολῇ, vv. 17–19):** The author returns to Abraham's greatest test of faith (Genesis 22). The Greek tenses in v. 17 are striking: when he was tested, "*Abraham … offered up Isaac*" (*prosenēnochen* – προσενήνοχεν, perfect: in his heart and in the decision of his will the offering was already complete), and he "*was ready to offer up his only son*" (*prosepheren* – προσέφερεν, imperfect: he was in the act of offering him). This was not merely an emotional test for a father; it was a **theological crisis**. God had expressly promised: "*Through Isaac offspring will be named for you*" (v. 18). If Isaac died on the altar before his wedding and was burned to ashes, how could God's promise come true? Abraham was not paralysed by this apparent contradiction. "*He reckoned*" (*logisamenos* – λογισάμενος: he drew a mathematical, logical conclusion from God's character) "*that God is able even to raise from the dead*": if God had made the promise and given the command, then **God must raise Isaac from the ashes**! Although up to that point in biblical history there had not been a single

resurrection from the dead, Abraham's faith reached as far as resurrection. And "*as a symbol*" (*en parabolē* – so to speak, as a foreshadowing of Christ's resurrection) he received Isaac back from death.

5. **Deathbed faith that blesses the future (vv. 20–22):** What does true faith look like when the body weakens and death knocks at the door? The author names three deathbed scenes from the rest of Genesis: - **Isaac (v. 20):** Despite his human failings in Genesis 27, he pronounced in faith the covenant blessing over the future of Jacob and Esau, knowing that God's plan would go on. - **Jacob (v. 21):** On his deathbed in Egypt this old pilgrim blessed the two sons of Joseph (Ephraim and Manasseh) with crossed hands according to God's sovereign choice (Genesis 48), and bowed in worship before God, "*leaning on the top of his staff*" – grateful to the God who had led him like a shepherd all his life. (Hebrews follows the Greek translation of Genesis 47:31 here; the Hebrew text reads "at the head of the bed".) - **Joseph (v. 22):** Joseph was the viceroy of Egypt – surrounded by pyramids, power and wealth. He could easily have stayed buried in Egypt's splendour. But on his deathbed (Genesis 50:24–25) Joseph did not think of his Egyptian fame! He spoke of the future **exodus** (*exodos* – ἔξοδος) of Israel (which would not happen for almost four centuries!) and gave instructions that his coffin with his bones should not stay buried in Egypt, but be carried to the promised land. To his last breath Joseph was in effect declaring: "Egypt is not my home; my future lies in God's promise!"

### CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Faith obeys without the whole map.** Abraham went out not knowing where he was going, with only God's voice as his compass.
2. **Faith trusts God for what is humanly impossible.** The focus shifts from our own worn-out possibilities to the faithfulness of the One who promised.

3. **Believers are pilgrims on the way to a better homeland.** Their true home is the city that has the foundations, whose designer and builder is God – and so God is not ashamed to be called their God.
4. **Faith reckons with resurrection.** The God who promised is able even to raise from the dead; so we can lay our most precious things on his altar with open hands.

## Living It Out

Hebrews 11:8–22 puts a searching question to our modern way of life: **Are we living today as permanent citizens of the earth, or as pilgrims and tent-dwellers on the way to the city that has the foundations?**

Every day we are conditioned to think that our happiness depends on how deeply we can drive our tent pegs into this earthly ground. But when, like the patriarchs, we understand that we are only *parepidēmoi* (travellers passing through) here, on the way to our true *patris* (homeland), it radically changes three things in our everyday lives:

First, it frees you **to obey even when you cannot yet see the whole map (v. 8)**. We often want the Lord first to give us steps 1 to 10 of the next five years in writing before we are willing to take step 1. But Abraham went out "*not knowing where he was going*". You don't need to know what tomorrow holds if you know the One who calls you today.

Second, it keeps you from **turning your eyes back to your old life (v. 15)**. When the pilgrim road gets rough, temptation often whispers that you should think back to the comforts of the "old homeland" from which we were called. If you let your thoughts keep circling (*mnēmoneuō* – μνημονεύω) around what you have given up, or how "easy" compromise would be, you will soon be looking for an opportunity to turn back. But when every morning you see the eternal city from afar and greet it with your heart (*aspazomai*), the world loses its charm. And think of the won-

der of v. 16: when you refuse to seek your ultimate security in this temporary world and set your whole hope on his heavenly inheritance, **God is not ashamed to be called your God!**

Third, Abraham on Moriah and Joseph in Egypt teach us **to hold our most precious things with open hands before the God of resurrection (vv. 17–22).** What is the "Isaac" in your life – the good gift, dream, child or ministry that the Lord himself gave you, but to which you may be clinging so tightly that it is becoming more important than the Giver? When we reckon (*logizomai*) that our God is the God who raises the dead, we can safely lay our future, our children and even our last breath on his altar.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Tent pegs or foundations?** If someone looked at your biggest worries, how you spend your time and your dreams, would they conclude that this earth is your final home, or that you are a pilgrim looking forward to the city whose designer and builder is God?
- **Obedience without the full map (v. 8):** Is there a particular step of obedience to which the Lord is calling you at the moment, but where you are still hesitating because you want to see all the answers and guarantees first?
- **Joseph's coffin and Egypt's pyramids (v. 22):** Which earthly success or "treasures of Egypt" sometimes threaten to make you forget that your true citizenship and future lie with God's covenant people? And what legacy of faith (like Jacob on his staff and Joseph's instruction) are you leaving today for your children and the generation after you?

## Prayer

> *God of Abraham, Isaac and Jacob – the living God who is not ashamed to be called my God – today, like Jacob of old, I bow before you in worship. Thank you for your gracious hand, which has led and carried me like a Shepherd to this very day.*

*Lord, when you call me to take new steps of obedience, keep me from the paralysing fear of the unknown. Give me the faith of Abraham to set out even when I cannot yet see the whole road ahead, because I know that you are with me. And where I face humanly impossible circumstances, let me, like Abraham and Sarah, not stare at my own weakness, but believe firmly that you, who gave the promise, are completely faithful.*

*Loosen my heart today from too strong an attachment to this temporary world. Remind me that I am only a pilgrim and a tent-dweller here, on the way to my true homeland – the eternal city with unshakeable foundations, whose Designer and Builder you yourself are. Today I lay my "Isaac" – my future, my family and everything precious to me – on your altar with open hands, trusting firmly in your resurrection power. Let me live, and one day die, with my eyes full of joy, fixed on your promises. Amen.*

DAY 24

# Moses and the Nameless Victors: Worth More than the Treasures of Egypt

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 11:23–40**

23 By faith Moses, after he was born, was hidden for three months by his
parents, because they saw that the child was beautiful, and they were
not afraid of the king's edict. 24 By faith Moses, when he had grown up,
refused to be called the son of Pharaoh's daughter, 25 choosing rather to
be mistreated along with the people of God than to have the fleeting en-
joyment of sin, 26 for he considered the reproach of the Christ greater
wealth than the treasures of Egypt, because he had his eyes fixed on the
reward. 27 By faith he left Egypt, not fearing the fury of the king; for he
held on as though he saw the one who is invisible. 28 By faith he insti-
tuted the Passover and the applying of the blood, so that the destroyer
of the firstborn would not touch them. 29 By faith they crossed the Red
Sea as on dry land; when the Egyptians attempted it, they were swal-
lowed up. 30 By faith the walls of Jericho fell after they had been encir-
cled for seven days. 31 By faith Rahab the prostitute did not perish with
those who disobeyed, because she had welcomed the spies in peace.

32 And what more shall I say? Time would fail me if I told of Gideon,
Barak, Samson, Jephthah, of David and Samuel and the prophets,
33 who through faith conquered kingdoms, practised righteousness, ob-
tained promises, shut the mouths of lions, 34 quenched the power of
fire, escaped the edge of the sword, were made strong out of weakness,
became mighty in war, put foreign armies to flight. 35 Women received
back their dead by resurrection. Others were tortured and refused to ac-
cept release, so that they might obtain a better resurrection. 36 Still oth-
ers experienced mocking and flogging, and even chains and prison.
37 They were stoned, they were sawn in two, they died by the sword;
they went about in sheepskins and goatskins, in want, afflicted, mis-
treated – 38 the world was not worthy of them – wandering in deserts
and mountains, in caves and holes in the ground.

39 And all these, though they were attested through their faith, did not
receive the promise, 40 since God had foreseen something better for us,
so that they would not be made perfect apart from us.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

### HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

With Hebrews 11:23–40 the famous "Hall of Fame of Faith" reaches its dramatic climax. Yesterday the author showed us how the patriarchs (Abraham, Isaac, Jacob and Joseph) lived and died as pilgrims. Now he focuses on **Moses**, the exodus and the conquest of Canaan (vv. 23–31), before summing up the rest of Old Testament history in a sweeping flood of stories of faith (vv. 32–40).

For first-century Jewish Christians who had lost their social standing, safety and property through persecution, this passage was like fresh water in a desert. The author shows them that true faith has two sides, both equally honoured by God: **faith that experiences supernatural deliverance and victory** (vv. 32–35a), and **faith that refuses to compromise and is ready to endure suffering for the sake of a better resurrection** (vv. 35b–38).

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us look at the insights from the original Greek and the theological structure of this passage:

1. **Moses' radical valuation and spiritual sight (*hēgeomai* – ἡγέομαι and *kartereō* – καρτερέω, vv. 23–28):** Moses' story of faith begins with his parents (Amram and Jochebed), who saw that the child was *asteios* (ἀστεῖος) – not just outwardly sweet, but exceptional and marked by God's favour (see Acts 7:20) – and who defied Pharaoh's murderous edict without fear. When Moses turned forty (Acts 7:23), he stood at the top of Egypt's pyramid of power. Yet he made a conscious decision of the will: he *"refused"* (*ērnēsato* – ἠρνήσατο: renounced his royal privileges), *"choosing rather to be mistreated along with the people of God than to have the fleeting enjoyment of sin"* (*helomenos* – ἑλόμενος). Why did he make such a seemingly foolish choice? Verse 26 shows his spiritual bookkeeping: *"for he considered the reproach of the Christ* (*ton oneidis-*

*mon tou Christou* – τὸν ὀνειδισμὸν τοῦ Χριστοῦ) *greater wealth than the treasures of Egypt"* (*hēgēsamenos* – ἡγησάμενος: he made a carefully reasoned, calculated valuation)! By identifying himself with God's messianic covenant people, Moses was already sharing ahead of time in the suffering of Christ, because his eyes were firmly fixed (*apeblepen* – ἀπέβλεπεν: looking away from everything else to focus on one point) on the eternal reward. In v. 27 lies the secret of his staying power: *"for he held on* (*ekarterēsen* – ἐκαρτέρησεν: like a soldier who stays standing, strong and unshaken) *as though he saw the one who is invisible"*! When you see the invisible King of the universe with the eye of faith, the fury of an earthly pharaoh shrinks to nothing. That is why, in faith, he could also have the Passover blood put on the doorposts as a shield against judgment (v. 28).

2. **Walls that fall and grace for an outsider (vv. 29–31):** From the crossing of the Red Sea the author moves on to Jericho. How did Jericho's impregnable walls fall? Not by battering rams or military skill, but by believing obedience to God's strange command to march around the city for seven days. And who is named right alongside Moses and Joshua in the hall of fame? **Rahab**, a Canaanite prostitute! She had no share in Israel's covenant history, but while her whole city hardened itself in unbelief, she did not perish, *"because she had welcomed the spies in peace"*, believing that Israel's God is the true God of heaven and earth (Joshua 2:11). Faith saves the least of outsiders and places her right in the family tree of the Messiah (Matthew 1:5)!

3. **Two sides of the same faith: victory and martyrdom (*apolytrōsis* – ἀπολύτρωσις and *tympanizō* – τυμπανίζω, vv. 32–38):** At v. 32 the author quickens his pace. He names six judges, kings and prophets – Gideon, Barak, Samson, Jephthah, David and Samuel – men full of human failings who nevertheless trusted God at the critical moment (they *"were made strong out of weakness"*, v. 34). They *"shut the mouths of lions"* (Daniel; compare also Samson and David) and survived fiery furnaces (Shadrach, Meshach and Abednego). Women (like the widow of

Zarephath with Elijah and the Shunammite woman with Elisha) even received their children back from death (v. 35a). But notice the sudden turn in the middle of v. 35: "**Others...**" (*alloi de* – ἄλλοι δέ). The same great faith that rescued some from the lions' den enabled others to *die faithfully in the lions' den and under torture*! The word for "tortured" (*etympanisthēsan* – ἐτυμπανίσθησαν) refers to the *tympanon* – a cruel rack or drum on which prisoners were stretched out and beaten to death (as in the Maccabean persecution under Antiochus Epiphanes in the period between the Testaments). They were offered release (*apolytrōsis*) if only they would deny their faith, but they refused it, "*so that they might obtain a better resurrection*" (*kreittonos anastaseōs* – κρείττονος ἀναστάσεως)! Whereas the sons of these women in v. 35a were only called back to this mortal life to die again later, the martyrs looked forward to the final resurrection to eternal glory. They were stoned (like Zechariah in 2 Chronicles 24), sawn in two (according to ancient Jewish tradition the fate of the prophet Isaiah under King Manasseh), and wandered about in sheepskins and goatskins (like Elijah). And then in v. 38 the Holy Spirit gives these despised wanderers the highest possible title of honour: "*the world was not worthy of them*"! The world thought these believers were not worthy to live in society; God declares that the world was too poor and unworthy to house such treasures!

4. **Made perfect together with us (*chōris hēmōn* – χωρὶς ἡμῶν, vv. 39–40):** The chapter closes with a surprising revelation. All these Old Testament giants of faith received a wonderful testimony from God, yet they died on earth without experiencing "the promise" (the final coming of the Messiah and the completed new covenant). Why? "*since God had foreseen something better for us, so that they would not be made perfect apart from us*" (*chōris hēmōn*).

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Faith weighs value in the light of eternity.** Moses considered the reproach of the Christ greater wealth than the treasures of Egypt, because his eyes were fixed on the reward.
2. **Faith sees the invisible One.** When you see the invisible King with the eye of faith, the fury of earthly powers shrinks to nothing.
3. **Faith has two sides, both equally honoured by God.** The same faith that rescued some from the lions' den enabled others to die faithfully under torture, looking to a better resurrection.
4. **Made perfect together.** In God's great plan of salvation, even the finally completed salvation and cleansing of conscience of Abraham, Moses and David waited for the death on the cross and the high-priestly work of Jesus Christ, which has dawned in our New Testament age. We and the Old Testament believers are brought **together** to our eternal destination through the one sacrifice of Christ!

## Living It Out

Hebrews 11:23–40 breaks down two very dangerous misconceptions in our modern Christian thinking and replaces them with unshakeable strength.

The first misconception is that the world's glittering offers are really worth it. Every day our culture holds "the treasures of Egypt" before us – status, comfort, instant gratification and the approval of people – if only we are willing to turn our backs on God's radical call. Look how honest the Bible is in v. 25: sin *does* bring enjoyment, but it is only "**fleeting**" (*proskairon* – πρόσκαιρον: for a short time). Moses looked through Egypt's glossy varnish and realized that the richest palace without God is a dead end, while the hardest road with Christ ("the reproach of the Christ") leads to eternal treasure. You can resist Egypt's temptations and threats only when, like Moses in v. 27, you live every day **as though you saw the one who is invisible.**

The second misconception is that great faith will always protect you from suffering, illness or misfortune. Some voices claim that if you only have enough faith, you will always be in the first half of the list (vv. 32–35a): walls will fall, lions' mouths will close, and every crisis will vanish overnight. But look at vv. 35b to 38! The people who suffered in poverty, imprisonment, chronic affliction and martyrdom did not have *less* faith than those who experienced miracles; on the contrary, it is about *them* that God exclaims: "**The world was not worthy of them!**" Whether God chooses today to calm the storm around you (as at the Red Sea), or to carry you through the fire without your compromising – in both cases your faith triumphs, because your eyes are fixed on the "better resurrection".

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Moses' scales (vv. 24–26):** If today you put the world's approval and comfort on one side of the scales, and obedience to Christ (even if it brings discomfort or reproach) on the other – which side weighs more heavily in your practical choices?
- **Do you see the invisible One (v. 27)?** What "fury of the king" or earthly pressure is making you afraid at the moment? How does your fear change when you turn your eyes away from the earthly threat and focus on the invisible King who stands beside you?
- **Faith in the "Others..." seasons (v. 35b):** How does your faith respond when God does *not* take your problem away at once, as in vv. 33–34, but calls you to endure faithfully in a difficult situation, looking to the eternal reward?

## Prayer

> *Almighty and invisible King, today I bow before you in deep awe. Thank you for the mighty cloud of witnesses who have gone before us – ordinary, weak people like Moses, Rahab, David and the prophets, who out of their weakness were strengthened by faith in your power.*

*Lord Jesus, purify my spiritual values today. Where the glittering treasures and the fleeting enjoyment of this world tug at my heart, give me the clear sight of Moses to see how quickly it all passes away. Let me count it my greatest wealth and honour to belong to you and even to bear your reproach, with my eyes firmly fixed on the eternal reward and the better resurrection you have purchased for me.*

*Open my spiritual eyes today, so that in every challenge I may hold on as though I saw the one who is invisible. Whether you lead me today through wonderful deliverance, or call me to stay standing faithfully under a heavy load without compromise – let my faith glorify your name. Thank you that in Christ you have foreseen something infinitely better for us and are bringing us, together with all the saints of all ages, to perfection. Amen.*

DAY 25

# The Race of Endurance: Eyes Fixed on Jesus and the Father's Discipline

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 12:1–13**

[1] Therefore, since we too have such a vast cloud of witnesses surrounding us, let us lay aside every weight and the sin that so readily wraps itself around us, and let us run with endurance the race that lies before us, [2] with our eyes fixed on Jesus, the pioneer of faith and the one who brings it to perfection. For the sake of the joy that lay before him he endured the cross, despising the shame, and he has taken his seat at the right hand of the throne of God. [3] Consider him who endured such opposition from sinners against themselves, so that you do not grow weary and lose heart in your souls.

[4] In your struggle against sin you have not yet resisted to the point of blood, [5] and you have forgotten the encouragement that addresses you as sons:

My son, do not make light of the discipline of the Lord,
and do not lose heart when you are corrected by him;
[6] for the Lord disciplines the one he loves,
and he flogs every son whom he accepts.

[7] It is for discipline that you endure. God is treating you as sons. For what son is there whom a father does not discipline? [8] But if you are without the discipline that all have come to share in, then you are illegitimate and not sons. [9] Besides, we had the fathers of our flesh to discipline us, and we respected them. Shall we not much more submit to the Father of spirits and live? [10] For they disciplined us for a few days as seemed good to them, but he does it for our good, so that we may share in his holiness. [11] All discipline, for the moment, seems to be a matter not of joy but of sorrow; later, however, it yields the peaceful fruit of righteousness to those who have been trained by it.

[12] Therefore lift up again the drooping hands and the weakened knees, [13] and make straight paths for your feet, so that what is lame may not be put out of joint but rather be healed.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

### HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

With the move into Hebrews 12, the author shifts the scene from the **historical hall of fame of the heroes of faith** (chapter 11) to a Graeco-Roman **athletics stadium** (verses 1–3) and to a **family home where children are raised** (verses 4–13). We have watched Abel, Abraham, Moses and the prophets complete their leg of the relay race of faith; now the baton is placed in our hands.

The first readers of this letter were spiritually and emotionally exhausted. The early excitement of their conversion had faded, and the constant social friction, rejection and mockery made them feel like long-distance runners who get a cramp halfway through a marathon and want to sit down beside the track. The author uses two powerful images to put new strength into their sinews: the discipline of a **marathon runner** and the loving upbringing given by a **Father**.

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us look at the Greek terms and the theological riches of this passage:

- **The cloud of witnesses and laying aside what is superfluous (*nephos*, *onkos* and *euperistatos* – νέφος, ὄγκος, εὐπερίστατος, v. 1):** We have *"such a vast cloud of witnesses surrounding us"* (*tosouton echontes perikeimenon hēmin nephos martyrōn* – τοσοῦτον ἔχοντες περικείμενον ἡμῖν νέφος μαρτύρων). The Greek word *nephos* refers to a dense, packed mass – an image used in ancient literature for a huge crowd. But notice the word for witnesses (*martyrōn* – μαρτύρων): the Old Testament heroes of faith are not merely curious spectators waiting to see whether we fall. They are *witnesses*, who testify through their own completed race that God's promises are reliable and that the finish line is worth every drop of sweat! To run the race (*agōna* – ἀγῶνα, from which we get the word "agony": a contest that demands everything) with endurance (*hypomonē* – ὑπομονή), the runner must strip off two things:

- **Every weight (*onkos* – ὄγκος):** In the ancient games athletes sometimes trained with weights, but on the day of the race they threw off every unnecessary garment and every extra pound (*onkos* can also mean "excess weight" or "bulk"). An *onkos* is not necessarily a sin; it is anything earthly – even something good or permissible in itself – that slows your spiritual pace and divides your attention.
- **The sin that so readily wraps itself around us (*euperistatos hamartia* – εὐπερίστατος ἁμαρτία):** This rare Greek adjective occurs only here in the New Testament, and its exact meaning is not certain. One popular explanation pictures a long, loose robe that wraps itself around your legs as you run and trips you up. In the context of Hebrews it is especially the sin of unbelief and little faith that keeps trying to make us stumble.

- **The fixed gaze on the pioneer and the one who brings faith to perfection (*aphorōntes*, *archēgos* and *teleiōtēs* – ἀφορῶντες, ἀρχηγός, τελειωτής, vv. 2–3):** No runner wins a race by looking at his own feet or at the crowd in the stands. The secret lies in the Greek participle *aphorōntes* ("keeping our eyes fixed"). The prefix *apo-* ("away from") means that you deliberately *turn* your eyes away from everything else in order to nail them, with undivided concentration, on a single point: **Jesus**. He is described with two masterly titles:
  - **The pioneer (*archēgos* – ἀρχηγός):** We met this word in Hebrews 2:10 (Day 5). Jesus does not just stand at the finish line with a stopwatch; he was the first to step onto the dusty track of human suffering, and he has run open for us the path of perfect trust in God.
  - **The one who brings it to perfection (*teleiōtēs* – τελειωτής):** He has brought faith to its perfect goal, and he guarantees that he will also carry over the finish line the faith he began in us. Look at how Jesus himself ran: *"For the sake of the joy that lay before him he endured the cross, despising the shame."* In the Roman world crucifixion was not only the most painful death; it was designed as the ultimate public humiliation (*aischynē* – αἰσχύνη, shame). But Jesus counted the

world's contempt as nothing, because his eyes looked beyond the cross to the joy ahead: to buy his bride free and to sit at the Father's right hand. That is why we are to consider his endurance (*analogisasthe* – ἀναλογίσασθε, v. 3): *"Consider him who endured such opposition from sinners against themselves, so that you do not grow weary and lose heart in your souls"* (*eklyomenoi* – ἐκλυόμενοι, like a bowstring going slack, or a runner collapsing after the finish line).

- **The Father's training discipline (*paideia* versus punishment – παιδεία, vv. 4–11):** In verse 4 the author reminds his readers that their trials have not yet reached the outer limit of martyrdom as Jesus' did: *"you have not yet resisted to the point of blood."* Why then does God allow his children to go through the mill of suffering and hardship? By quoting Proverbs 3:11–12, verses 5 to 11 give a radical change of perspective on hardship. The key word group, which occurs eight times in these verses, is **paideia** (with the verb *paideuō* – παιδεύω). The word comes from *pais* ("child") and refers to the whole process of **raising a child, forming character, coaching and loving discipline** – our translation renders it "discipline". There is a world of difference between a court's *punishment* (*timōria* – τιμωρία, cf. 10:29) and the Father's *discipline* (*paideia*):
  - Punishment looks *back* at the offence, in order to repay it; all our punishment has already fallen on Jesus on the cross!
  - *Paideia* looks *forward* to the child's growth, out of love! When we go through hardship, we often react with one of the two extremes that verse 5 warns against: either we "make light of it" (*oligōrei* – ὀλιγώρει: we stiffen our necks and refuse to learn what God wants to teach us through the crisis), or we "lose heart" (*eklyou* – ἐκλύου: we give up and think God hates us). The truth is exactly the opposite (vv. 6–8): a man in the street does not discipline other people's children; he shapes only his own children, for whom he has a future in mind! The fact that the Father does not let you carry on comfortably in spiritual shallowness or sin, but prunes and shapes you through

hard seasons, is the seal that you are truly his child! And what is his high purpose in it? Verses 10 and 11 answer: not to break us, but "*so that we may share in his holiness*", and so that later, for those who have been trained by it in God's gymnasium (*gegymnasmenois* – γεγυμνασμένοις), it yields "**the peaceful fruit of righteousness**"!

- **Spiritual physiotherapy for discouraged feet (*anorthōsate* and *ektrapē* – ἀνορθώσατε, ἐκτραπῇ, vv. 12–13):** The passage closes with a call (based on Isaiah 35:3 and Proverbs 4:26) that combines medical and athletic terms: "*Therefore lift up again the drooping hands and the weakened knees*" (*anorthōsate* – set back in their proper position). They are to "*make straight paths for your feet*" (*trochias orthas* – τροχιὰς ὀρθάς). Why? If a long-distance runner with an injured or sprained ankle ("what is lame" – *to chōlon*, τὸ χωλόν) keeps running on a rocky, uneven track of doubt and compromise, that joint will be completely "put out of joint" (*ektrapē*). But if the church stays together on the level, straight path of obedience to the gospel, the struggling limb will "**be healed**" (*iathē* – ἰαθῇ) as it runs!

### CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **We do not run alone.** The heroes of faith in chapter 11 are witnesses who testify, through their completed race, that God's promises are reliable.
2. **Jesus is the pioneer of faith and the one who brings it to perfection.** He ran the path of suffering first, and he carries the faith he began in us over the finish line.
3. **Discipline is not punishment.** Punishment looks back at the offence – and our punishment has already fallen on Jesus on the cross; the Father's *paideia* looks forward to the growth of his children, out of love.
4. **Hardship under the Father's hand has a purpose.** He shapes us so that we may share in his holiness and so that the peaceful fruit of righteousness ripens later.

## Living It Out

Hebrews 12:1–13 is medicine for every believer who feels today that the road has become long and steep and that their spiritual energy is running low.

First, this text asks us to **take an honest inventory of the "weights" (*onkos*) we are carrying (v. 1)**. We often ask: *Is there anything wrong with this habit, this pastime or this ambition*? But for a marathon runner the question is not only whether something is *permitted*, but whether it *helps you run faster and lighter*! You cannot win a marathon with a heavy backpack full of needless earthly worries, endless distractions or bitterness on your back. What is the Lord asking you to put down beside the track today, so that you can breathe freely again?

Second, verse 2 gives us the practice of **a spiritual shift of gaze (*aphorōntes*)**. When you feel overwhelmed by people's opposition, by injustice or by your own weakness, your natural tendency is to stare inward (until you lose heart) or to look at the people around you (until you grow bitter). Practise today deliberately turning your eyes *away* from the storm and fixing them on Jesus. Look at his cross, look at his endurance, and look at the throne where he now sits. You cannot look Jesus in the eyes and drown spiritually at the same time.

Third, verses 5 to 11 bring deep healing to the way we **interpret pain and disappointment**. When life hurts and God does not change the circumstances at once, it is not because his Father's heart has grown cold; it is because his Father's hand is busy with *paideia* – deeper forming of character. In the moment itself the pruning shears feel sharp and bring tears (verse 11 is honest about it: it seems a matter of "sorrow", not of "joy"!). But hold on to the little word "**later**" (*hysteron* – ὕστερον) in verse 11: the pain is temporary, but the harvest of peace, maturity and godly holiness that will grow from it lasts for ever.

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Weights on the racetrack (*onkos*):** Which particular "weight" – perhaps not even an open sin, but a load of worry, a constant rush or a distraction – is slowing my spiritual pace at the moment and needs to be laid down today?
- **The secret of "for the sake of the joy" (v. 2):** Jesus endured the cross by fixing his eyes on the joy on the other side. In my present sacrifices and service, do I stare only at the present cost, or do I see the eternal joy that stretches out before me?
- **Under the Father's shaping hand (*paideia*):** How have I responded recently to difficult circumstances or discipline in my life? Did I rebel against it, collapse in discouragement – or am I letting the Father train me through it, so that later it may yield *the peaceful fruit of righteousness*?

## Prayer

> *Loving Father of spirits, I come to you today with my weariness, my drooping hands and my trembling knees. Thank you that you do not leave me by the roadside when my strength runs low, but surround me with the encouraging testimony of all the believers who have already finished the race by your grace.*
>
> *Lord Jesus, pioneer of my faith and the one who brings it to perfection, today I turn my eyes away from all the distractions, the fears and the opposition of this world, and I fix my gaze on you alone. Thank you that, for the joy of saving me, you endured the bitter suffering and shame of the cross and now sit in full victory at the right hand of God. Help me today to throw off every unnecessary weight and every sin that wraps itself around me, so that I can run my leg of the race for you with endurance.*
>
> *Father, give me grace also to recognise your shaping hand in the hard seasons of my life. Where discipline and pruning hurt today, keep me from losing heart or hardening my heart. I bow under your wise, fatherly upbring-*

*ing, firmly trusting that you love me and are giving me a share in your holiness and preparing a harvest of peace and righteousness in my life. Strengthen my feet today on your straight path, and heal what is injured in my soul. Amen.*

DAY 26

# Sinai and Zion: Receiving a Kingdom That Cannot Be Shaken

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 12:14–29**

14 Pursue peace with everyone, and holiness, without which no one will
see the Lord. 15 See to it that no one falls short of the grace of God, that
no root of bitterness springs up and causes trouble, and through it many
are defiled, 16 that no one is sexually immoral or godless like Esau, who
sold his birthright for a single meal. 17 For you know that later, when he
wanted to inherit the blessing, he was rejected; for he found no place for
repentance, although he sought it with tears.

18 For you have not approached something that could be touched, and
blazing fire, and darkness and gloom and storm, 19 and the sound of a
trumpet and a voice speaking words, whose hearers begged that no fur-
ther word be spoken to them, 20 for they could not bear the command,
"Even if an animal touches the mountain, it shall be stoned." 21 And so
terrifying was the sight that Moses said, "I am full of fear and trem-
bling." 22 But you have approached Mount Zion and the city of the living
God, the heavenly Jerusalem, and myriads of angels, the festal gather-
ing 23 and assembly of the firstborn who are enrolled in the heavens, and
God, the judge of all, and the spirits of the righteous who have been
made perfect, 24 and Jesus, the mediator of a new covenant, and the
blood of sprinkling that speaks better than Abel.

25 See that you do not refuse the one who is speaking. For if they did not
escape when they refused the one who warned them on earth, much
less shall we, if we turn away from the one who warns from heaven.
26 His voice shook the earth then, but now he has promised:

Once more I will shake not only the earth
but also heaven.

27 This "Once more" shows that what is shaken will be removed, as
things that have been made, so that what is not shaken may remain.
28 Therefore, since we are receiving a kingdom that cannot be shaken,
let us be thankful, and so worship God in a way that pleases him, with
reverence and awe; 29 for our God is indeed a consuming fire.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

### HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

In yesterday's devotional (Hebrews 12:1–13) the author encouraged us to lift up our drooping hands and weakened knees and keep running on the Lord's straight path. Now, in Hebrews 12:14–29, the exhortations of the whole letter reach their great rhetorical and visual climax. Here we also find what is often counted as the **fifth and last warning passage** of the letter (verses 25–29).

The author begins with a pastoral call to watch over one another and points to the tragic example of Esau (verses 14–17). Then, in two breathtaking pictures, he sets the two covenants side by side as **two mountains**: the terrifying, unapproachable mountain **Sinai** (verses 18–21) and the joyful, accessible mountain **Zion** (verses 22–24). Finally he speaks of God's last shaking of the whole cosmos and of receiving **a kingdom that cannot be shaken** (verses 25–29).

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us dig into the riches of the Greek terms and the theological structure of this passage:

- **Peace, holiness and the danger of Esau's short-sightedness (*episkopountes* and *bebēlos* – ἐπισκοποῦντες, βέβηλος, vv. 14–17):** The author calls us actively to "pursue" two things (*diōkete* – διώκετε, like a hunter or an athlete chasing a goal with full effort): **peace** with one another (*eirēnē* – εἰρήνη) and practical **holiness** (*hagiasmos* – ἁγιασμός). *"Pursue peace with everyone, and holiness, without which no one will see the Lord."* Without holiness no one will see the Lord – not because we are saved by our own works, but because a life cleansed by the blood of Christ (10:10) is inevitably renewed by his Spirit to fit his holy presence. Further, believers are to "see to it" (*episkopountes* – related to the word "bishop" or "overseer": we are all to be one another's spiritual overseers!) and guard against three dangers within the church:

- *"that no one falls short of the grace of God"* (*hysterōn* – ὑστερῶν: falling behind on the training track and dropping out).
- that no "**root of bitterness**" (*rhiza pikrias* – ῥίζα πικρίας, a quotation from Deuteronomy 29:18 about someone whose heart turns away from the Lord and who nurses a poisonous, rebellious attitude) springs up, infects the whole community of faith and "defiles" it (*miainō* – μιαίνω).
- that no one is "godless" (*bebēlos* – βέβηλος) like **Esau**. The Greek word *bebēlos* literally means something trodden on at the threshold – someone who treats everything holy and spiritual as flat, cheap and ordinary. Esau was completely taken up with his immediate physical hunger; *"for a single meal"* – a bowl of lentil stew – he threw away his precious covenant birthright (Genesis 25:29–34). When he later wanted to receive the material blessing from Isaac (Genesis 27:34–38), he wept bitterly, but he could not undo what was done: *"he found no place for repentance"* (*metanoias topon* – μετανοίας τόπον). His tears were only regret over his loss, not true repentance towards God.

- **The first mountain: the terror and distance of Sinai (*psēlaphōmenō* – ψηλαφωμένῳ, vv. 18–21):** Why would it be so foolish for the Jewish Christians, like Esau, to give up their spiritual inheritance and return to the old Mosaic law? Because of what the old covenant looked like at Sinai (Exodus 19–20; Deuteronomy 4:11): *"For you have not approached something that could be touched"* (*psēlaphōmenō* – something physical and earthly that a person could take hold of). The Greek text does not even use the word "mountain", but verse 20 makes it clear: this is Sinai, wrapped in fire, darkness, gloom and storm. The whole atmosphere at Sinai shouted a single message: **Keep away!** Even a stray animal that crossed the boundary had to be stoned (Exodus 19:13 adds: or shot with arrows), so that no one had to touch the offender. The people begged that God would stop speaking (Exodus 20:19), and even Moses the mediator cried out: *"I am full of fear and trembling"* (*ekphobos eimi kai entro-*

*mos* – ἔκφοβός εἰμι καὶ ἔντρομος; the first words come from Deuteronomy 9:19, where Moses trembles before God's anger after the golden calf). Sinai could reveal God's spotless holiness, but it could not bring a single sinner near.

- **The second mountain: the festal fellowship of Zion (*panēgyris* and *prōtotokōn* – πανήγυρις, πρωτοτόκων, vv. 22–24):** Against that dark scene of fear, verse 22 breaks out in triumphant contrast: "**But you have approached Mount Zion**" (*proselēlythate* – προσεληλύθατε, perfect tense: you are already standing there!). By faith we already stand at the foot of the true, heavenly reality! And look at the seven wonderful realities that surround us at Zion:
  - **Mount Zion, the city of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem:** the eternal city with foundations that Abraham was looking forward to (11:10).
  - **Myriads of angels, the festal gathering (*panēgyris*):** The Greek word *panēgyris* refers to a great national festival or celebration (as at the Olympic Games, when the whole city danced and cheered). Where the angels at Sinai surrounded the awe-inspiring giving of the law (cf. 2:2), at Zion they celebrate the redemption of sinners!
  - **The assembly of the firstborn (*ekklēsia prōtotokōn* – ἐκκλησία πρωτοτόκων):** Where Esau sold his birthright (v. 16), *every single believer* in Christ counts as a "firstborn" with full rights of inheritance, *"enrolled in the heavens"* – their name permanently written in heaven's register of citizens!
  - **God, the judge of all:** At Sinai it was deadly to come near the Judge, but at Zion we may come right up to the Judge of the universe, because our Mediator has settled our case.
  - **The spirits of the righteous who have been made perfect:** all the heroes of faith in chapter 11 who, through Christ's work, have already reached their perfected state in heaven (cf. 11:40).

- **Jesus, the mediator of a new covenant:** Where Moses trembled with fear at Sinai (v. 21), Jesus stands at Zion as our fearless, loving Mediator.
- **The blood of sprinkling that speaks better than Abel:** In Genesis 4:10 the blood of the murdered Abel cried out to God from the ground for **vengeance and just punishment** on guilty Cain. But the blood of Jesus, shed on the cross, speaks of infinitely better things: from the heavenly altar it cries out for **grace, pardon and peace** for the guilty sinner!

- **The last shaking and the kingdom that cannot be shaken (*saleuō*, *basileian asaleuton* and *echōmen charin* – σαλεύω, βασιλείαν ἀσάλευτον, ἔχωμεν χάριν, vv. 25–29):** Now comes the last warning in verse 25: *"See that you do not refuse the one who is speaking"* (*paraiteomai* – παραιτέομαι: making excuses so as not to listen). The same God who spoke at Sinai speaks to us today from heaven, through the blood of his Son. The author quotes **Haggai 2:6**: at Sinai God's voice shook the earth, but he has promised: *"Once more I will shake not only the earth but also heaven"* (v. 26). Why does God shake creation (and sometimes our earthly securities too)? Verse 27 gives the answer: *"so that what is not shaken may remain"* (*ta mē saleuomena* – τὰ μὴ σαλευόμενα)! Everything that belongs to this temporary, created world – every human empire, every earthly system and every false prop – will be shaken and cleared away, so that only God's eternal creation remains. But for us as believers this does not end in panic! Look at the majestic conclusion in verses 28–29: *"Therefore, since we are receiving a kingdom that cannot be shaken, let us be thankful, and so worship God in a way that pleases him, with reverence and awe; for our God is indeed a consuming fire."* *Echōmen charin* means "let us be thankful", but it can also be read as a call to hold on to grace; and the two words for our attitude are reverence (*eulabeia* – εὐλάβεια) and awe (*deos* – δέος). The closing words come from Deuteronomy 4:24. The God of Zion is no different from the God of

Sinai; his holiness is still a consuming fire that burns up all sin and impurity. But because we are secure in Christ's unshakeable kingdom, our slavish fear is turned into deep, grateful reverence!

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **Holiness is not the ground of our salvation but its fruit.** A life cleansed by the blood of Christ is renewed by his Spirit to fit his holy presence.
2. **We already stand at Zion.** By faith we have not approached the fear and distance of Sinai, but the festal city of the living God – as firstborn whose names are enrolled in heaven.
3. **The blood of Jesus speaks better than Abel.** Where Abel's blood cried out for retribution, the blood of Jesus cries out for grace, pardon and peace.
4. **God shakes everything created so that only the unshakeable remains.** The God of Zion is the same consuming fire as the God of Sinai, but in Christ our fear becomes grateful reverence.

## Living It Out

Hebrews 12:14–29 shakes us awake from spiritual slumber and sets our feet on a Rock that can never move.

First, look at the **danger of Esau and the root of bitterness in everyday life (vv. 14–17).** A root of bitterness always starts underground and unseen – an unforgiven grievance, a disappointment with people or circumstances that we nurse in our hearts until it spreads poison through our words and attitudes into our home or church. And right beside it lies Esau's trap: the temptation to sacrifice your eternal calling and spiritual peace for a moment's "lentil stew" – a quick fleshly gratification, a compromise for financial gain or a brief escape. Do not trade your "birthright" in Christ for a bowl of passing soup!

Second, look at **the voice of Jesus' blood in your conscience (v. 24)**. Every time you stumble, your own guilty conscience and the accuser cry out like Abel's blood: *Guilty! You deserve judgement!* But at Mount Zion there is a voice that speaks louder and with greater authority in the heavenly throne room than all your failures: **the sprinkled blood of Jesus.** His blood cries out over your life today: *Paid! Redeemed! Welcome to the Father!* Listen today to the better voice of the blood of Golgotha.

Third, look at our **anchor when the world around us shakes (vv. 26–29)**. We live in a time when economies, political systems, social norms and human securities keep shaking before our eyes. When things tremble around us, we as children of the living God need not panic. Every shaking in this world only reminds us that earthly things are temporary and that we are citizens of **a kingdom that cannot be shaken** (*basileia asaleutos*). And how does a citizen of such a kingdom live? Not with shallow frivolity, nor with slavish anxiety, but with **grateful worship and holy reverence**, because our King is a consuming fire of pure love and holiness!

### QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Hidden roots and lentil stew (vv. 15–16):** Is there a hidden "root of bitterness" or unforgiveness in my heart at the moment that needs to be pulled up? And what "bowl of soup" of passing comfort sometimes tempts me to neglect my eternal priorities?
- **Sinai or Zion (vv. 18–24)?** Do I still approach God in my prayer life with the slavish fear and distance of Sinai – or do I realise that through the blood of Jesus I have already approached the festive city of Zion as a beloved "firstborn"?
- **What shakes, and what stands firm (vv. 27–28)?** Which shakeable things in my life or my surroundings are being shaken at the moment, and how does this help me anchor my heart more deeply in the kingdom that cannot be shaken, which I have received in Christ?

## Prayer

*Holy and living God, judge of all and consuming fire of spotless purity, I bow today before your throne with deep reverence and holy awe. I praise you that by the grace of your Son I need not tremble before the darkness and judgement of Mount Sinai, but have already been welcomed at the heavenly Mount Zion, the city of the living God!*

*Lord Jesus, mediator of the new covenant, thank you for your precious blood of sprinkling, which today in heaven speaks of infinitely better things than the blood of Abel. Where my sin cried out for judgement, your blood pleads today for my complete forgiveness, for peace and for my acceptance as a firstborn in your family.*

*Search my heart today by your Spirit: pull up every root of bitterness before it springs up, and keep me from the folly of Esau, who traded eternal treasures for passing pleasure. Help me to pursue peace with everyone and to grow in the holiness that glorifies you. While everything in this created world shakes and trembles around us, I thank you that in you I have received a kingdom that cannot be shaken. I choose to worship you today with a thankful heart, with reverence and awe. Amen.*

DAY 27

# Love in Practice: Contentment, Grace and Going Out to Jesus outside the Camp

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 13:1–14**

[1] Let love for one another as brothers and sisters continue. [2] Do not forget to show hospitality to strangers, for by doing so some have entertained angels without knowing it. [3] Remember those in prison as though you were in prison with them, and those who are mistreated, since you yourselves also are in the body. [4] Let marriage be held in honour by all, and the marriage bed be kept undefiled; for God will judge the sexually immoral and adulterers. [5] Let your way of life be free from the love of money; be content with what you have. For he himself has said, "I will never let you go and never abandon you." [6] So we can say with courage:

The Lord is my helper, I will not be afraid.
What can a human being do to me?

[7] Remember your leaders, who spoke the word of God to you. Consider the outcome of their way of life, and imitate their faith. [8] Jesus Christ is yesterday and today the same – and for ever. [9] Do not be carried away by all kinds of strange teachings; for it is good for the heart to be strengthened by grace, not by foods, which have not benefited those who lived by them. [10] We have an altar from which those who worship at the tent have no right to eat. [11] For the bodies of the animals whose blood is brought by the high priest into the sanctuary for sin are burned outside the camp. [12] That is why Jesus too suffered outside the gate, in order to make the people holy through his own blood. [13] So let us go out to him outside the camp, bearing his reproach. [14] For here we have no city that lasts; rather, we are seeking the one that is to come.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

### HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

At the end of chapter 12 the author declared that we are receiving **a kingdom that cannot be shaken**, and that we should therefore worship God with thankfulness, reverence and awe (12:28). Now, in Hebrews 13:1–14, he shows what that grateful worship looks like in everyday life! True worship of the King on Mount Zion does not just float in the clouds; it walks with its shoes on through our living rooms, our marriages, our wallets and our attitude to suffering.

The chapter opens with short, powerful instructions about our relationships and way of life (verses 1–6), moves on to our spiritual steadiness in the unchanging Christ (verses 7–9), and reaches a moving climax in the call to leave the safe "religious camp" behind and go out to Jesus outside the gate (verses 10–14).

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us dig into the riches of the Greek terms and the theological structure of this passage:

- **The four directions of kingdom love (*philadelphia*, *philoxenia* and *timios* – φιλαδελφία, φιλοξενία, τίμιος, vv. 1–4):** How do we worship a God who is a consuming fire? With fervent, practical love! Notice how the author unpacks the different facets of love:
  - **Love for brothers and sisters (*philadelphia*, v. 1):** "*Let love for one another as brothers and sisters continue*" (*menetō* – μενέτω). He does not ask them to *start* loving one another; they have already done so (cf. 6:10; 10:33). But under pressure their tenderness towards one another threatens to cool. It must persistently *remain*.
  - **Hospitality (*philoxenia*, v. 2):** From *philadelphia* (love for brothers and sisters) he moves to *philoxenia* (literally "love of strangers"). In the Roman world of the first century, inns were often dirty and immoral; travelling Christians and evangelists depended entirely on

believers who opened their homes. With a nod to Abraham and Sarah at the oaks of Mamre (Genesis 18), he reminds them that people have already, without knowing it, served angels at their table.

- **Compassion for those who suffer (*syndedemenoi* – συνδεδεμένοι, v. 3):** We are to remember prisoners as though we were bound together with them (*syndedemenoi*), and those who are mistreated, *"since you yourselves also are in the body"* (*en sōmati* – ἐν σώματι). As long as we live in this earthly, mortal body, we are just as vulnerable to pain as they are, and we belong to the same body of Christ.
- **Purity in marriage (*timios* and *amiantos* – τίμιος, ἀμίαντος, v. 4):** In a Graeco-Roman culture flooded with sexual licence (and perhaps also against ascetic false teachers who despised marriage), the author declares: *"Let marriage be held in honour by all, and the marriage bed be kept undefiled."* Marriage is *timios* – precious, prized like a jewel – and the marriage bed *amiantos* – the same word that 7:26 uses for the spotless purity of Jesus!

- **Free from the love of money because of the fivefold promise (*aphilargyros* and *arkeomai* – ἀφιλάργυρος, ἀρκέομαι, vv. 5–6):** Alongside sexual temptation lies the temptation of materialism and financial anxiety. Our way of life (*tropos* – τρόπος) is to be "free from the love of money" (*aphilargyros* – free from the love of silver), and we are to be "content" (*arkoumenoi* – ἀρκούμενοι, having enough) with what we have now. Where does a person find the inner rest not to chase money frantically or fear the future? Look at the little word **"for"** (*gar* – γάρ) in verse 5b! Our security lies not in *what* we have in the bank, but in *whom* we have. He himself has said: *"I will never let you go and never abandon you"* (cf. Deuteronomy 31:6; Joshua 1:5). In the Greek of verse 5b there is an astonishing construction with **five negatives in a row** (*ou mē se anō, oud' ou mē se enkatalipō* – οὐ μή σε ἀνῶ οὐδ' οὐ μή σε ἐγκαταλίπω); freely rendered: I will never, ever loosen my grip on you, and I will never,

ever, under any circumstances abandon you! That is why we can join with courage in the refrain of Psalm 118:6 (v. 6): *"The Lord is my helper, I will not be afraid."*

- **The unchanging Christ and a heart strengthened by grace (*ekbasis* and *bebaiousthai* – ἔκβασις, βεβαιοῦσθαι, vv. 7–9):** In verse 7 the author calls the church to remember its spiritual leaders who have already died. They are to look closely at the "outcome" (*ekbasis* – the way out, the successful completion) of those leaders' way of life and imitate their faith. Why can we live out today the same faith as the leaders who went before us? Verse 8 gives the rock-solid anchor of the whole letter: **"Jesus Christ is yesterday and today the same – and for ever."** Leaders die, cultures change and circumstances shift, but the person, character and high-priestly faithfulness of Jesus Christ never change. Because Jesus is unchanging, we are not to be like driftwood, *"carried away by all kinds of strange teachings"* (*didachais poikilais kai xenais* – διδαχαῖς ποικίλαις καὶ ξέναις) – probably Jewish ceremonial rules about ritual meals and food laws ("foods"). The heart is not made spiritually strong (*bebaiousthai* – anchored and stabilised) by outward ceremonies, but only **by grace (*chariti* – χάριτι)**!
- **Our altar and the call outside the camp (*exō tēs parembolēs* – ἔξω τῆς παρεμβολῆς, vv. 10–14):** In verses 10 to 14 the author takes his final leave of the Old Testament temple system. Under the Mosaic law the priests were allowed to eat the meat of certain offerings, but of the great sin offering on the **Day of Atonement** (*Yom Kippur*, Leviticus 16:27), whose blood was carried into the Most Holy Place, not even the high priest could eat a bite. The carcasses of those animals had to be taken **"outside the camp"** (*exō tēs parembolēs* – the unclean place outside Israel's camp) and burned there. Now verse 12 draws the line straight to Golgotha: *"That is why Jesus too suffered outside the gate, in order to make the people holy through his own blood."* Jesus was thrust out by the religious leaders of Jerusalem and crucified outside the city wall at Golgotha – at the place of rejection and uncleanness. He is the true

"altar" for us (v. 10 – a reference to his sacrifice on the cross, in which believers share by faith, while *"those who worship at the tent"* and cling to the old Levitical shadows have no share in it). And then the radical call of verses 13–14 rings out: **"So let us go out to him outside the camp, bearing his reproach."** For the Jewish Christians, "the camp" was the safe, respectable and socially acceptable world of official Judaism and the temple in Jerusalem. To stay inside that "camp" would mean being safe from persecution, but separated from Jesus – for Jesus is outside the gate! Why can we dare to give up earthly security and human approval? Verse 14 closes the circle back to Abraham in 11:10: "*For here we have no city that lasts; rather, we are seeking the one that is to come.*"

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **True worship becomes practical.** The grateful worship of 12:28 becomes visible in love for brothers and sisters, hospitality, compassion for those who suffer and honour for marriage.
2. **Contentment rests on a person, not on possessions.** Our security lies not in what we have, but in whom we have: the God who will never let us go and never abandon us.
3. **Jesus Christ never changes.** Leaders die and cultures shift, but he is yesterday and today the same – and for ever; that is why the heart is strengthened by grace, not by outward ceremonies.
4. **To follow Jesus is to go out to him outside the camp.** He suffered outside the gate to make us holy; we bear his reproach, because we are seeking the city that is to come.

## Living It Out

Hebrews 13:1–14 brings the lofty theology of our heavenly High Priest right down into the smallest details of our household, our finances and our spiritual identity.

First, look at the **secret of a quiet, contented heart in an uncertain world (vv. 5–6)**. We live in a culture driven by *more* – the idea that we will only be truly secure and happy when our bank account, our property or our reputation has reached a certain level. But Hebrews 13:5 shows us that the love of money and restlessness are really a crisis of faith. True contentment (*arkeomai*) does not come when your circumstances are perfect, but when you let the **fivefold "never"** of God's promise sink into your soul: he will never, ever let you go and never, ever, under any circumstances abandon you! Because Jesus is exactly the same faithful Redeemer yesterday (in all your past storms), today (in your present challenges) and for ever (in your whole future) (v. 8), you already have enough today to live in peace.

Second, look at where your **heart draws its strength from (v. 9)**. It is striking how easily we still fall for the temptation to try to strengthen our hearts with "foods" – outward rules, legalistic achievements or religious forms that make us feel that we ourselves are in control. But verse 9 says: *"it is good for the heart to be strengthened by grace"*! When your heart feels tired or unsteady, do not reach for a list of laws; drink deeply once more from the fountain of God's undeserved grace in Christ.

Third, look at the call to **go out to Jesus "outside the camp" (vv. 13–14)**. Every generation has its own "camp" – that comfortable zone of cultural acceptance, compromise or merely outward, formal religion where no one looks at you strangely and where it costs you nothing. But Jesus does not stand inside the comfortable camp of worldly approval; he suffered for us outside the gate. To truly follow him today means being willing to step out of our comfort zone, to go and stand with him and to bear his reproach – with the joyful knowledge that no earthly city is our final address!

QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **Love inside and outside my walls (vv. 1–4):** What is the practical temperature of love for brothers and sisters, hospitality, compassion for those who suffer and honour for marriage in my own home at the moment?
- **The antidote to financial worry (vv. 5–6):** Where am I currently uneasy about material things or the future? How does God's fivefold promise ("*I will never let you go and never abandon you*") change my ability to live today contented and without fear?
- **Inside the "camp" or outside with Jesus (v. 13)?** In which situation am I currently tempted to hide safely inside the "camp" of human approval and comfort, while Jesus is calling me to stand openly with him outside the gate?

## Prayer

*Faithful and unchanging God, I praise you that you have not only given me citizenship in a kingdom that cannot be shaken, but are also teaching me how to live today on earth in the light of that kingdom. Let your love be practically visible in my home and my life – in tender love for my brothers and sisters, an open door of hospitality, sincere compassion for those who suffer, and spotless honour for marriage.*

*Lord Jesus, I worship you as the one who is yesterday and today the same – and for ever! Where everything in this world changes, you stand firm. Free my heart from all love of money and anxious worry about tomorrow. Teach me the secret of true contentment, because I hold on to your own word of promise: that you will never loosen your grip on my life and never, under any circumstances, abandon me. With you as my helper I need fear no one.*

*Strengthen my heart today by your pure grace alone. And because you suffered for me outside the gate to make me holy through your own blood, give me the courage to leave behind the false safety of the world's "camp" and to*

*go out to you, even if it means bearing your reproach. My heart is not anchored in this passing earth; full of joy I long for the lasting city that is to come. Amen.*

DAY 28

# The Sacrifice of Praise and the Great Shepherd: Equipped by the God of Peace

SCRIPTURE

**Hebrews 13:15–25**

15 Through him, then, let us continually offer up a sacrifice of praise to
God, that is, the fruit of lips that confess his name. 16 Do not forget to do
good and to share, for with such sacrifices God is pleased.

17 Listen to your leaders and defer to them, for they keep watch over
your souls as people who will give account. Let them do this with joy
and not with groaning, for that would be of no benefit to you. 18 Pray for
us; for we are convinced that we have a good conscience, wanting to live
well in every respect. 19 I encourage you all the more to do this, so that I
may be restored to you sooner.

20 Now may the God of peace, who brought up from the dead the great
shepherd of the sheep by the blood of an eternal covenant, our Lord
Jesus, 21 equip you with everything good to do his will, working in us
what is pleasing in his sight, through Jesus Christ, to whom be the glory
for ever. Amen.

22 I encourage you, brothers and sisters: bear with this word of encour-
agement, for I have written to you only briefly. 23 You should know that
our brother Timothy has been released; if he comes soon, I will see you
with him. 24 Greet all your leaders and all the saints. Those from Italy
greet you. 25 Grace be with you all.

## Digging Deeper: Context and Meaning

### HISTORICAL, CULTURAL AND LITERARY BACKGROUND

With Hebrews 13:15–25 we reach the majestic destination of our journey through the whole letter to the Hebrews. In yesterday's passage (13:10–14) the author called us to leave the earthly shadow-temple behind for good and to go out to Jesus "outside the camp". Now a practical question arises: *If we no longer bring animal sacrifices to an earthly altar, what sacrifices do believers of the new covenant bring?*

The author answers this question by pointing us to the true spiritual sacrifices of thanksgiving and service (verses 15–16) and to our relationship with spiritual leaders and our prayer for one another (verses 17–19). He then closes with one of the mightiest blessings (*benedictions*) in the whole of Scripture (verses 20–21) and a last personal greeting (verses 22–25).

### INSIGHTS FROM THE GREEK

Let us dig into the riches of the Greek terms and the theological structure of these closing verses:

- **The two sacrifices of the new covenant: lips and hands (*thysia aineseōs* and *koinōnia* – θυσία αἰνέσεως, κοινωνία, vv. 15–16):** Because Jesus' once-for-all sacrifice on the cross has ended all sin offerings for ever (10:18), all that remains for the believing priesthood are **offerings of thanksgiving and praise**! Under the old covenant (Leviticus 7:12) the praise offering (*todah*) was a voluntary thank offering for God's deliverance, and a later rabbinic tradition (Leviticus Rabbah 9:7) says that in the age to come all other offerings will cease except the *todah* praise offering. The author shows that we now bring God "continually" (*dia pantos* – διὰ παντὸς: in every season, not only at the festivals in Jerusalem), through Jesus our High Priest, two inseparable sacrifices:
  - **Upward with our mouths (v. 15):** *"Through him, then, let us continually offer up a sacrifice of praise to God, that is, the fruit of lips that confess his name"* (*thysian aineseōs* – θυσίαν αἰνέσεως; *karpon cheileōn* –

καρπὸν χειλέων, an expression from Hosea 14:2 (14:3 in the Septuagint); *homologountōn* – ὁμολογούντων).

- **Outward with our hands (v. 16):** Praise with the lips without an open hand towards people in need is empty. That is why verse 16 immediately adds: *"Do not forget to do good and to share, for with such sacrifices God is pleased"* (*eupoiias* – εὐποιΐας, doing good; *koinōnias* – κοινωνίας, sharing what you have in practical and financial ways; *thysiais* – θυσίαις, sacrifices; *euaresteitai* – εὐαρεστεῖται, is pleased). Our praise of God and our generosity towards people are the true incense that fills the heavenly sanctuary!

- **Spiritual leadership, accountability and a good conscience (*agrypneō* and *stenazō* – ἀγρυπνέω, στενάζω, vv. 17–19):** In verse 7 the author spoke of leaders who had already died; in verse 17 he speaks of their present, living spiritual leaders (*hēgoumenois* – ἡγουμένοις). He calls the church to listen to them (*peithesthe* – πείθεσθε: let yourselves be persuaded by their word from Scripture) and to defer to them (*hypeikete* – ὑπείκετε: willingly give way to their leading). Why? Look at the moving picture of a shepherd's task: *"for they keep watch over your souls as people who will give account"* (*agrypnousin* – ἀγρυπνοῦσιν, literally: they stay awake, giving up their night's rest; *logon* – λόγον, account). Spiritual leadership is not a title of honour but a heavy responsibility before the judgement seat of Christ. When church members are stubborn, leaders do their work "with groaning" (*stenazontes* – στενάζοντες: with a heavy, sighing heart), and that harms the church itself spiritually – it would be *"of no benefit to you"* (*alysiteles* – ἀλυσιτελές). In verses 18–19 the author humbly asks for prayer and testifies to a "good conscience" (*kalēn syneidēsin* – καλὴν συνείδησιν) – the same cleansed conscience he wrote about in chapters 9 and 10, now visible in living well (*kalōs anastrephesthai* – καλῶς ἀναστρέφεσθαι) in every respect.

- **The great blessing: the God of peace and the great shepherd (*ho poimēn ho megas* and *katartizō* – ὁ ποιμὴν ὁ μέγας, καταρτίζω, vv. 20–21):** In verses 20 and 21 the author gathers all the great themes of the whole letter into one breathtaking closing prayer. It is the only place in the whole letter to the Hebrews that speaks explicitly of Jesus' **resurrection from the dead**!
  - **The source:** "The God of peace" (*ho theos tēs eirēnēs* – ὁ θεὸς τῆς εἰρήνης). Because the war between a holy God and sinful people was settled on the cross, we now approach him as the God of *shalom*.
  - **The mighty act:** He "**brought up from the dead the great shepherd of the sheep by the blood of an eternal covenant**" (*anagagōn* – ἀναγαγών; *ton poimena tōn probatōn ton megan* – τὸν ποιμένα τῶν προβάτων τὸν μέγαν). Here the author reaches back to **Isaiah 63:11**, which speaks of how God brought up Moses, the shepherd of his flock, out of the sea. Moses was only an earthly shepherd; Jesus is the *great shepherd* (cf. John 10:11), who went through death and was raised from the grave by the worth of his own covenant blood, to lead his flock for ever!
  - **The equipping within us (*katartizō*):** And what does the author ask this God of the resurrection to do in us? May he *"equip you with everything good to do his will"* (*katartisai* – καταρτίσαι)! The Greek verb *katartizō* (which we also met in 11:3, where the worlds were fashioned by God's word) is a rich term, used in medicine for splinting and setting a broken bone, and by fishermen for mending and preparing torn nets (Matthew 4:21). And how does he equip us? We do not have to squeeze it out of our own human strength: he does it, "**working in us what is pleasing in his sight, through Jesus Christ**" (*poiōn en hēmin* – ποιῶν ἐν ἡμῖν)! What God requires of us, he himself works in us by his Spirit!
- **A word of encouragement and the last greeting (*logos tēs paraklēseōs* – λόγος τῆς παρακλήσεως, vv. 22–25):** The author modestly calls his whole masterly letter a *"word of encouragement"* (*tou logou tēs*

*paraklēseōs* – τοῦ λόγου τῆς παρακλήσεως – the same expression that Acts 13:15 uses for a sermon in the synagogue), which he has written "only briefly" (*dia bracheōn* – διὰ βραχέων) – it takes about an hour or less to read the whole letter aloud! He shares the good news that their brother Timothy has been released (probably from prison), passes on the greetings of the believers "from Italy", and ends with the simplest and yet richest blessing imaginable: "**Grace be with you all.**"

CORE THEOLOGICAL TRUTHS

1. **The sacrifice of the cross has ended all sin offerings; now we bring praise and good deeds.** The fruit of our lips and the sharing of our hands are the sacrifices with which God is pleased.
2. **Spiritual leadership is a heavy responsibility.** Leaders keep watch over our souls as people who will give account; we listen to them and pray for them.
3. **The risen Jesus is the great shepherd.** The God of peace brought him up from the dead by the blood of an eternal covenant to lead his flock for ever.
4. **What God asks of us, he himself works in us.** He equips us with everything good and works in us what is pleasing in his sight, through Jesus Christ.

## Living It Out

At the end of our long journey of twenty-eight days through the whole letter to the Hebrews, these last verses leave us with three unforgettable life lessons for the road ahead.

First, look at **how your whole everyday life becomes a sanctuary (vv. 15–16).** Sometimes we think that "worship" only happens when we sing a song on Sunday, and that the rest of our week is "secular". But Hebrews 13:15–16 tears down that division: every time you choose, in the middle of daily pressure, not to complain but to speak through Jesus a word of

thanks or praise over his name ("the fruit of lips"), incense rises to God's throne. And every time you use your time, your knowledge or your means to do practical good and to share with others (*koinōnia*), you lay on the altar a sacrifice in which the Father takes deep pleasure!

Second, look at the **comfort of the great shepherd who rose from the dead (v. 20).** Throughout the letter we have come to know Jesus as our *great High Priest* in heaven; now, on the very last page, we also meet him as our **great shepherd** on the ground beside us! A high priest intercedes for you before God's throne; a shepherd walks with you through the deep valleys of the shadow of death, looks for you when you wander, and carries you on his shoulders when you are tired. And because the God of peace brought him up from the grave by the blood of an eternal covenant, there is no dark valley in your life where your shepherd has not already won the victory.

Third, look at the **secret of Christian service in verse 21**: may he equip you, *"working in us what is pleasing in his sight"*! Do you sometimes feel broken like a limb put out of joint (12:13), or torn like an old fishing net, when you look at the calling before you? Do not lose heart! The same God who fashioned the worlds (*katartizō*, 11:3) is the God who mends your broken places, equips you and by his Spirit himself works in you the strength and the willingness to do his will. We rest in his finished work, and we work out of his indwelling strength!

So our journey through Hebrews ends where it began: with the Son through whom God *"at the end of these days … has spoken to us"* (1:2). Keep your eyes fixed on Jesus – he is yesterday and today the same, and for ever.

#### QUESTIONS FOR PERSONAL REFLECTION

- **The sacrifices of lips and hands (vv. 15–16):** Is my daily life marked at present by a *continual sacrifice of praise* and thanksgiving on my lips, and by practical *sharing* with my hands?

- **Joy for spiritual leaders (vv. 17–18):** Do I pray faithfully for those who give spiritual guidance in my life and minister the Word – and does my attitude make it a joy for them to keep watch over my soul?
- **Equipped by the great shepherd (vv. 20–21):** Where do I feel inadequate today for the task or calling God has entrusted to me? How does it change my outlook to know that the God of peace himself is *working in me* what is pleasing in his sight, through Jesus Christ?

## Prayer

> *God of peace, at the end of this rich journey through your Word I bow before you with a heart overflowing with worship. Today, through Jesus Christ, I bring you the sacrifice of praise of my lips that confess your holy name, and I ask you to open my life and my hands to do good tirelessly and to share with those around me, for your pleasure.*
>
> *I thank you that you brought up from the dead the great shepherd of the sheep, our Lord Jesus, by the precious blood of an eternal covenant! Lord Jesus, you are not only my High Priest in heaven, but also my faithful shepherd on every step of my earthly pilgrimage. Bless and strengthen everyone you have appointed to keep watch over our souls and to minister your Word; grant that they may fulfil their service with joy and a good conscience.*
>
> *And now, God of peace, take my life into your hands: restore what is broken, and equip me fully with everything good to do your will. By your Spirit work in my inmost being what is pleasing in your sight, through Jesus Christ – to whom be all praise, honour and glory, yesterday, today and for ever! Amen.*

# The whole of Hebrews

The complete text of the letter to the Hebrews in the translation used in these devotionals.

## Chapter 1

[1] In many parts and in many ways God spoke in the past to the fathers
through the prophets; [2] at the end of these days he has spoken to us through
the Son. Him he appointed heir of everything, and through him he also made
the worlds. [3] He is the radiance of his glory and the very stamp of his being,
and he carries all things by the powerful word. When he himself had made
purification for sins, he took his seat at the right hand of the Majesty on high,
[4] and so he has become as much better than the angels as the name he has inherited is superior to theirs.

[5] For to which of the angels did he ever say:

You are my Son;
today I have fathered you?
And again:
I will be a father to him,
and he will be a son to me?

[6] And when he again brings the firstborn into the world, he says:

And let all God's angels worship him.

[7] With regard to the angels he says:

He makes his angels winds,
and his ministers a flame of fire.

[8] But with regard to the Son:

Your throne, O God, stands for ever and ever,
and the sceptre of uprightness is the sceptre of your kingdom.
[9] You have loved righteousness and hated lawlessness;
therefore God, your God, has anointed you
with the oil of rejoicing beyond your partners.

[10] And:

In the beginning, Lord, you laid the foundation of the earth,
and the heavens are the works of your hands.
[11] They will perish, but you remain;
they will all wear out like a garment,
[12] and like a cloak you will roll them up;
like a garment they will also be changed.
But you are the same,
and your years will never come to an end.

[13] But to which of the angels has he ever said:

Sit at my right hand
until I make your enemies
a footstool for your feet?

[14] Are they not all ministering spirits, sent out to serve for the sake of those who are going to inherit salvation?

## Chapter 2

[1] That is why we must pay much closer attention to what we have heard, so that we do not drift away. [2] For if the word spoken through angels proved binding, and every transgression and disobedience received a just penalty, [3] how shall we escape if we disregard a salvation this great? It began when the Lord spoke of it, and it was confirmed to us by those who heard, [4] while God added his testimony by signs and wonders and various mighty works and by distributions of the Holy Spirit according to his will.

[5] For it was not to angels that he subjected the world to come, about which we are speaking. [6] Rather, someone has testified somewhere:

What is a human being, that you remember him,
or a son of man, that you look after him?
[7] You made him a little lower than the angels;
with glory and honour you crowned him;
[8] you subjected everything under his feet.

For in subjecting everything to him, he left nothing that is not subject to
him. As it is, we do not yet see everything subjected to him.

9 But we do see the one who was made a little lower than the angels, Jesus,
crowned with glory and honour because of the suffering of death, so that by
the grace of God he might taste death for everyone.

10 For it was fitting for him, for whose sake everything exists and through
whom everything exists, in bringing many sons to glory, to make the pioneer
of their salvation perfect through sufferings. 11 For the one who makes holy
and those who are made holy are all from one. That is why he is not ashamed
to call them brothers and sisters, 12 saying:

I will declare your name to my brothers and sisters;
in the midst of the assembly I will sing your praise.

13 And again:

I will put my trust in him.
And again:
See, here am I, and the children God has given me.

14 Since, then, the children share in blood and flesh, he too in the same way
took part in the same things, so that through death he might break the power
of the one who holds sway over death, that is, the devil, 15 and set free all
those who through fear of death were held in slavery all their lives. 16 For
surely he does not take hold of angels; it is the offspring of Abraham he takes
hold of. 17 Therefore he had to be made like the brothers and sisters in every
respect, so that he might become a merciful and faithful high priest before
God, to make atonement for the sins of the people. 18 For because he himself
suffered when he was tested, he is able to help those who are being tested.

## Chapter 3

1 Therefore, holy brothers and sisters, partners in a heavenly calling, consider
closely the apostle and high priest of our confession, Jesus. 2 He is faithful to
the one who appointed him, as Moses also was in his house. 3 For he has been
counted worthy of greater glory than Moses, just as the builder of a house has
greater honour than the house itself. 4 For every house is built by someone,

but the one who built all things is God. [5] Moses was faithful in all his house as
a servant, to testify to the things that were to be spoken later, [6] but Christ as a
Son over his house. And we are his house, if we hold fast to the confidence
and the pride we take in hope.

[7] Therefore, as the Holy Spirit says:

Today, if you hear his voice,
[8] do not harden your hearts as in the rebellion,
on the day of testing in the wilderness,
[9] where your fathers tested me and put me to the proof
and saw my works
[10] for forty years.
Therefore I was indignant with this generation
and said: They always go astray in their heart;
they have not known my ways.
[11] So I swore in my anger:
They shall never enter my rest!

[12] Take care, brothers and sisters, that none of you has an evil heart full of unbelief that falls away from the living God. [13] Rather, encourage one another every day, as long as it is called "Today", so that none of you is hardened by the deceitfulness of sin. [14] For we have become partners of Christ – if indeed we hold the assurance we had at the beginning firm to the end. [15] As it is said:

Today, if you hear his voice,
do not harden your hearts as in the rebellion,

[16] who, then, were they who heard and yet rebelled? Was it not all those who came out of Egypt led by Moses? [17] And with whom was he indignant for forty years? Was it not with those who sinned, whose corpses fell in the wilderness? [18] And to whom did he swear that they would not enter his rest, if not to those who disobeyed? [19] So we see that they could not enter because of unbelief.

## Chapter 4

[1] So, since the promise of entering his rest still stands, let us fear that any of you should seem to have fallen short. [2] For we too have had the good news proclaimed to us, just as they did; but the word they heard did not benefit them, because they were not united by faith with those who truly heard. [3] For we who have believed are entering the rest, just as he has said:

So I swore in my anger:
They shall never enter my rest!
And yet the works had been finished since the foundation of the world.

[4] For somewhere he has spoken about the seventh day like this: "And God rested on the seventh day from all his works." [5] And again in this passage: "They shall never enter my rest!" [6] Since, then, it remains for some to enter it, and those who first had the good news proclaimed to them did not enter because of disobedience, [7] he again sets a certain day – "Today" – speaking through David so long afterwards, as has been said before:

Today, if you hear his voice,
do not harden your hearts.

[8] For if Joshua had given them rest, he would not have spoken afterwards of another day. [9] So then, a Sabbath rest remains for the people of God; [10] for whoever has entered his rest has also rested from his own works, as God did from his. [11] Let us therefore make every effort to enter that rest, so that no one falls by following the same example of disobedience.

[12] For the word of God is living and effective and sharper than any double-edged sword; it pierces through to the dividing of soul and spirit, of joints and marrow, and it judges the thoughts and purposes of the heart. [13] And no creature is hidden before him, but all things are naked and laid bare to the eyes of the one to whom we must give account.

[14] Since, then, we have a great high priest who has passed through the heavens, Jesus, the Son of God, let us hold fast to the confession. [15] For we do not have a high priest who is unable to sympathize with our weaknesses, but one

who has been tested in every respect in the same way – yet without sin. [16] Let us therefore approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace as help at the right time.

## Chapter 5

[1] For every high priest is taken from among human beings and appointed on behalf of human beings in what is to be done before God, to offer gifts and sacrifices for sins. [2] He is able to deal gently with those who are ignorant and going astray, since he himself is beset with weakness. [3] Because of this he must offer sacrifices for sins for himself as well as for the people. [4] And no one takes this honour for himself; he is called by God, just as Aaron was.

[5] So also Christ did not glorify himself to become high priest; it was the one who said to him:

You are my Son;
today I have fathered you,

[6] as he also says in another place:

You are a priest for ever
according to the order of Melchizedek.

[7] In the days of his flesh he offered up prayers and pleas with loud cries and tears to the one who was able to save him out of death, and he was heard because of his reverence. [8] Although he was a Son, he learned obedience through what he suffered; [9] and having been made perfect, he became the source of eternal salvation for all who obey him, [10] addressed by God as high priest according to the order of Melchizedek.

[11] About this we have much to say, and it is hard to explain, since you have become sluggish in hearing. [12] For though by this time you ought to be teachers, you again need someone to teach you the first basics of the words of God; you have become people who need milk, not solid food. [13] For everyone who still lives on milk is unacquainted with the word of righteousness, for he is an infant. [14] But solid food is for the mature, whose faculties have been trained by practice to distinguish good from evil.

## Chapter 6

[1] So let us leave behind the elementary word about Christ and be carried on to
maturity, not laying again a foundation of repentance from dead works and
of faith in God, [2] of teaching about washings and laying on of hands, about
the resurrection of the dead and eternal judgment. [3] And this we will do, if
indeed God permits.

[4] For it is impossible for those who have once been enlightened, who have
tasted the heavenly gift and have become partners of the Holy Spirit, [5] who
have tasted the goodness of the word of God and the powers of the age to
come, [6] and who have fallen away, to be renewed again to repentance – cruci-
fying the Son of God again for themselves and holding him up to contempt.
[7] For land that drinks the rain that often falls on it, and produces vegetation
useful to those for whose sake it is cultivated, receives a blessing from God.
[8] But if it bears thorns and thistles, it fails the test and is close to being cursed,
and its end is to be burned.

[9] But even though we speak like this, dear friends, we are convinced of better
things in your case, things that belong to salvation. [10] For God is not unjust;
he will not forget your work and the love you have shown for his name when
you served the saints, as you still serve them. [11] And we long for each one of
you to show the same eagerness for the full assurance of hope to the end, [12] so
that you do not become sluggish, but imitate those who through faith and pa-
tience inherit the promises.

[13] For when God made his promise to Abraham, since he had no one greater
by whom to swear, he swore by himself, [14] saying: "I will surely bless you and
surely multiply you." [15] And so, after waiting patiently, Abraham obtained the
promise. [16] For people swear by someone greater than themselves, and for
them an oath is the end of every dispute, as confirmation. [17] In the same way
God, wanting to show even more clearly to the heirs of the promise how un-
changeable his purpose was, guaranteed it with an oath, [18] so that through
two unchangeable things, in which it is impossible for God to lie, we who
have fled for refuge might have strong encouragement to hold fast to the
hope set before us. [19] We have this hope as an anchor of the soul, sure and

firm, and it enters the inner place behind the curtain, [20] where Jesus has entered as a forerunner on our behalf, having become high priest for ever according to the order of Melchizedek.

## Chapter 7

[1] For this Melchizedek, king of Salem, priest of God Most High, met Abraham as he was returning from the defeat of the kings and blessed him, [2] and Abraham gave him a tenth of everything. His name means first "king of righteousness", and then he is also king of Salem, that is, "king of peace". [3] Without father, without mother, without genealogy, having neither beginning of days nor end of life, but made like the Son of God, he remains a priest for all time.

[4] See how great he is, to whom Abraham the patriarch gave a tenth of the best of the spoils. [5] Those of the sons of Levi who receive the priestly office have a commandment in the law to collect a tenth from the people, that is, from their brothers and sisters, though these too have come from Abraham's body. [6] But this man, who does not trace his descent from them, collected a tenth from Abraham and blessed the one who had the promises. [7] Beyond all dispute, the lesser is blessed by the better. [8] Here, mortal men receive tithes; there, one of whom it is testified that he lives. [9] And one might even say that Levi himself, who receives tithes, paid a tenth through Abraham, [10] for he was still in his ancestor's body when Melchizedek met him.

[11] Now if perfection had come through the Levitical priesthood – for on the basis of it the people received the law – what further need would there have been for another priest to arise according to the order of Melchizedek, and not to be named according to the order of Aaron? [12] For when the priesthood is changed, there is of necessity a change of law as well. [13] For the one of whom these things are said belonged to another tribe, from which no one has ever served at the altar. [14] For it is clear that our Lord has arisen from Judah, and in connection with that tribe Moses said nothing about priests.

[15] And it is even more evident if another priest arises in the likeness of Melchizedek, [16] who has become a priest not according to a law of a fleshly commandment but according to the power of an indestructible life. [17] For it is testified:

You are a priest for ever
according to the order of Melchizedek.

18 For on the one hand, a former commandment is set aside because of its
weakness and uselessness 19 – for the law made nothing perfect – and on the
other hand, a better hope is brought in, through which we draw near to God.

20 And it was not without a sworn oath. For the others became priests without
a sworn oath, 21 but he with a sworn oath, through the one who said to him:

The Lord has sworn
and will not change his mind:
You are a priest for ever.

22 So much the more has Jesus become the guarantor of a better covenant.

23 The former priests were many in number, because they were prevented by
death from continuing in office; 24 but he, because he remains for ever, holds
his priesthood permanently. 25 That is why he is able to save completely those
who approach God through him, since he always lives to intercede for them.

26 For it was fitting that we should have such a high priest: holy, innocent, un-
defiled, separated from sinners, and become higher than the heavens. 27 He
has no need, like the high priests, to offer up sacrifices day after day, first for
his own sins and then for those of the people; for this he did once for all when
he offered up himself. 28 For the law appoints as high priests men who have
weakness, but the word of the sworn oath, which came after the law, ap-
points a Son, made perfect for ever.

## Chapter 8

1 The main point of what we are saying is this: we have such a high priest, who
took his seat at the right hand of the throne of the Majesty in the heavens, 2 a
minister in the sanctuary and in the true tent, which the Lord pitched, not a
human being. 3 For every high priest is appointed to offer gifts and sacrifices;
so it is necessary for this one too to have something to offer. 4 Now if he were
on earth, he would not even be a priest, since there are those who offer the
gifts according to the law. 5 They worship at a copy and shadow of the heav-
enly things, just as Moses was instructed when he was about to complete the

tent: "See," he says, "that you make everything according to the pattern that was shown you on the mountain." [6] But as it is, he has obtained a ministry that is as much superior as he is also mediator of a better covenant, which has been enacted on better promises.

[7] For if that first covenant had been faultless, no place would have been sought for a second. [8] For he finds fault with them when he says:

See, days are coming, says the Lord,
when I will bring about a new covenant
with the house of Israel and with the house of Judah,
[9] not like the covenant that I made with their fathers
on the day when I took hold of their hand
to lead them out of the land of Egypt;
for they did not remain in my covenant,
and I disregarded them, says the Lord.
[10] For this is the covenant that I will make with the house of Israel
after those days, says the Lord:
I will put my laws into their minds,
and I will write them on their hearts;
and I will be their God,
and they shall be my people.
[11] And they shall not teach, each one his fellow citizen
and each one his brother, saying: Know the Lord,
for they shall all know me,
from the least of them to the greatest.
[12] For I will be merciful toward their unrighteous deeds,
and I will remember their sins no more.

[13] By saying "new", he has made the first one old; and what is becoming old and growing aged is close to disappearing.

## Chapter 9

[1] Now even the first covenant had regulations for worship and an earthly sanctuary. [2] For a tent was set up, the first one, in which were the lampstand and the table and the loaves set out; this is called the Holy Place. [3] Behind the second curtain was a tent called the Most Holy Place. [4] It had a golden altar of

incense and the ark of the covenant, covered on all sides with gold, in which were a golden jar holding the manna, and Aaron's staff that had budded, and the tablets of the covenant. [5] Above it were the cherubim of glory, overshadowing the atonement cover. Of these things we cannot now speak in detail.

[6] With these things set up in this way, the priests go continually into the first tent to carry out their acts of worship, [7] but into the second only the high priest goes, once a year, and not without blood, which he offers for himself and for the sins the people have committed in ignorance. [8] By this the Holy Spirit makes clear that the way into the sanctuary has not yet been revealed while the first tent still has standing. [9] This is a symbol for the present time, according to which gifts and sacrifices are offered that cannot make the worshipper perfect with respect to conscience, [10] since they deal only with food and drink and various washings – regulations for the flesh, imposed until the time of setting things right.

[11] But when Christ came as high priest of the good things that have come, through the greater and more perfect tent, not made with hands, that is, not of this creation, [12] not through the blood of goats and calves but through his own blood, he entered the sanctuary once for all and obtained eternal redemption. [13] For if the blood of goats and bulls and the sprinkled ashes of a heifer make holy those who have been defiled, so that their flesh is clean, [14] how much more will the blood of Christ, who through the eternal Spirit offered himself without blemish to God, cleanse our conscience from dead works to worship the living God!

[15] And for this reason he is mediator of a new covenant, so that, since a death has taken place for redemption from the transgressions committed under the first covenant, those who are called may receive the promise of the eternal inheritance. [16] For where there is a will, the death of the one who made it must be established. [17] For a will takes effect only at death, since it is never in force while the one who made it is alive. [18] That is why not even the first covenant was inaugurated without blood. [19] For when every commandment had been spoken by Moses to all the people according to the law, he took the blood of the calves with water and scarlet wool and hyssop, and sprinkled both the book itself and all the people, [20] saying: "This is the blood of the covenant that God has commanded for you." [21] In the same way he sprinkled with the blood

the tent and all the vessels used in the ministry. [22] Indeed, according to the law almost everything is cleansed with blood, and without the shedding of blood there is no forgiveness.

[23] So it was necessary for the copies of the things in the heavens to be cleansed with these, but the heavenly things themselves with better sacrifices than these. [24] For Christ did not enter a sanctuary made with hands, a counterpart of the true one, but into heaven itself, now to appear in the presence of God on our behalf. [25] Nor did he enter to offer himself again and again, as the high priest enters the sanctuary year by year with blood that is not his own; [26] for then he would have had to suffer again and again since the foundation of the world. But as it is, he has been revealed once at the end of the ages to set aside sin by his sacrifice. [27] And just as it is in store for human beings to die once, and after that comes judgment, [28] so Christ also, having been offered once to bear the sins of many, will appear a second time, apart from sin, to those who eagerly wait for him, for salvation.

## Chapter 10

[1] For the law has only a shadow of the good things to come, not the very form of the realities. So it can never, by the same sacrifices that they offer continually year after year, make perfect those who approach. [2] Otherwise, would they not have stopped being offered? For the worshippers, once cleansed, would no longer have any sins on their conscience. [3] But in these sacrifices there is a reminder of sins year after year. [4] For it is impossible for the blood of bulls and goats to take away sins.

[5] Therefore, when he comes into the world, he says:

Sacrifice and offering you did not want,
but a body you have prepared for me;
[6] in burnt offerings and sin offerings
you took no pleasure.
[7] Then I said: See, I have come –
in the scroll of the book it is written of me –
to do your will, O God.

[8] Above he says: "Sacrifices and offerings and burnt offerings and sin offerings
you did not want, nor did you take pleasure in them" – these are offered ac-
cording to the law. [9] Then he has said: "See, I have come to do your will." He
takes away the first in order to establish the second. [10] By this will we have
been made holy through the offering of the body of Jesus Christ once for all.

[11] Every priest stands day after day ministering and offering again and again
the same sacrifices, which can never take away sins. [12] But this one offered
one sacrifice for sins for all time and took his seat at the right hand of God,
[13] and from then on he waits until his enemies are made a footstool for his
feet. [14] For by one offering he has made perfect for all time those who are
made holy. [15] And the Holy Spirit also testifies to us; for after saying:

[16] This is the covenant that I will make with them
after those days, says the Lord:
I will put my laws on their hearts,
and I will write them on their minds,
[17] and their sins and their lawless deeds
I will remember no more.

[18] Where there is forgiveness of these, there is no longer any offering for sin.

[19] So, brothers and sisters, since we have confidence to enter the sanctuary by
the blood of Jesus, [20] by the new and living way that he inaugurated for us
through the curtain, that is, his flesh, [21] and since we have a great priest over
the house of God, [22] let us approach with a true heart in full assurance of
faith, with our hearts sprinkled clean from an evil conscience and our bodies
washed with pure water. [23] Let us hold fast to the confession of hope, unwa-
vering, for the one who made the promise is faithful. [24] And let us consider
one another, so as to spur one another on to love and good works, [25] not aban-
doning our own meeting together, as is the habit of some, but encouraging
one another, and all the more as you see the Day drawing near.

[26] For if we sin deliberately after we have received the knowledge of the truth,
there no longer remains a sacrifice for sins, [27] but only a fearful expectation
of judgment and the fury of a fire that will consume the adversaries.
[28] Anyone who has set aside the law of Moses dies without pity on the testi-
mony of two or three witnesses. [29] How much worse punishment, do you

think, will be deserved by the one who has trampled on the Son of God, has regarded as unclean the blood of the covenant by which he was made holy, and has insulted the Spirit of grace? [30] For we know the one who said:

Vengeance is mine; I will repay.
And again:
The Lord will judge his people.

[31] To fall into the hands of the living God is a fearful thing.

[32] But remember the earlier days, when, after you had been enlightened, you endured a hard struggle with sufferings, [33] sometimes being made a public spectacle through reproaches and afflictions, and sometimes standing in fellowship with those who were treated in this way. [34] For you sympathized with the prisoners, and you accepted the seizure of your possessions with joy, knowing that you yourselves have a better possession, one that lasts. [35] So do not throw away your confidence, which has a great reward. [36] For you need endurance, so that when you have done the will of God you may receive the promise.

[37] For yet a very little while,
and the one who is coming will come and will not delay;
[38] but my righteous one will live by faith,
and if he draws back,
my soul takes no pleasure in him.

[39] But we are not of those who draw back to destruction, but of those who have faith to the preserving of the soul.

## Chapter 11

[1] Now faith is the assurance of what is hoped for, the proof of things that are not seen. [2] For by it the people of old were attested. [3] By faith we understand that the worlds were fashioned by God's word, so that what is seen did not come into being out of things that appear.

[4] By faith Abel offered God a greater sacrifice than Cain. Through it he was attested as righteous, God himself testifying about his gifts; and through it, though he died, he is still speaking. [5] By faith Enoch was taken up so that he

would not see death, and "he was not found, because God had taken him up". For before he was taken up, it was testified of him that he had pleased God. [6] And without faith it is impossible to please him, for whoever approaches God must believe that he exists and that he rewards those who earnestly seek him. [7] By faith Noah, when he was warned by God about things not yet seen, in reverence built an ark for the salvation of his house. Through it he condemned the world, and he became heir of the righteousness that accords with faith.

[8] By faith Abraham obeyed when he was called to go out to a place that he was to receive as an inheritance; and he went out, not knowing where he was going. [9] By faith he lived as a guest in the land of the promise as in a foreign land, living in tents with Isaac and Jacob, co-heirs of the same promise. [10] For he was waiting for the city that has the foundations, whose designer and builder is God. [11] By faith he received power to father offspring – together with Sarah herself – even when he was past the age for it, since he considered the one who had promised faithful. [12] Therefore from one man, and him as good as dead, descendants were born as many as the stars of heaven and as countless as the sand on the shore of the sea.

[13] In faith all these died without having received the promises, but they saw them from afar and greeted them, and confessed that they were strangers and temporary residents on the earth. [14] For people who speak like this make it clear that they are seeking a homeland. [15] If they had been thinking of the one they had left, they would have had opportunity to return. [16] But as it is, they long for a better one, that is, a heavenly one. Therefore God is not ashamed of them, to be called their God; for he has prepared a city for them.

[17] By faith Abraham, when he was tested, offered up Isaac. He who had received the promises was ready to offer up his only son, [18] he to whom it had been said, "Through Isaac offspring will be named for you." [19] He reckoned that God is able even to raise from the dead; hence he did receive him back – as a symbol. [20] By faith Isaac blessed Jacob and Esau, also concerning things to come. [21] By faith Jacob, when he was dying, blessed each of the sons of Joseph, and he worshipped, leaning on the top of his staff. [22] By faith Joseph, at the end of his life, mentioned the exodus of the sons of Israel and gave instructions about his bones.

[23] By faith Moses, after he was born, was hidden for three months by his parents, because they saw that the child was beautiful, and they were not afraid of the king's edict. [24] By faith Moses, when he had grown up, refused to be called the son of Pharaoh's daughter, [25] choosing rather to be mistreated along with the people of God than to have the fleeting enjoyment of sin, [26] for he considered the reproach of the Christ greater wealth than the treasures of Egypt, because he had his eyes fixed on the reward. [27] By faith he left Egypt, not fearing the fury of the king; for he held on as though he saw the one who is invisible. [28] By faith he instituted the Passover and the applying of the blood, so that the destroyer of the firstborn would not touch them. [29] By faith they crossed the Red Sea as on dry land; when the Egyptians attempted it, they were swallowed up. [30] By faith the walls of Jericho fell after they had been encircled for seven days. [31] By faith Rahab the prostitute did not perish with those who disobeyed, because she had welcomed the spies in peace.

[32] And what more shall I say? Time would fail me if I told of Gideon, Barak, Samson, Jephthah, of David and Samuel and the prophets, [33] who through faith conquered kingdoms, practised righteousness, obtained promises, shut the mouths of lions, [34] quenched the power of fire, escaped the edge of the sword, were made strong out of weakness, became mighty in war, put foreign armies to flight. [35] Women received back their dead by resurrection. Others were tortured and refused to accept release, so that they might obtain a better resurrection. [36] Still others experienced mocking and flogging, and even chains and prison. [37] They were stoned, they were sawn in two, they died by the sword; they went about in sheepskins and goatskins, in want, afflicted, mistreated – [38] the world was not worthy of them – wandering in deserts and mountains, in caves and holes in the ground.

[39] And all these, though they were attested through their faith, did not receive the promise, [40] since God had foreseen something better for us, so that they would not be made perfect apart from us.

## Chapter 12

[1] Therefore, since we too have such a vast cloud of witnesses surrounding us, let us lay aside every weight and the sin that so readily wraps itself around us, and let us run with endurance the race that lies before us, [2] with our eyes

fixed on Jesus, the pioneer of faith and the one who brings it to perfection.
For the sake of the joy that lay before him he endured the cross, despising the
shame, and he has taken his seat at the right hand of the throne of God.
3 Consider him who endured such opposition from sinners against them-
selves, so that you do not grow weary and lose heart in your souls.

4 In your struggle against sin you have not yet resisted to the point of blood,
5 and you have forgotten the encouragement that addresses you as sons:

My son, do not make light of the discipline of the Lord,
and do not lose heart when you are corrected by him;
6 for the Lord disciplines the one he loves,
and he flogs every son whom he accepts.

7 It is for discipline that you endure. God is treating you as sons. For what son
is there whom a father does not discipline? 8 But if you are without the disci-
pline that all have come to share in, then you are illegitimate and not sons.
9 Besides, we had the fathers of our flesh to discipline us, and we respected
them. Shall we not much more submit to the Father of spirits and live? 10 For
they disciplined us for a few days as seemed good to them, but he does it for
our good, so that we may share in his holiness. 11 All discipline, for the mo-
ment, seems to be a matter not of joy but of sorrow; later, however, it yields
the peaceful fruit of righteousness to those who have been trained by it.

12 Therefore lift up again the drooping hands and the weakened knees, 13 and
make straight paths for your feet, so that what is lame may not be put out of
joint but rather be healed.

14 Pursue peace with everyone, and holiness, without which no one will see
the Lord. 15 See to it that no one falls short of the grace of God, that no root of
bitterness springs up and causes trouble, and through it many are defiled,
16 that no one is sexually immoral or godless like Esau, who sold his birthright
for a single meal. 17 For you know that later, when he wanted to inherit the
blessing, he was rejected; for he found no place for repentance, although he
sought it with tears.

18 For you have not approached something that could be touched, and blazing
fire, and darkness and gloom and storm, 19 and the sound of a trumpet and a
voice speaking words, whose hearers begged that no further word be spoken

to them, [20] for they could not bear the command, "Even if an animal touches the mountain, it shall be stoned." [21] And so terrifying was the sight that Moses said, "I am full of fear and trembling." [22] But you have approached Mount Zion and the city of the living God, the heavenly Jerusalem, and myriads of angels, the festal gathering [23] and assembly of the firstborn who are enrolled in the heavens, and God, the judge of all, and the spirits of the righteous who have been made perfect, [24] and Jesus, the mediator of a new covenant, and the blood of sprinkling that speaks better than Abel.

[25] See that you do not refuse the one who is speaking. For if they did not escape when they refused the one who warned them on earth, much less shall we, if we turn away from the one who warns from heaven. [26] His voice shook the earth then, but now he has promised:

Once more I will shake not only the earth
but also heaven.

[27] This "Once more" shows that what is shaken will be removed, as things that have been made, so that what is not shaken may remain. [28] Therefore, since we are receiving a kingdom that cannot be shaken, let us be thankful, and so worship God in a way that pleases him, with reverence and awe; [29] for our God is indeed a consuming fire.

## Chapter 13

[1] Let love for one another as brothers and sisters continue. [2] Do not forget to show hospitality to strangers, for by doing so some have entertained angels without knowing it. [3] Remember those in prison as though you were in prison with them, and those who are mistreated, since you yourselves also are in the body. [4] Let marriage be held in honour by all, and the marriage bed be kept undefiled; for God will judge the sexually immoral and adulterers. [5] Let your way of life be free from the love of money; be content with what you have. For he himself has said, "I will never let you go and never abandon you." [6] So we can say with courage:

The Lord is my helper, I will not be afraid.
What can a human being do to me?

[7] Remember your leaders, who spoke the word of God to you. Consider the outcome of their way of life, and imitate their faith. [8] Jesus Christ is yesterday and today the same – and for ever. [9] Do not be carried away by all kinds of strange teachings; for it is good for the heart to be strengthened by grace, not by foods, which have not benefited those who lived by them. [10] We have an altar from which those who worship at the tent have no right to eat. [11] For the bodies of the animals whose blood is brought by the high priest into the sanctuary for sin are burned outside the camp. [12] That is why Jesus too suffered outside the gate, in order to make the people holy through his own blood. [13] So let us go out to him outside the camp, bearing his reproach. [14] For here we have no city that lasts; rather, we are seeking the one that is to come. [15] Through him, then, let us continually offer up a sacrifice of praise to God, that is, the fruit of lips that confess his name. [16] Do not forget to do good and to share, for with such sacrifices God is pleased.

[17] Listen to your leaders and defer to them, for they keep watch over your souls as people who will give account. Let them do this with joy and not with groaning, for that would be of no benefit to you. [18] Pray for us; for we are convinced that we have a good conscience, wanting to live well in every respect. [19] I encourage you all the more to do this, so that I may be restored to you sooner.

[20] Now may the God of peace, who brought up from the dead the great shepherd of the sheep by the blood of an eternal covenant, our Lord Jesus, [21] equip you with everything good to do his will, working in us what is pleasing in his sight, through Jesus Christ, to whom be the glory for ever. Amen.

[22] I encourage you, brothers and sisters: bear with this word of encouragement, for I have written to you only briefly. [23] You should know that our brother Timothy has been released; if he comes soon, I will see you with him. [24] Greet all your leaders and all the saints. Those from Italy greet you. [25] Grace be with you all.